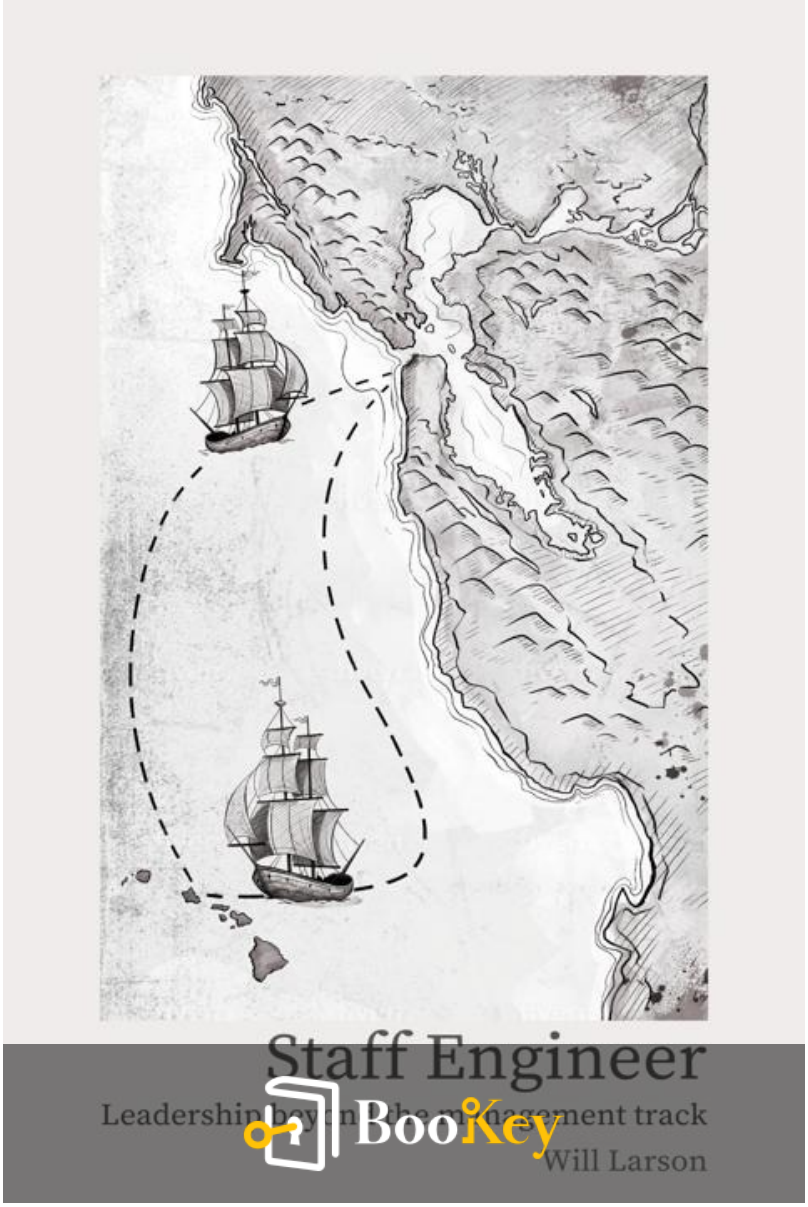
Staff Engineer PDF

Will Larson



More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Staff Engineer

Mastering Technical Excellence Without Transitioning to Management.

Written by Bookey

Check more about Staff Engineer Summary

Listen Staff Engineer Audiobook

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

About the book

In the fast-evolving landscape of technology careers, achieving the title of Senior Software Engineer typically takes five to eight years, after which professionals face a crucial decision: pursue technical excellence as a Staff Engineer or take a path toward engineering management. While numerous resources exist to guide aspiring managers, the transition to Staff Engineer—alongside advanced roles like Principal and Distinguished Engineer—remains largely uncharted. "Staff Engineer: Leadership Beyond the Management Track" offers a practical exploration of this journey, addressing essential questions about the skills needed for success, the role of technical expertise, and the impact of managerial support. This book serves as a vital roadmap for those seeking to navigate the challenges of advancing in a technical career and thriving in Staff-plus positions.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

About the author

Will Larson is a seasoned engineering leader and advocate for the growth and development of technical talent in the software industry. With over a decade of experience in various roles at top companies, including Uber and Stripe, Larson has cultivated a deep understanding of the challenges faced by engineers and the importance of effective mentorship and career progression. In "Staff Engineer," he shares his insights and experiences, providing practical guidance for engineers aspiring to elevate their careers beyond traditional paths. Larson's passion for fostering technical excellence and his commitment to empowering others makes his work a valuable resource for professionals navigating the complexities of engineering leadership and personal development.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Try Bookey App to read 1000+ summary of world best books

Unlock 1000+ Titles, 80+ Topics

New titles added every week

Brand | Leadership & Collaboration | Time Management | Relationship & Communication

ness Strategy | Creativity | Public | Money & Investing | Know Yourself | Positive P

Entrepreneurship | World History | Parent-Child Communication | Self-care | Mind & Spi

Insights of world best books

Free Trial with Bookey

Summary Content List

Chapter 1 : Acknowledgments

Chapter 2 : Foreword

Chapter 3 : Preface

Chapter 4 : Staff engineer archetypes

Chapter 5 : What do Staff engineers actually do?

Chapter 6 : Does the title even matter?

Chapter 7 : Work on what matters

Chapter 8 : Writing engineering strategy

Chapter 9 : Managing technical quality

Chapter 10 : Stay aligned with authority

Chapter 11 : To lead, you have to follow

Chapter 12 : Learn to never be wrong

Chapter 13 : Create space for others

Chapter 14 : Build a network of peers

Chapter 15 : Present to executives

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Chapter 16 : Promotion packets

Chapter 17 : Find your sponsor

Chapter 18 : Staff projects

Chapter 19 : Get in the room, and stay there

Chapter 20 : Being visible

Chapter 21 : Finding the right company

Chapter 22 : Interviewing for Staff-plus roles

Chapter 23 : Negotiating your offer

Chapter 24 : Michelle Bu - Payments Products Tech Lead at Stripe

Chapter 25 : Ras Kasa Williams - Staff Engineer at Mailchimp

Chapter 26 : Keavy McMinn - Senior Principal Engineer at Fastly

Chapter 27 : Bert Fan - Senior Staff Engineer at Slack

Chapter 28 : Katie Sylor-Miller - Frontend Architect at Etsy

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Chapter 29 : Ritu Vincent - Staff Engineer at Dropbox

Chapter 30 : Rick Boone - Strategic Advisor to Uber’s VP of Infrastructure

Chapter 31 : Nelson Elhage - Formerly Staff Engineer at Stripe

Chapter 32 : Diana Pojar - Staff Data Engineer at Slack

Chapter 33 : Dan Na - Staff Engineer and Team Lead at Squarespace

Chapter 34 : Joy Ebertz - Senior Staff Software Engineer at Split

Chapter 35 : Damian Schenkelman - Principal Engineer at Auth0

Chapter 36 : Dmitry Petrashko - Tech Advisor to the Head of Infra at Stripe

Chapter 37 : Stephen Wan - Staff Engineer at Samsara

Chapter 38 : Additional resources on Staff-plus engineering

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Chapter 39 : Where do Staff-plus engineers fit into the org?

Chapter 40 : Managing Staff-plus engineers

Chapter 41 : Designing a Staff-plus interview loop

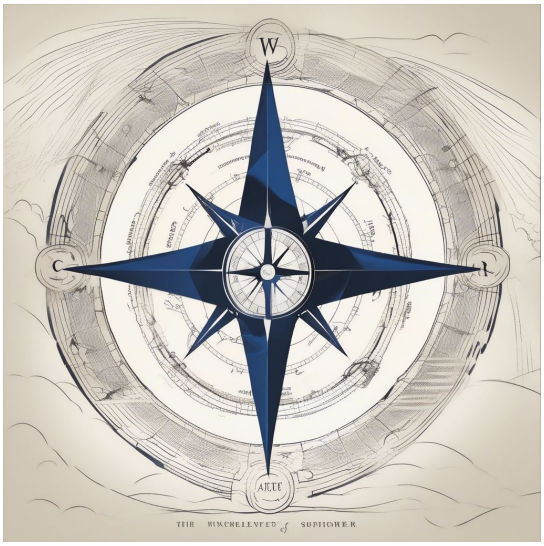
Chapter 42 : Staff-plus career ladders

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Chapter 1 Summary : Acknowledgments



Acknowledgments

This book, "Staff Engineer," was made possible through the collective efforts of many individuals, particularly during the tumultuous year of 2020. The author expresses deep gratitude to those who shared their stories, including Michelle, Kasa, Keavy, and others. Special thanks are also extended to contributors from staffeng.com and to Tanya Reilly for her remarkable foreword. The book's cover design by Luciana Guerra draws inspiration from historical nautical maps, symbolizing the uncertain nature of the Staff engineer role. Acknowledgment is also given to the TechWriters Discord community for their invaluable support and feedback, especially to Gergely, Shawn, and Uma. Laurel's line-editing

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

efforts significantly enhanced the book's consistency and quality. Thanks are further extended to reviewers and contributors who helped shape this work.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 2 Summary : Foreword

Acknowledgments

This chapter expresses gratitude to various individuals and communities who contributed to the writing of the book during the challenging year of 2020. Special thanks are given to those who shared their stories, participated in the editing process, and offered support in various capacities. The author appreciates the unique voices of contributors both within and outside the book and looks forward to more comprehensive resources on staff engineering.

Foreword

Tanya Reilly reflects on the challenges faced by engineers

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

pursuing technical leadership roles, highlighting the limitations of available resources for senior engineers compared to management literature. She discusses the necessity for engineers to find their place in organizations, navigate undefined roles, and define their impact. The introduction of the term “staff-plus” aims to encapsulate these roles and provide clarity within the tech industry. Reilly commends Will Larson's efforts in establishing staffeng.com as a vital resource for understanding and developing in staff engineering roles. The chapter emphasizes the urgent need for practical advice and community support for engineers at various stages in their careers and advocates for ongoing resources to guide them as they navigate their paths in a rapidly evolving field.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 3 Summary : Preface

Foreword

Tanya Reilly expresses her experience with Will Larson's previous book, "An Elegant Puzzle," highlighting its focus on managerial perspectives, which can be alienating for principal engineers. Reilly emphasizes the need for resources tailored for senior engineers who play critical roles in driving technical strategy and leadership within organizations. As engineers advance in their careers, they often feel unsupported and unclear about their roles, especially when transitioning into “staff-plus” roles. Reilly discusses the launch of staffeng.com as a significant milestone for defining these roles and providing guidance on what constitutes effective technical leadership. She appreciates that this book, "Staff Engineer," directly addresses the needs of staff-plus

Install Bookey App to Unlock Full Text and Audio

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Why Bookey is must have App for Book Lovers

30min Content
The deeper and clearer interpretation we provide, the better grasp of each title you have.

Text and Audio format
Absorb knowledge even in fragmented time.

Quiz
Check whether you have mastered what you just learned.

And more
Multiple Voices & fonts, Mind Map, Quotes, IdeaClips...

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 4 Summary : Staff engineer archetypes

Section	Summary
Overview	Software engineers typically achieve Senior level in 5-8 years but face limited options for further advancement into management. Companies offer dual-track systems for those wanting to progress without management roles, leading to positions like Staff Engineer and Principal Engineer. The book provides guidance on how to navigate these technical leadership roles.
Staff Engineer Archetypes	The author identifies four archetypes among Staff-plus engineers: Tech Lead: Guides team execution and supports managerial tasks, often using agile methodologies. Architect: Oversees domain quality and direction, emerging in larger or complex organizations. Solver: Addresses critical problems independently, focusing on urgent issues rather than ongoing team collaboration. Right Hand: Works alongside senior leaders to solve important problems without direct management responsibilities.
Choosing the Right Archetype	Individuals should assess their strengths and align with the appropriate archetype. Tech Lead is often the most accessible role, with Architect and Right Hand evolving as organizations grow. Personal preference and alignment with company goals are essential for career satisfaction and success.

Overview

In most technology companies, software engineers typically reach the Senior level within five to eight years. At this career stage, advancement to higher management roles is uncommon. Engineers may also explore engineering management paths, with various resources available to assist in navigating these roles. For those seeking career advancement without management responsibilities, companies often offer a dual-track system: engineering

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

management and technical leadership, the latter comprising roles like Staff Engineer and Principal Engineer. This book aims to clarify the expectations and journey toward these technical leadership roles, informed by the experiences of many successful Staff-plus engineers.

Staff Engineer Archetypes

Career ladders often create a standardized set of expectations for Staff Engineers, but these can obscure the variety of roles encompassed within the title. The author identifies four common archetypes among Staff-plus engineers:

1.

Tech Lead

Tech Leads guide team execution and partner closely with managers. They manage tasks, promote team cross-functionality, and often transition from Senior Engineer roles due to their strong alignment with agile methodologies.

2.

Architect

Architects oversee the quality and direction of critical domains within a company, leveraging their understanding of

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

the business and technical constraints. Their roles typically emerge in larger organizations or those with complex codebases.

3.

Solver

Solvers tackle particularly challenging problems deemed critical by leadership. While they work independently, they often encounter team dynamics that can be transient, focusing on resolving acute issues rather than ongoing team effort.

4.

Right Hand

The least common archetype, the Right Hand operates alongside senior organizational leaders, handling crucial problems without direct managerial duties while supporting leadership objectives.

Choosing the Right Archetype

Individuals are encouraged to reflect on their energy sources and consider which archetype aligns best with their skills and the needs of their organization. The Tech Lead role is often

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

the most accessible, while Architect and Right Hand roles may develop as companies scale. Ultimately, aligning one's career path with personal preferences and organizational goals is crucial for long-term satisfaction and success in these roles.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Example

Key Point:Choosing the right archetype influences your career path as a technical leader.

Example:Imagine you're reflecting on your daily tasks and discover that you thrive on creating innovative solutions while collaborating with a team. As you progress through your career, you recognize that the Solver archetype resonates with you more than the management-heavy paths others are exploring. This realization empowers you to seek out complex challenges within your organization, ensuring that your contributions align with your strengths and passions, ultimately leading to job satisfaction and career advancement.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Critical Thinking

Key Point:Career Clarity and Diversity in Engineering Roles

Critical Interpretation:The author's framework of archetypes for Staff Engineers highlights the varied paths within technical leadership yet may oversimplify the complexities of career progression in tech. While Will Larson categorizes these roles effectively, it's essential to recognize that individual experiences can differ significantly depending on company culture, personal ambitions, and evolving industry demands. Not all engineers will fit neatly into these archetypes, and many may find themselves navigating hybrid roles that challenge the clear-cut definitions presented. Critical perspectives from sources such as "The Manager's Path" by Camille Fournier suggest that the variance in paths can lead to disillusionment if one subscribes too rigidly to such categorizations. Thus, while Larson's insights provide valuable guidance, it's important for engineers to remain adaptable and open to defining their unique professional journeys.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 5 Summary : What do Staff engineers actually do?

Section	Content
Introduction to Staff Engineer Archetypes	Staff engineers have distinct expectations tailored to their roles, highlighting four archetypes through discussions.
Common Staff Engineer Archetypes	Tech Lead: Guides team execution, collaborates with managers, and leads product roadmap changes. Architect: Ensures quality and direction in critical areas, merging technical and organizational leadership. Solver: Focuses on complex problems independently, tackling critical issues designated by leadership. Right Hand: Acts as a senior leader's support, addressing high-impact problems without direct managerial roles.
Choosing Your Archetype	Select the archetype that excites you and fits your organizational context, with the Tech Lead often being the most accessible option.
Key Roles and Responsibilities	Engage in strategic projects, set technical direction, mentor others, and ensure team alignment with organizational goals.
Setting Technical Direction	Align technical vision with the needs of the organization rather than personal interests.
Mentorship and Sponsorship	Prioritize the growth of engineers over personal achievements by fostering a supportive culture.
Exploration and Problem Solving	Trusted with tackling ambiguous challenges, which are rewarding yet risky.
Conclusion	Becoming a Staff engineer requires understanding archetypes, aligning strengths, and embracing challenges for impactful growth.

Staff Engineer Archetypes

Introduction to Staff Engineer Archetypes

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Most career ladders provide a uniform set of expectations for Staff engineers, which suits populations better than individual roles, particularly for Staff-plus engineers. Conversations regarding the role revealed four distinct archetypes.

Common Staff Engineer Archetypes

1.
Tech Lead

- Guides a team's approach and execution.
- Partners with one or multiple managers.
- Often the first point of contact for product roadmap changes.

2.
Architect

- Responsible for the direction and quality within a critical area.
- Combines technical and organizational leadership.
- Advocates for approaches within their domain, which is often complex and central to the organization.

3.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Solver

- Delves deeply into complex organizational problems.
- Identified and assigned to critical issues by leadership.
- Often operates independently, focusing on identified priorities rather than team dynamics.

4.

Right Hand

- Functions as a senior leader's extension without direct managerial duties.
- Works across various business and technical issues, prioritizing high-impact problems.
- Requires alignment with the executive’s vision and objectives.

Choosing Your Archetype

Identifying the right archetype involves reflecting on what kind of work excites you and considering available roles within your organization. The Tech Lead is often the most accessible role; others, like the Solver, may emerge depending on a company’s emphasis on individual versus team ownership.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Key Roles and Responsibilities

- Staff engineers always engage in strategic projects contributing to the organization's goals.
- Responsibilities include setting technical directions, mentoring, and ensuring team alignment with broader company objectives.
- While coding may take a backseat, maintaining technical involvement remains essential for informed decisions.

Setting Technical Direction

Effective Staff engineers align technical vision with organizational needs rather than personal interests, facilitating necessary changes across teams.

Mentorship and Sponsorship

Growth of engineers around you is prioritized over personal achievement. Incorporating mentorship effectively creates a culture of support and guidance within the tech team.

Exploration and Problem Solving

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Staff engineers are typically trusted with exploratory roles, allowing them to tackle ambiguous yet critical challenges impacting the organization. This work is rewarding but also carries significant risk.

Conclusion

The journey to becoming a Staff engineer involves understanding each archetype's nuances, aligning with your strengths, and embracing the long-timeframes inherent in these roles. Despite challenges such as reduced coding time, the transition often leads to fulfilling responsibilities that leave a lasting impact on both the organization and personal growth.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Example

Key Point:Choosing Your Archetype is Crucial for Your Career Path

Example:Reflect on your interests and strengths to effectively select one of the four archetypes that align with your career aspirations.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Critical Thinking

Key Point:Critique of the Staff Engineer Archetypes

Critical Interpretation:While Will Larson presents a structured view of Staff Engineer archetypes encompassing roles like Tech Lead, Architect, Solver, and Right Hand, one must critically engage with the assumption that these categories are universally applicable. They seem to offer a somewhat rigid framework that could obscure the nuanced, often hybrid nature of roles that professionals might occupy depending on their organization's culture and dynamics. The archetypes suggest clarity in role definition, yet this might inadvertently promote pigeonholing, limiting individual expression and growth within unique contexts. Moreover, perceptions of effectiveness can vary greatly across different organizations and industry standards; thus, both organizations and engineers must remain fluid rather than reliant on fixed archetypes. The literature on organizational behavior, such as

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 6 Summary : Does the title even matter?

Section	Summary
Understanding the Role of Staff Engineers	Explores the specific responsibilities and expectations of Staff engineers in technology teams.
Role Variability and Responsibilities	Responsibilities depend on team needs and individual strengths, focusing on strategic projects, technical design, and team performance.
Distinction from Senior Engineers	Staff engineers prioritize strategic thinking and mentorship over direct coding, unlike Senior engineers who may focus more on execution.
Core Activities of Staff Engineers	Include setting technical direction, advocating for technology, mentoring others, and providing technical insights in high-level discussions.
Exploration and Problem Solving	Engage in addressing ambiguous problems and innovating solutions while managing immediate organizational challenges.
The 'Glue' Role	Perform supportive yet unglamorous tasks that enhance team cohesion and project success.
Coding Responsibilities	Continue to write code, but less frequently; focus on maintaining technical relevance and supporting the team.
Challenges and Rewards	Role transition may involve longer timelines for impact, but fosters personal growth and broader influence.
Advantages of Holding a Staff Title	Includes reducing bias about competence, gaining access to influential discussions, and typically higher compensation.
Navigating the Staff Engineer Path	Consider alignment with personal career goals as the role comes with higher expectations and responsibilities.
Conclusion: Titles vs. Skills	Achieving a Staff title does not equate to new skills; focus should be on contributions and alignment with strategic goals, rather than just title aspiration.

Understanding the Role of Staff Engineers

Role Variability and Responsibilities

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

The responsibilities of Staff-plus engineers greatly depend on the team's needs and the individual's strengths. Their main focus is typically on projects of strategic value while enhancing technical design and elevating team performance.

Distinction from Senior Engineers

While Staff engineers perform similar tasks to Senior engineers—such as building relationships and writing software—their role shifts as technical tasks turn auxiliary, prioritizing strategic thinking and mentorship over direct coding.

Core Activities of Staff Engineers

-

Setting Technical Direction

: Facilitating a clear technical vision for teams and aiding in

Install Bookey App to Unlock Full Text and Audio

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

App Store
Editors' Choice

22k 5 star review

Positive feedback

Sara Scholz

tes after each book summary
erstanding but also make the
and engaging. Bookey has
ding for me.

Fantastic!!!

Masood El Toure

I'm amazed by the variety of books and languages Bookey supports. It's not just an app, it's a gateway to global knowledge. Plus, earning points for charity is a big plus!

Fi
Ab
bo
to
my

José Botín

ding habit
p's design
ual growth

Love it!

Wonnie Tappkx

Bookey offers me time to go through the important parts of a book. It also gives me enough idea whether or not I should purchase the whole book version or not! It is easy to use!

Time saver!

Bookey is my go-to app for
summaries are concise, ins
curated. It's like having acc
right at my fingertips!

Awesome app!

Rahul Malviya

I love audiobooks but don't always have time to listen to the entire book! bookey allows me to get a summary of the highlights of the book I'm interested in!!! What a great concept !!!highly recommended!

Beautiful App

Alex Walk

This app is a lifesaver for book lovers with busy schedules. The summaries are spot on, and the mind maps help reinforce wh I've learned. Highly recommend!

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 7 Summary : Work on what matters

Section	Key Points
Introduction to Staff Engineer Role	Role requires a focus shift to mentorship and strategic work, slow feedback cycles can be demoralizing.
Key Topics for Personal Development	Work on What Matters: Prioritize impactful tasks. Write an Engineering Strategy: Advocate for alignment with business goals. Curate Technical Quality: Maintain software quality amid growth. Stay Aligned with Authority: Work closely with leadership for effectiveness. Collaborate and Communicate: Foster understanding over being 'right.' Create Space for Others: Empower and support team growth.
Overcoming Learning Curves	Adapt to mentorship and sponsorship roles; be the team "glue."
Energized Work vs. Impactful Work	Balance personal energizing work and company-focused impactful work for sustainability.
Common Pitfalls	Avoid Snacking: Focus on high-impact projects instead of low-value tasks. Stop Preening: Differentiate visibility from true impact. Stop Chasing Ghosts: Avoid outdated strategies not relevant to current context.
Focusing on What Matters	Identify and address existential risks within the company.
Fostering Team Growth	Invest in onboarding and mentoring to enhance team velocity.
Editing and Finishing Projects	Encourage project completion through small adjustments for substantial results.
Unique Contributions	Focus on tasks that leverage your unique skills for the greatest impact.
Long-term Career Considerations	Value reputation and expertise over project contributions, focus on skill development.

Operating at Staff

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Introduction to Staff Engineer Role

A common misconception about becoming a Staff engineer is that it grants control and authority over work. In reality, the role often demands a shift in focus and responsibilities, including mentorship, relationship building, and strategic work, with a slower feedback cycle that may be demoralizing.

Key Topics for Personal Development

In interviews and personal experiences, several key themes became evident for staff engineers:

-
Work on What Matters:
Prioritize impactful work as your responsibilities evolve and time becomes scarce.

-
Write an Engineering Strategy:
Advocate for architecture and technology that supports business objectives.

-
Curate Technical Quality:
Maintain the organization's software quality as it grows.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

-

Stay Aligned with Authority:

Align with leadership for continued effectiveness as a leader.

-

Collaborate and Communicate:

Shift focus from being 'right' to fostering understanding and collaboration.

-

Create Space for Others:

Empower your team to grow, enhancing organizational strength.

Overcoming Learning Curves

The adjustment to a Staff engineer role involves overcoming early challenges and learning to embrace mentorship, sponsorship, and how to effectively be the "glue" within teams.

Energized Work vs. Impactful Work

Consider work that energizes you personally instead of just focusing on company-centric impactful work. Balance work commitments with personal life to sustain long-term

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

effectiveness.

Common Pitfalls

1.
Avoid Snacking:
Prioritize high-impact projects over low-effort tasks that provide little learning or growth.
2.
Stop Preening:
Distinguish between high-visibility, low-impact work and genuinely impactful contributions.
3.
Stop Chasing Ghosts:
Avoid pursuing outdated strategies based on previous experiences without understanding the current company context.

Focusing on What Matters

Identify existential risks within the company and dedicate efforts to address them. Engage in work that is undervalued but essential, such as inclusion and tooling efforts.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Fostering Team Growth

Investing in onboarding, mentoring, and coaching can greatly enhance team velocity and is often neglected compared to hiring.

Editing and Finishing Projects

Small adjustments and encouraging other engineers to complete projects can lead to substantial results. Prioritizing project completion can shift risks to leverage.

Unique Contributions

Identify work that only you can accomplish, leveraging your unique skills and passions—this is where the most significant impact can be made.

Long-term Career Considerations

In the long run, subjective measures like reputation and accumulated expertise matter more than individual project contributions. Focus on valuable work that develops your skills and aligns with personal and organizational values.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Example

Key Point:Work on What Matters: Prioritize impactful work as your responsibilities evolve and time becomes scarce.

Example:As you transition into a Staff engineer role, imagine standing in front of a whiteboard filled with ideas. You're tasked with choosing only a few to embark on, knowing that your time and energy are limited. Perhaps you're drawn to a project that excites you but lacks broader significance. Instead, you vividly realize that tackling a complex architecture issue, which has been a critical bottleneck for the entire team, not only aligns with your growth but also enhances workflow across the organization. This conscious decision to prioritize high-impact work over smaller tasks not only demonstrates your commitment to the company's success but catapults your career by establishing your reputation as a thoughtful leader focused on meaningful contributions.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 8 Summary : Writing engineering strategy

Work on What Matters

Introduction to Energized Work

The concept of "energized" work is preferrable to "impactful," implying a focus on personally fulfilling and motivating activities rather than merely those deemed essential by the company. As professionals advance in their careers, the challenge becomes balancing personal satisfaction with growing expectations.

Common Pitfalls in Work Prioritization

1.
Avoid Snacking
: Engaging in low-effort tasks that provide a quick sense of accomplishment can detract from high-impact work. It's essential to balance snacks with meaningful efforts.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

2.

Stop Preening

: Performing visible but low-value work can lead to misalignment between recognition and actual impact, hindering personal growth and credibility.

3.

Stop Chasing Ghosts

: New leaders may pursue significant changes based on misjudgments from previous experiences. Prioritizing understanding the current context before driving change is crucial.

Finding Work That Matters

-

Existential Issues

: Focus on tasks that address dire risks to the company's survival, such as financial troubles or operational stability.

-

Work Where There’s Room

: Seek out projects that matter to the company yet are undervalued or overlooked for their potential.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

-

Foster Growth

: Invest time in mentoring and developing team members to create lasting impact beyond individual contributions.

Editing and Finishing Work

- Small changes or coaching can significantly shift a project's outcome. Getting projects across the finish line maximizes effort and becomes essential for leverage.

Unique Contributions

Identify work that you are uniquely positioned to accomplish—projects that will not proceed without your involvement. This type of work is critical for both personal fulfillment and professional growth.

Long-term Career Strategy

Accumulate valuable experiences and expertise through impactful work, steering toward companies that appreciate this value. Your accumulated skills and context will define

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

your career trajectory more than subjective measures like titles or prestige.

Writing Engineering Strategies

1.
When and Why
: Proactively create strategies when discussions stall or when forward-looking investments need direction.

2.
Design Documents
: Craft detailed design documents to ground strategies in reality and provide practical steps.

3.
Synthesize into Strategies
: Review multiple design documents to identify key themes and contradictions, crafting a coherent strategy.

Crafting an Engineering Vision

1.
Time Frame

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

: Focus on a two- to three-year vision that balances ambition with feasibility.

2.
Ground in Business Value
: Ensure the vision serves user needs and aligns with business goals.

3.
Specificity and Conciseness
: Keep the vision clear and concise, ideally one to two pages long, to ensure reader engagement.

Conclusion

When sharing your vision, be prepared for muted responses, and instead gauge its success through long-term improvements in project documentation. Continuous alignment with both immediate and strategic goals is essential for sustaining impact in an evolving career landscape.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Example

Key Point:Prioritize your fulfillment over immediate company demands when selecting projects to undertake.

Example:Imagine working on a project that truly excites you, igniting your passion and creativity, rather than just completing tasks for the sake of appearances. By consciously choosing to engage in work that resonates with your personal motivations, you not only enhance your own job satisfaction but also produce more significant contributions to your team and company, ultimately steering your career towards fulfilling opportunities.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Chapter 9 Summary : Managing technical quality

Writing Engineering Strategy

Challenges of Strategy Writing

Writing about engineering strategy can be daunting due to its perceived complexity and the common association with innovation. However, good engineering strategy is often straightforward and may even seem boring. Writing an effective strategy is easier than writing a poor one.

Creating an Engineering Strategy

To create an effective engineering strategy, analyze multiple design documents to identify commonalities, which will serve as the foundation of the strategy. For an engineering vision, extrapolate potential implications from several strategies. Prioritize clarity and practicality in your writing, believing that effective strategies emerge from iterative

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

learning rather than abstract concepts.

When and Why to Create Strategies

Strategies are essential tools for proactive alignment, enabling teams to make swift decisions and reducing repetitive discussions. Recognize when discussions become stagnant or when direction is unclear, signaling the need to document a strategy or vision.

Steps to Writing Effective Strategies

1.
Write Five Design Documents:

Create detailed design documents that outline specific problems and solutions. Templates can help structure these documents, but they should remain focused and avoid

Install Bookey App to Unlock Full Text and Audio

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Read, Share, Empower

Finish Your Reading Challenge, Donate Books to African Children.

The Concept

BOOKS FOR AFRICA × ×

This book donation activity is rolling out together with Books For Africa. We release this project because we share the same belief as BFA: For many children in Africa, the gift of books truly is a gift of hope.

The Rule

Earn 100 points → **Redeem a book** → **Donate to Africa**

Your learning not only brings knowledge but also allows you to earn points for charitable causes! For every 100 points you earn, a book will be donated to Africa.

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 10 Summary : Stay aligned with authority

Topic	Summary
Understanding the Crisis of Technical Quality	Technical quality issues are often misattributed to personnel instead of organizational decisions; low quality is often a norm influenced by evolving standards.
The Leadership Challenge	Engineering leaders must balance technical quality with business objectives, adapting their approach as quality standards shift.
Hot Spots and Immediate Solutions	Address immediate quality issues by identifying "hot spots" rather than rushing to implement new processes; understanding context is crucial.
Best Practices and Organizational Maturity	Focus on resolving hot spots before widespread adoption of best practices, ensuring organizational readiness for scalable practices.
Leveraging Quality Points	Key areas to focus on include interfaces, stateful systems, and data models to prevent quality failures and optimize future investments.
Aligning Technical Vectors	Aligning technical decisions across teams is vital for achieving organizational goals, supported by feedback, documentation, and structure.
Measuring Technical Quality	Clear metrics tailored to the organization allow for gap identification and tracking quality improvements over time.
Building a Quality Team	A dedicated technical quality team enhances software quality through impactful tools and practices, ensuring usability and team adoption.
Establishing a Quality Program	Quality programs driven by managers set goals, create measurable metrics, and support teams in maintaining technical quality.
Continuous Improvement and Small Steps	Implement gradual improvements to technical quality to allow teams to adapt effectively, avoiding overwhelming changes.
Management and Authority in Leadership	In staff-plus roles, leaders should maintain alignment with management and foster partnerships for better collaboration.
Influencing Organizational Change	Leaders should cultivate a unique perspective while aligning with organizational values to influence change effectively.

Managing Technical Quality

Understanding the Crisis of Technical Quality

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Engineers, managers, and executives acknowledge a crisis in technical quality; often blamed on personnel rather than organizational decisions. Low quality is typically a normal condition rather than a crisis, influenced by evolving quality standards as organizations grow.

The Leadership Challenge

Engineering leadership must balance maintaining appropriate technical quality while focusing on core business objectives. As organizational quality standards shift, approaches must adapt, emphasizing fixing immediate issues, adopting best practices, and establishing accountability.

Hot Spots and Immediate Solutions

The first step in addressing quality issues is identifying and fixing "hot spots" rather than immediately introducing new processes. Effective problem-solving requires understanding the context rather than imposing external accountability measures.

Best Practices and Organizational Maturity

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Before implementing extensive best practices, organizations should first address quality hot spots. Successful adoption of best practices requires a level of organizational readiness and involves serving specific teams well before scaling the practice company-wide.

Leveraging Quality Points

Key leverage points in maintaining technical quality include focus on interfaces, stateful systems, and data models. Prioritizing these areas can prevent major quality failures and streamline future quality investments.

Aligning Technical Vectors

Alignment of technical decisions within teams is crucial for achieving mutual organizational goals. Direct feedback, documentation of strategy, and organizational structure influence can improve this alignment.

Measuring Technical Quality

Establishing clear metrics for technical quality allows for the

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

identification of gaps and assessment of changes over time. Defining quality specifically to an organization's needs is essential for creating useful measurements.

Building a Quality Team

A dedicated technical quality team is important for maintaining high software quality. Such a team focuses on creating impactful tools and practices while balancing overall engineering efforts, ensuring their work is user-friendly and promotes team adoption.

Establishing a Quality Program

Quality programs, led by dedicated managers, aim to maintain technical quality across an organization. It requires setting clear goals, generating reproducible metrics, and providing supportive resources for teams.

Continuous Improvement and Small Steps

Organizations should gradually introduce improvements to technical quality rather than attempting comprehensive solutions at once. This iterative approach allows teams to

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

adapt effectively to quality changes.

Management and Authority in Leadership

In Staff-plus roles, maintaining alignment with organizational authority is critical. Leaders should avoid surprises for their managers, provide clear context, and cultivate partnerships that enhance collaboration.

Influencing Organizational Change

Developing a unique perspective while remaining aligned with organizational values is crucial for influencing leadership. This requires balancing personal vision with the overarching goals of the organization.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Example

Key Point:Understand and address quality issues by identifying 'hot spots' in your organization.

Example:Recognizing where technical quality falters is crucial; think about a project you lead where certain components frequently fail—direct your focus to these 'hot spots' instead of just blaming individuals. By doing this, you can implement immediate fixes that enhance productivity and morale, leading to a more robust overall outcome.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 11 Summary : To lead, you have to follow

Stay Aligned with Authority

In a Staff-plus role, it's crucial to operate as a proxy for your direct manager by understanding their worldview deeply. This trust enables you to effectively implement their strategies. Many aspiring for senior roles mistakenly believe that authority equates to power and autonomy, but titles come with organizational authority that must be maintained through alignment with one's manager.

Beyond the Safety Net

Upon reaching a Staff role, you transition from receiving support and guidance to being responsible for setting success parameters for your team and company. Unlike previous roles where you might have had a safety net, in leadership positions, you must navigate and align the elements around you for your success.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Serving at the Pleasure of the President

In roles like Staff-plus, authority stems from strong relationships with higher authority figures. You must consciously work to align with your manager, ensuring that you never surprise them and that you provide them with relevant context. Maintaining transparency and open communication is essential.

Influencing Without Too Much Friction

To grow as a leader, you must develop your own perspectives while merging them with those of senior leaders. Being proactive in advocating for your values helps you influence your organization positively. However, effective leaders often spend more time following than leading. It’s important to step back and allow others to lead when necessary, supporting their efforts even when you may not fully agree with their direction.

Learning to Follow

Real success in leadership involves understanding the balance between leading and following. You should be clear

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

about your priorities, support trustworthy leaders, and give feedback that is constructive yet non-blocking. Recognizing when to allow others to take charge can enhance overall progress and effectiveness, highlighting the importance of collaboration in achieving shared goals.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Example

Key Point:Understand the importance of aligning with your manager's worldview in a leadership role.

Example:Imagine you're leading a pivotal project, and you've developed a brilliant plan tailored to your team's strengths. However, before moving forward, you sit down with your manager to discuss your approach, carefully considering their insights and feedback. By incorporating their vision and ensuring you’re aligned with their strategic goals, you not only secure their support but also empower your team to execute your plan effectively. This alignment fosters trust and demonstrates that you respect their authority, which is crucial for your project's success and your growth as a leader.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Critical Thinking

Key Point:The importance of aligning with authority figures in leadership roles.

Critical Interpretation:Will Larson emphasizes how critical alignment with authority figures is in leadership positions, particularly in roles like Staff Engineer. While his principle that titles come with organizational authority is grounded in common workplace dynamics, one could argue that the blind pursuit of alignment could stifle innovation and independent thought, leading to missed opportunities for progress. This perspective is supported by various leadership models that advocate for balancing authority with personal initiative and creative thinking, such as Daniel Pink's "Drive" which discusses intrinsic motivation as a key factor for successful leadership.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Chapter 12 Summary : Learn to never be wrong

To Lead, You Have to Follow

Global Thinking and Local Application

Leadership is about applying a global understanding of technical initiatives to align with Engineering-wide strategies while being responsive to immediate stakeholder needs.

Definition of Leadership and Management

Leadership differs from management in that it is more of an approach rather than a profession. Effective leaders recognize the gap between the current state and desired state, and they act to bridge that gap.

The Importance of Following

Successful leaders often spend more time following than

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

leading. They understand that effective leadership involves shifting between leading and following roles, emphasizing collaboration over hierarchy.

Strategies for Effective Leadership

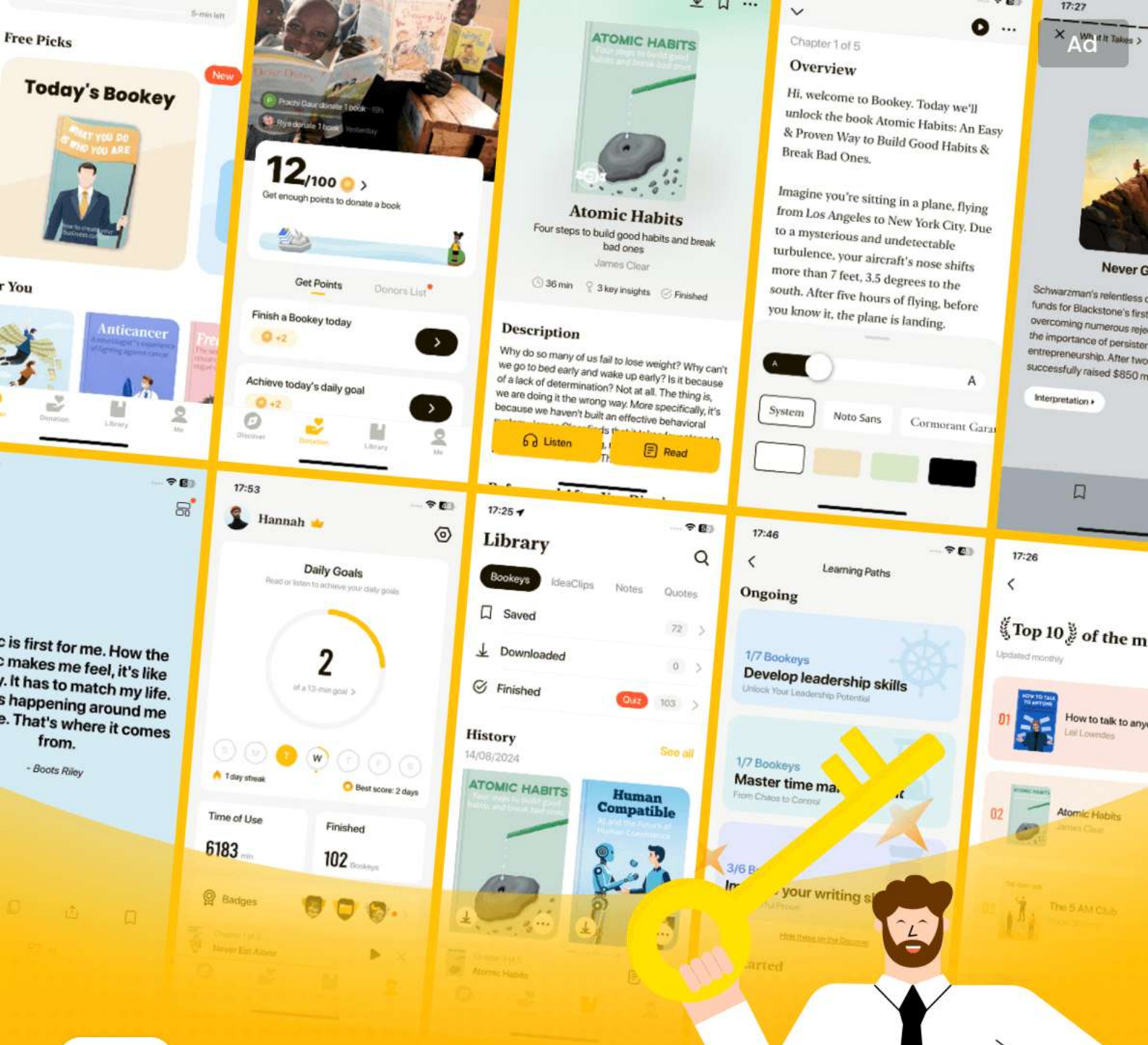
1.
Set Clear Priorities
: Know what really matters and focus efforts accordingly.
2.
Empower Others
: Allow others to take the lead where appropriate and provide support.
3.
Provide Non-Blocking Feedback
: Offer constructive feedback that doesn't impede others' progress.
4.

Install Bookey App to Unlock Full Text and Audio

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It



World' best ideas unlock your potential

Free Trial with Bookey

Scan to download

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play

Chapter 13 Summary : Create space for others

Summary of Chapter 13: Learn to Never Be Wrong

In Chapter 13 of "Staff Engineer," Will Larson discusses the importance of a collaborative leadership style that fosters open dialogue and encourages team involvement. The chapter emphasizes the need for senior technical leaders to avoid the pitfalls of dominant personalities who insist they are always right. Instead, effective leaders should aim to create space for others to express their viewpoints while guiding discussions toward productive outcomes.

Key Concepts

Creating a Collaborative Environment

- Leaders should strive to be correct without overpowering discussions.
- Active listening and asking clarifying questions enhance

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

collective understanding and enable more voices to be heard.
- Successful meetings begin with a clear purpose, allowing participants to align on the problem at hand without feeling pressured.

Mastering Key Approaches

1.
Listening through Questions
: Encourage participation by asking specific, open-ended questions to deepen the conversation.
2.
Defining Purpose
: Establish clear objectives for discussions to avoid ambiguity and facilitate focused conversations.
3.
Reading the Room
: Gauge the team's readiness to make decisions and adapt accordingly to maintain a healthy discussion dynamic.

Dealing with Challenging Personalities

- Some individuals may resist collaboration. Effective ways to manage this include:

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

- Bringing in a respected third party for mediation.
- Aligning with them before meetings to ensure their voices are considered.

Transitioning to a Sponsorship Role

- As leaders grow, their role shifts from being a contributor to empowering others. This involves:
  - Delegating critical tasks to help team members grow and succeed.
  - Ensuring decisions are made collaboratively, with efforts focused on including team perspectives in decision-making processes.

Importance of Documentation and Feedback

- Writing down thought processes and decisions helps others learn and provides transparency.
- Circulating ideas early allows for constructive feedback and shared ownership.

Sponsorship for Growth

- Encourage team members to take on pivotal projects to

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

promote their development.
- Leaders should step back and allow team members to claim ownership of their work while providing guidance as needed.

Final Thoughts

The chapter emphasizes that true leadership is about creating opportunities for others, recognizing that a leader's success is rooted in the ability to step back and allow their team to thrive. By learning to "never be wrong," leaders ensure that they maintain a focus on inclusivity and collective achievement, which ultimately benefits the organization as a whole.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 14 Summary : Build a network of peers

Section	Summary
Create Space for Others	Focus on empowering team members to contribute meaningfully, ensuring their growth and reducing reliance on individual expertise.
Empowering Others	Shifting from advocating for technologies to creating an environment that encourages team contribution and personal development.
Discussions	Evolving discussions by enhancing participation through insightful questions, engaging quiet members, and documenting contributions.
Decisions	Guiding team decision-making, promoting development and ownership, and employing effective strategies for involvement and feedback.
Sponsorship	Identifying and supporting team members in meaningful projects, allowing them freedom in their unique approaches to foster growth.
Building a Network of Peers	Networking is crucial for career growth through mentorship and peer interaction, providing insights on challenges.
Visible Networking	Being approachable and participating in discussions, conferences, and social media to enhance visibility and networking.
Internal Networks	Building internal networks for immediate benefits and career advancement as colleagues progress through the industry.
Ambient Networks	For those uneasy with traditional networking, creating ambient networks through social media engagement can aid professional growth.
Quality Over Quantity	Focus on building genuine connections rather than numerous relationships for more impactful collaborations.
Practical Networking Tips	Introverts can network by reaching out with specific questions to respected individuals, fostering relationships over time.

Create Space for Others

Empowering Others

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

As staff engineers, the focus shifts from advocating for specific technologies to empowering others to do so. It is crucial to foster an environment where team members can make meaningful contributions, ensuring their growth while reducing reliance on personal expertise.

Discussions

Good discussions evolve from personal impact to involving more participants in decision-making. Techniques to enhance participation include asking insightful questions, engaging quiet members, taking notes to facilitate contributions, and ensuring key stakeholders are present in meetings.

Decisions

Success in engineering transitions from making decisions to guiding others in decision-making. Involving the team in the process supports their development and promotes collective ownership. Strategies for effective decision-making include documenting processes, soliciting early feedback, separating style from substance, avoiding over-interference, and showing openness to changing one’s mind.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Sponsorship

Once team members are involved in discussions, the next step is to actively sponsor them in meaningful work. This involves identifying suitable individuals for projects, supporting their efforts, and allowing them the freedom to take their unique approaches, fostering both learning and leadership growth.

Building a Network of Peers

Importance of Networking

Building a network of peers is highly recommended for career growth. Regular interactions with mentors and trusted colleagues can provide valuable insights and feedback on challenges faced.

Visible Networking

Being visible and approachable as a staff engineer can help cultivate connections. Participating in discussions, contributing to conferences, and engaging on social media

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

platforms can enhance visibility and foster networking.

Internal Networks

Developing internal networks within one's organization can provide immediate benefits and facilitate career advancement as colleagues spread throughout the industry over time.

Ambient Networks

For those uncomfortable with traditional networking, creating an ambient network by following industry experts and engaging with their content on social media can be a helpful starting point for professional growth.

Quality Over Quantity

Building a meaningful network should prioritize genuine connections over the quantity of relationships. Taking time to foster trust and respect within professional relationships leads to more impactful collaborations.

Practical Networking Tips

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

For introverts or those unsure how to network, consider reaching out to respected individuals with specific questions or requests for advice. Cultivo mutexing relationships thoughtfully over time can lead to a supportive professional network.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 15 Summary : Present to executives

Section	Summary
Importance of a Personal Network	Building a personal network of peers is essential for advancing in a Staff-plus engineering career. Mentors and feedback from trusted friends are vital for support and personal development.
Strategies for Building a Network	This section outlines effective strategies for networking including visibility, internal networking, ambient networking, focusing on quality connections, and tips for introverts.
Being Visible	Engage in discussions on Staff-plus roles, share insights through writing or speaking, and utilize social media to enhance visibility and connections.
Internal Networking	Develop relationships within the company across teams to aid professional growth and support network expansion as colleagues move on.
Ambient Networking	For those who prefer less direct engagement, following industry leaders online can help establish an initial network.
Quality Over Quantity	Focus on meaningful relationships based on trust and respect to create a supportive professional network.
Tips for Introverts	Introverts should reach out to respected peers with specific questions to build connections gradually.
Presenting to Executives	Effective communication with executives is crucial; understanding their perspective and preparing structured communications is key.
Understanding the Communication Challenges	Executives may lack technical knowledge and have limited time, necessitating clear and purposeful communication.
Effective Communication Techniques	Use structured documents (like SCQA) and gather feedback beforehand to ensure alignment and clarity in presentations.
Avoiding Common Mistakes	Accept feedback, present problems with solutions, communicate concisely, and prioritize relationship building during presentations.
Conclusion	By preparing thoughtfully and engaging authentically, professionals can enhance their influence through effective executive communication.

Build a Network of Peers

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Importance of a Personal Network

To advance in a Staff-plus engineering career, building a personal network of peers is crucial. Many successful engineers stress the importance of having mentors and trusted friends for support and candid feedback. Regular discussions with peers help navigate career challenges and boost personal development.

Strategies for Building a Network

Being Visible

One effective method to enhance visibility is to engage in discussions regarding Staff-plus engineering roles. Sharing insights through writing or speaking at tech conferences can establish connections. Social media platforms like Twitter

Install Bookey App to Unlock Full Text and Audio

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Try Bookey App to read 1000+ summary of world best books

Unlock 1000+ Titles, 80+ Topics

New titles added every week

Brand | Leadership & Collaboration | Time Management | Relationship & Communication

ness Strategy | Creativity | Public | Money & Investing | Know Yourself | Positive P

Entrepreneurship | World History | Parent-Child Communication | Self-care | Mind & Spi

Insights of world best books

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 16 Summary : Promotion packets

Getting the Title Where You Are

Promotion Systems and Staff Engineer Roles

Most companies have a career level that ends with Senior Engineer, and the transition to Staff Engineer often depends on timing, luck, and personal effort. Companies may have a mindset that hinders promotions to Staff, with some employees needing to change companies to obtain the title. The career progression is not standard after reaching Senior level, necessitating a proactive approach to career navigation.

Finding Your Trail

Shifting from a reliance on management to a self-directed approach can be jarring for engineers. Special attention must be paid to documenting achievements in a promotion packet, which serves as a roadmap for attaining the Staff Engineer

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

title. Engaging in high-leverage projects and becoming visible within the organization is crucial for promotion, despite the challenges posed by uneven opportunities in different company structures.

Inequities in Opportunity

Opportunity at companies can be unevenly distributed, influenced by factors such as team dynamics and engineering focus. Recognizing these disparities is essential for strategizing personal growth and seeking sponsorship to overcome systemic barriers.

Considering Management Roles

While the majority of Staff Engineers do not choose management paths, some find value in alternating between engineering and management roles. This experience can provide a broader perspective and enhance effectiveness in both capacities. However, management should not be pursued solely for personal advancement; motivations should center on team support and development.

Staff-Plus Titles as Leadership Positions

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Attaining a Staff-plus title often requires alignment with existing leadership perceptions. Those with representation similar to current leaders may have a smoother path to promotion.

Promotion Packets as Tools of Success

Crafting a promotion packet early in one's career is advised, as it can guide the development of skills necessary for Staff Engineer roles. The packet should articulate projects, impact, mentorship contributions, and identify gaps that need addressing. Regular updates and feedback from managers and peers help refine this document.

Steps for Creating a Promotion Packet

1. Identify your reasons for pursuing the Staff role.
2. Keep realistic expectations on promotion timelines.
3. Collaborate with your manager to communicate career goals.
4. Draft and refine your promotion packet consistently.
5. Seek feedback from peers and managers throughout the process.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

By diligently following these steps and using the promotion packet as a foundational tool, one can strategically navigate towards achieving the Staff Engineer title.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 17 Summary : Find your sponsor

Promotion Packets

Promotion packets are often seen as the final step toward achieving a Staff-plus role. However, a more effective strategy is to start creating your promotion packet early, before you even think you're ready for promotion. This approach allows the packet to serve as a roadmap toward your goals rather than merely a formality for review.

General Template Format

A useful template for structuring your promotion packet includes the following:
- Outline of Staff projects: What you did, project impact, complexity, and links to supporting documents.
- High-leverage improvements you've made within the organization and their quantifiable impacts.
- Individuals you have mentored and the accomplishments achieved through this mentorship.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

- Your glue work for the organization and its impact.
- Teams and leaders familiar with your work, what they value about it, and any survey data if available.
- Gaps in skills or behaviors that could hinder your progression and plans to address them.

Engaging with peers and managers in this process and soliciting their feedback is crucial.

Iterative Approach for Promotion Packets

1.
Understanding Your Motivation
: Acknowledge your reasons for pursuing a Staff role to avoid pursuing a path that doesn’t energize you.
2.
Managing Expectations
: Realize that promotions take time; avoid expecting instant results.
3.
Involving Your Manager
: Discuss your goal with your manager during regular meetings, allowing for guidance and assistance in shaping your packet.
4.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Drafting and Editing
: Write a first draft of your packet, then review and edit it iteratively, including feedback from trusted peers and your manager.
5.
Ongoing Review
: Maintain regular discussions about the packet with your manager through career-related one-on-ones to keep aligning your work with promotion criteria.

Finding Your Sponsor

Having an organizational sponsor is vital for successfully achieving a promotion. This sponsor speaks on your behalf in discussions where your contributions are assessed. While your direct manager is often your primary sponsor, building relationships with skip-level managers can also help reinforce your case for promotion.

Activating Your Sponsor

To effectively engage your sponsors, you should:
- Clearly communicate your promotion goals.
- Collaborate on reviewing your promotion packet to identify

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

gaps and improve your candidacy.
- Build a relationship over time by supporting their initiatives, rather than treating sponsorship as a one-time transaction.

Dealing with Challenges

If the relationship with your manager isn’t working, focus on proactive communication to facilitate improvement. If after six months of effort things don’t improve, consider exploring new team opportunities, leveraging relationships with higher-ups for support. Developing the ability to work with people of differing styles and goals is essential in leadership roles.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Example

Key Point:Start Early with Your Promotion Packet.

Example:Creating your promotion packet ahead of time provides a strategic advantage, helping you clarify your goals and track your progress.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Chapter 18 Summary : Staff projects

Section	Summary
Find Your Sponsor	Finding a sponsor is essential for advancing to a Staff-plus role as they can advocate for your work and promotion.
Role of Your Manager	Your direct manager is usually your primary sponsor, but it's important to network beyond them if they lack experience in higher role promotions.
Activating Your Sponsor	Communicate your career goals clearly and align with your sponsor by seeking guidance and discussing your promotion packet.
Building Relationships	Sponsorship requires a non-transactional relationship; invest time in supporting and engaging with your sponsor actively.
What to Do If It Doesn't Work	If a manager is hard to work with, it may hinder your promotion. Focus on skill development and maintain connections with upper management during transitions.
Expectation of a Staff Project	While completing a Staff project is often expected, many advance without one, especially when changing companies.
Diverse Experiences	Engineers can reach Staff positions due to leadership track records or company transitions, though some companies do require Staff projects for internal promotions.
Value of Staff Projects	Staff projects develop skills and demonstrate readiness for a Staff role by presenting complex, high-visibility challenges.
Accessing Staff Projects	To engage in a Staff project, gain management trust, showcase technical skills, and identify pressing leadership needs.
Final Thoughts on Pursuing Staff Projects	The necessity of a Staff project for promotion varies, but they are important for growth and enhancing engineering skills.

Find Your Sponsor

Importance of Sponsorship

Finding a sponsor is crucial for advancing to a Staff-plus role. Many engineers struggle to have their work recognized despite having a strong impact. They may be advised to

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

complete various projects, but what they often lack is a sponsor who can advocate for them.

Role of Your Manager

Your direct manager is typically your primary sponsor, responsible for advocating for your promotion and guiding you through the promotion process. It's essential to establish relationships beyond your direct manager, especially if they have limited experience with promotions to higher roles.

Activating Your Sponsor

To activate your sponsor, share your career goals openly. Don’t assume that your work is complete once you identify your sponsors; it's essential to align with them by asking for guidance on specific gaps and facilitating conversations around your promotion packet.

Install Bookey App to Unlock Full Text and Audio

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Why Bookey is must have App for Book Lovers

30min Content
The deeper and clearer interpretation we provide, the better grasp of each title you have.

Text and Audio format
Absorb knowledge even in fragmented time.

Quiz
Check whether you have mastered what you just learned.

And more
Multiple Voices & fonts, Mind Map, Quotes, IdeaClips...

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 19 Summary : Get in the room, and stay there

Section	Summary
Understanding Staff Projects	Completing a Staff Project is often necessary for promotion to Staff Engineer, but not all engineers have dedicated projects.
Experiences of Engineers	No Staff Project Required: Some engineers, like Joy Ebertz and Diana Pojar, were promoted without one. Staff Project Required: Others, like Ritu Vincent and Ras Kasa Williams, had projects critical for their promotions.
Why Pursue a Staff Project	Pursuing a Staff Project can lead to significant personal and professional growth, developing skills and confidence.
Characteristics of Staff Projects	Complex and Ambiguous: Starts with ill-defined problems requiring creative solutions. Numerous Stakeholders: Involves various parties with differing opinions. High Visibility: Closely monitored outcomes with significant impact.
Getting Access to Staff Projects	Access is determined by trust with management, technical competence, and alignment with company needs.
Deciding to Pursue a Staff Project	Pursuing a Staff Project is likely essential for promotion and provides a chance for substantial professional growth.
Getting in the Room and Staying There	Unique value, sponsorship, and active engagement are crucial for gaining and maintaining access to decision-making spaces.
Common Pitfalls to Avoid	Misunderstanding the room's purpose. Being dogmatic or withholding consent. Overwhelming discussions with excessive input. Embarrassing one's sponsor or being flaky.
Final Thoughts	Selectivity in career opportunities is important; exiting unproductive spaces allows better investment of time and resources.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Summary of Chapter 19: Staff Projects

Understanding Staff Projects

There is an implicit understanding that completing a "Staff Project" is typically necessary for promotion to a Staff Engineer position. While most promotions include a significant project, not every engineer has a formal, designated Staff Project, and many attain the role through other means.

Experiences of Engineers

- **No Staff Project Required**
: Some engineers, such as Joy Ebertz and Diana Pojar, report not having a dedicated Staff Project as part of their promotion process.
- **Staff Project Required**
: Many companies do require Staff Projects for promotions, and experiences, like that of Ritu Vincent at Dropbox and Ras Kasa Williams at Mailchimp, illustrate how such

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

projects can be critical to promotion.

Why Pursue a Staff Project

Although not universally needed for promotion, embarking on a Staff Project is an opportunity for significant personal and professional growth. Engaging in complex, high-stakes projects helps develop skills and increases confidence.

Characteristics of Staff Projects

1.
Complex and Ambiguous
: Often begins with ill-defined problems that require creative solutions.
2.
Numerous Stakeholders
: Projects may involve various parties with differing opinions or goals.
3.
High Visibility
: Outcomes have a significant impact and are closely monitored by leadership.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Getting Access to Staff Projects

Access depends on several factors, including establishing trust with management, demonstrating technical competence, and aligning with company needs.

Deciding to Pursue a Staff Project

For those seeking a promotion within their company, pursuing a Staff Project is likely essential. Even if not required, the challenging nature of the work can lead to substantial professional growth.

Getting in the Room and Staying There

Access to decision-making spaces is crucial. To get in, one must provide unique value, have a sponsor, and engage actively. To remain in these spaces, one should keep contributing meaningful context without disrupting the group’s flow.

Common Pitfalls to Avoid

1. Misunderstanding the room's purpose.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

2. Being dogmatic or withholding consent.
3. Overwhelming discussions with excessive input.
4. Embarrassing one's sponsor or being flaky.

Final Thoughts

While there are numerous rooms to enter in a career, being selective about which ones to focus on is vital. Exiting unproductive rooms can allow for better investment of time and resources elsewhere.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Example

Key Point:Pursuing a Staff Project can catalyze your professional growth, even if not mandated for promotion.

Example:Imagine you're navigating a complex project that challenges your technical skills and decision-making abilities, impacting various stakeholders and drawing the attention of leadership. Engaging wholeheartedly in such a project allows you to push your boundaries, fostering valuable experience and enhancing your credibility within your team. As you tackle ambiguous problems and seek innovative solutions, you not only sharpen your technical expertise but also build vital relationships with colleagues and leaders, all of which can pave the way for your advancement in the engineering hierarchy.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Critical Thinking

Key Point:Promotion Necessity vs. Strategic Growth

Critical Interpretation:The author implies that having or pursuing a 'Staff Project' is crucial for career advancement, but this may oversimplify the promotion process. While many engineers have successfully secured promotions without a designated Staff Project, such as Joy Ebertz and Diana Pojar, the assumption that it’s universally necessary could pressure others into unnecessary stress. This aligns with varying promotion criteria across industries, suggesting the need for a more nuanced view. Research such as 'Professional Presence: Creating a Culture of Confidence' by Carol Kinsey Goman supports the notion of diverse pathways to growth and recognition beyond rigid structures.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Chapter 20 Summary : Being visible

Get in the Room, and Stay There

One of the key frustrations for engineers is their absence from decision-making processes. Staff-plus engineers often cite access to crucial meetings as a significant advantage of their roles. However, there is no singular "room"; instead, entering important discussions is an ongoing challenge throughout an engineer's career.

Getting in the Room

To enter these critical spaces, engineers need to:

-

Bring Unique Value

: Offer insights or context that others may not possess. This could include expertise in a relevant area or experiences from previous roles.

-

Secure a Sponsor

: Someone within the room must advocate for your

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

participation, as they are risking their social capital by supporting you.

-

Align with Leadership

: Ensuring agreement with your manager's strategic direction increases your chances of being included.

-

Be Present and Prepared

: Attend meetings with a clear mind and contribute actively. Volunteer for lower-status tasks to establish your usefulness.

Staying in the Room

Once inside, maintaining a presence is critical. To stay in the room, you have to:

-

Contribute Meaningfully

: Continue to provide valuable insights and actively engage in discussions.

-

Understand the Room's Dynamics

: Adjust your approach based on the goals of the meeting and how the group operates.

-

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Avoid Negative Patterns
: Misunderstanding the meeting's purpose, being dogmatic, withholding consent, dominating discussions, embarrassing your sponsor, or being flaky can all lead to removal from the room.

Exiting the Room

Recognizing when to leave a room is equally important. Exiting can free up space for others and allow you to focus on more productive areas. Always consider the utility of each room before committing your time.

Visibility Matters

Visibility is essential for promotion. This involves:
-
Creating Internal Visibility
: Work on projects that align with company goals and engage in communication strategies that shine a light on your contributions.
-
Building Executive Relationships
: Cultivate connections with upper management to ensure

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

they know your work.

-

External Presence

: While not mandatory, having a presence outside the organization can enhance your reputation and create opportunities that may not be available internally.

Finding the Balance

Increasing visibility within an organization can be a double-edged sword; ensure that it does not distract from your core responsibilities or hinder others' chances. Focus on learning and personal development after you've established sufficient visibility to support your ambitions.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Example

Key Point:Bring Unique Value

Example:Imagine you're in a crucial team meeting where strategic decisions are being made. Your colleagues are discussing metrics and processes, but you realize that you possess insights gained from your previous project that could significantly influence the outcome. As you confidently share your expertise, the room quiets and attention turns toward you. Suddenly, you’re not just a participant; you are becoming a pivotal voice in the discussion. This moment highlights the importance of bringing unique value to the table, not only helping to shape decisions but also solidifying your place in future conversations. That distinctive perspective you offer allows you to 'get in the room' and stay relevant, boosting your visibility and career prospects.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Critical Thinking

Key Point:The Importance of Presence in Decision-Making

Critical Interpretation:The chapter emphasizes the essential role that being present in discussions and decision-making processes plays in the career advancement of engineers. While Larson outlines strategies for gaining access and maintaining visibility, it's important to critically assess whether these tactics uniformly apply across various organizational cultures and individual career paths. Different environments might prioritize distinct capabilities beyond mere participation; some might value collaborative dynamics or diverse perspectives over strategic positioning or visibility alone. Thus, while Larson's insights provide a framework, one should consider sources such as 'The Lean Startup' by Eric Ries that challenge conventional approaches to participation in organizational growth, advocating for adaptability. This indicates that no single approach guarantees success in every context.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Chapter 21 Summary : Finding the right company

Deciding to Switch Companies

Keavy McMinn's decision to switch companies led to him obtaining the title of Principal Engineer at Fastly. While the nature of his work remained similar, the act of changing companies was pivotal in achieving this title.

Long-Term Employment in Technology vs. Other Fields

Unlike traditional roles, such as those in academia, technology sees frequent job changes. Historically, many engineers would switch jobs every few years to optimize equity gains, a trend less common among those in Staff-plus roles who are often rewarded for longevity. Significant efforts in building visibility are needed to transition from Senior engineer to Staff-plus roles.

Reasons for Leaving a Company

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

While current employers are seen as the best sources for promotions, various factors may hinder this, such as team seniority, budget constraints, or lack of internal sponsors. When seeking new roles, professionals have the opportunity to find organizations willing to grant desired titles that may not be available in their current positions.

Internal Changes Before Leaving

Before making a final decision, individuals may explore internal opportunities to switch roles, which can help them stay engaged and utilize existing networks. For those experiencing burnout, negotiating sabbaticals can provide needed downtime.

Leaving Without a Job

Install Bookey App to Unlock Full Text and Audio

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

App Store
Editors' Choice

22k 5 star review

Positive feedback

Sara Scholz

tes after each book summary
erstanding but also make the
and engaging. Bookey has
ding for me.

Fantastic!!!

Masood El Toure

I'm amazed by the variety of books and languages Bookey supports. It's not just an app, it's a gateway to global knowledge. Plus, earning points for charity is a big plus!

Fi
Ab
bo
to
my

José Botín

ding habit
p's design
ual growth

Love it!

Wonnie Tappkx

Bookey offers me time to go through the important parts of a book. It also gives me enough idea whether or not I should purchase the whole book version or not! It is easy to use!

Time saver!

Bookey is my go-to app for
summaries are concise, ins
curated. It's like having acc
right at my fingertips!

Awesome app!

Rahul Malviya

I love audiobooks but don't always have time to listen to the entire book! bookey allows me to get a summary of the highlights of the book I'm interested in!!! What a great concept !!!highly recommended!

Beautiful App

Alex Walk

This app is a lifesaver for book lovers with busy schedules. The summaries are spot on, and the mind maps help reinforce wh I've learned. Highly recommend!

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 22 Summary : Interviewing for Staff-plus roles

Finding the Right Company

There are two main paths to achieve a Staff-plus role: negotiate for the title during a job switch or develop credibility in a supportive environment with a sponsor. The crucial factor in both scenarios is choosing the right company.

Values Alignment

When aiming for career progression, it’s essential to find a company that values your unique skills. Well-run organizations appreciate your strengths, whereas poorly-run companies may focus on your identity without recognizing your true contributions.

Company Perspectives: Meritocrats vs. Proceduralists

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Understanding the company’s leadership philosophy is key:

-

Meritocrats:

These companies favor exceptional talent and may create roles for specific individuals based on their vision of high potential.

-

Proceduralists:

They prioritize consistency and fairness, often leading to rigid structures.

It's important to identify a company that aligns with your identity and has supportive sponsors.

Company Archetypes and Growth Potential

Most companies hire limited types of Staff engineers, so researching existing staff will provide insight into the company's supporting archetypes. Additionally, slower-growing companies might restrict Staff-plus roles due to budget or structural limitations, whereas fast-growing companies will likely offer more organic opportunities.

Sponsorship Importance

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

A powerful advocate within your prospective company is essential. Seek out roles where there is a supportive management structure that believes in your capabilities. Networking and establishing connections can yield potential sponsors.

Evaluating Company Durability

Consider if the company has long-term viability; assess if it will still exist years down the line and whether your potential sponsor will remain in a leadership role to support your career development.

Aligning Pace and Expectations

Assess whether the company culture and pace align with your capabilities. Ensure the pace of the company matches your ability to sustain a leadership role, as well as your long-term compatibility with the organization.

Effective Job Search Strategy

Searching for leadership roles takes longer than typical job searches, requiring careful consideration of toxic issues and

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

alignment with the company's mission and team dynamics.

Interview Preparation for Staff-plus Roles

Staff-plus interviews often lack clarity. Familiarize yourself with the process and ask questions about the interview format and the evaluation criteria to tailor your preparation effectively. Maintain clarity on the roles you are aiming for during your application process.

Conclusion: Finishing Well

When concluding your job search, negotiate the terms thoughtfully, follow up with references, and keep communication lines open with interviewers. Properly managing these final details can significantly influence the effectiveness of your transition into a new role.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 23 Summary : Negotiating your offer

Interviewing for Staff-plus Roles

Expectations and Preparation

When preparing for a Staff-plus role, clarity around the interview process is often lacking compared to a Senior Engineer interview. It's essential to navigate the ambiguity, recognizing that interview formats may vary widely between companies.

Defining Your Criteria

Before entering the interview, carefully consider what types of processes and companies align with your career goals. Identify any signals during the interview that might indicate a lack of understanding from the company about Staff-plus evaluations.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Understanding the Interview Process

Assertively gather details about the interview format, evaluation criteria, and interviewers. This preparation helps ensure that the process aligns with your professional goals and that you can effectively showcase your capabilities.

Negotiating Offers

When you reach the offer stage, be prepared to negotiate not just salary but also other aspects such as equity, vacation days, and work flexibility. Building a narrative around your requests can help make them more acceptable to employers.

Ending the Process Well

Always follow through with references and other formalities after the interview process. This final step can significantly impact your professional relationships and reputation.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Critical Thinking

Key Point:Importance of Clarity in the Interview Process

Critical Interpretation:Will Larson emphasizes the necessity of understanding the interview format and evaluation criteria for Staff-plus roles, which he believes is crucial for success. However, one could argue that his perspective may overlook the adaptability of engineers who thrive despite unclear processes, as some candidates may be better suited to navigate ambiguity more effectively than the typical guidelines suggest. Sources such as 'The Lean Startup' by Eric Ries mention that embracing uncertainty can lead to innovation and adaptability, providing a contrasting viewpoint to Larson's emphasis on structured preparation.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 24 Summary : Michelle Bu - Payments Products Tech Lead at Stripe

Stories

After publishing my first book, I realized I do not enjoy reading reviews of my work. While some comments made me feel good momentarily, most left me feeling sad. One particular review pointed out the Silicon Valley-centric nature of my writing, which stayed with me as I began brainstorming for this book. I aimed to create a guide that reflects diverse experiences in the industry, taking into account perspectives shaped by privilege, luck, and unique journeys. The following chapter is pivotal as it shares candid interviews from industry practitioners.

Interview with Michelle Bu

Role at Stripe
Michelle Bu, the Payments Products Tech Lead at Stripe, collaborates with the Chief Product Officer. Her work involves supporting critical initiatives across the

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

organization, focusing primarily on large cross-organizational design projects while also reviewing technical and product designs.

Normal Staff Engineer Role

At Stripe, most Staff-plus engineers work on specific teams. Some, like Michelle, also hold a Tech Lead title, overseeing broader projects. Two types of Staff-plus engineers exist: those with deep expertise in a domain and those with broad scopes, affecting multiple projects and accumulating context across various domains.

Impact as a Staff-plus Engineer

Michelle finds her current role energizing, shifting from being merely impactful to finding work that excites her. She feels most invigorated when she can contribute to teams or witness the growth and achievements of those she has sponsored.

Changes in Role and Interactions

Transitioning to a Tech Lead role has altered how colleagues

Install Bookey App to Unlock Full Text and Audio

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Read, Share, Empower

Finish Your Reading Challenge, Donate Books to African Children.

The Concept

BOOKS FOR AFRICA × ×

This book donation activity is rolling out together with Books For Africa. We release this project because we share the same belief as BFA: For many children in Africa, the gift of books truly is a gift of hope.

The Rule

Earn 100 points → **Redeem a book** → **Donate to Africa**

Your learning not only brings knowledge but also allows you to earn points for charitable causes! For every 100 points you earn, a book will be donated to Africa.

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 25 Summary : Ras Kasa Williams - Staff Engineer at Mailchimp

Chapter 25 Summary: Insights from Stripe's Technical Leaders

Michelle Bu’s Role at Stripe

- Michelle Bu is the Payments Products Tech Lead at Stripe, collaborating with the Chief Product Officer and focusing on cross-organizational design projects, API design, and supporting urgent issues.

Staff-plus Engineer Responsibilities at Stripe

- Staff-plus Engineers at Stripe either have a deep or broad scope. Those with broad scope engage in cross-organizational projects, while deep-scoped engineers become subject-matter experts.

Impact as a Staff-plus Engineer

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

- Michelle emphasizes feeling "energized" by her work and contributing to the progress of engineering teams rather than seeking personal accolades.

Challenges of Leadership and Visibility

- Transitioning to a more senior role has led to increased expectations for her opinions during discussions, and she acknowledges the loneliness that can accompany leadership roles.

Maintaining Empathy and Technical Involvement

- To stay connected with the engineering team, she engages in regular one-on-ones and stays informed about incidents within Stripe.

Advocacy and Empowerment

- Michelle focuses more on empowering others to advocate for their ideas and technologies rather than directly pushing for change.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Sponsorship and Mentorship

- Sponsorship is a key aspect of her role. She actively facilitates impactful work for individual contributors, focusing on their development and visibility within the organization.

Career Journey at Stripe

- Michelle's journey at Stripe began after college and included a gradual growth in responsibilities. Early challenges in her career helped her build resilience and peer connections.

Staff Projects and Leadership

- She has contributed to significant projects that became successful products, demonstrating essential leadership qualities such as effective communication and technical understanding.

Promotion and Advice on Career Progression

- Michelle credits her promotion to having supportive

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

managers and emphasizes the importance of listening and empathizing with others.

Navigating Staff Role Expectations

- She advises new Staff-plus Engineers to avoid overextending themselves and instead focus on solidifying their current contributions while selectively expanding their influence.

Engineering Management vs. Technical Leadership

- Although she manages a small team, she prefers the technical path over traditional management roles, allowing her to work directly on impactful projects.

Continuous Learning and Growth

- Michelle values peer relationships and ongoing feedback as critical for professional development, often opting for a diverse set of mentors rather than a single figure.

Conclusion

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

- The chapter showcases experiences and insights from Michelle Bu about her role as a Staff-plus Engineer at Stripe, emphasizing the balance between personal fulfillment, organizational impact, effective sponsorship, and advocacy.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Critical Thinking

Key Point:Impact and Empowerment in Leadership Roles

Critical Interpretation:A significant focus of this chapter is Michelle Bu's advocacy for empowering others within her organization, highlighting that true leadership lies not in personal accolades but in facilitating the success of team members. While this perspective underscores the importance of humility and collective success in engineering leadership, one should also consider that this approach may not universally apply. In some instances, individual recognition can serve as a strong motivator for engineers, driving innovation and excellence. This notion is supported by various studies in organizational behavior (e.g., Pink's "Drive") which suggest that personal achievement can be an important driver. Therefore, while Michelle's emphasis on empowerment is noteworthy, it is important for readers to critically evaluate the effectiveness of such an approach in differing contexts and teams.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 26 Summary : Keavy McMinn - Senior Principal Engineer at Fastly

Summary of Chapter 26: Conversation with Ras Kasa Williams

Current Role and Responsibilities

Ras Kasa Williams is a Staff Engineer at Mailchimp, working within the Data Services engineering group. His team focuses on building data processing systems to support various analysts across the company. Kasa has taken on tech lead responsibilities, emphasizing scalable data processing pipelines and business intelligence initiatives while also handling some engineering management tasks. He is transitioning this role to another engineer after nearly two years.

Understanding the Staff-plus Role

At Mailchimp, becoming a Staff Engineer means joining

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

"Engineering Leadership." This role requires global thinking, aligning with the company’s product and technical strategies while supporting team needs. Staff Engineers focus on improving processes and developing the skills of other engineers.

Daily Work Activities

Kasa's day-to-day tasks involve defining and executing his team’s technical strategy, mentoring engineers, engaging with internal customers, and ensuring alignment with overall business goals. His contributions include regular coding as well as fostering communication and self-sufficiency within the team.

Key Impact Areas

Kasa finds satisfaction in helping peers unblock technical challenges and maintaining momentum on projects. His responsibilities include guiding team members in technical decision-making and fostering their growth through exposure and support.

Contribution as a Staff Engineer

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

As a newly appointed Staff Engineer, Kasa has experienced more agency in his role, coaching peers beyond his immediate team. He notes that titles do matter, impacting how others perceive agency, visibility, and mentorship opportunities. He views his initial project at Mailchimp—an internal analytics platform—as pivotal in gaining visibility and ultimately earning his promotion to Staff Engineer.

Advice for Aspiring Staff Engineers

Kasa recommends that new Staff Engineers focus on building a network of peers and taking care not to overextend themselves by trying to solve every problem at once. He emphasizes effective communication, documentation, and creating opportunities for other engineers to grow. Building relationships early can help in future collaborations, as well as being proactive in presenting solutions and recommendations to management.

Future Path and Time Management

Kasa expresses a goal of eventually moving into a CTO role but remains satisfied with his contributions as an individual

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

contributor. He stresses the importance of balancing technical direction, mentorship, and project management, while also adapting to changes in his responsibilities as he transitions out of his current tech lead role.

Supporting Resources and Role Models

Kasa highlights the significance of effective communication and various role models in his career journey. He cites influential figures, resources like books and blogs, and the value of attending conferences to build skills and relationships within the engineering community.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 27 Summary : Bert Fan - Senior Staff Engineer at Slack

Chapter 27 Summary

Introduction to Keavy McMinn's Role

Keavy McMinn is a Senior Principal Engineer at Fastly, working in the Office of the CTO (OCTO). OCTO comprises principal and distinguished engineers focused on various areas, and Keavy serves as the API Lead.

Role of a Staff-Plus Engineer

At Fastly, staff-plus engineers have the autonomy to choose projects, focusing on long-term, holistic solutions. They engage in a mix of written work, research, and regular meetings with teams to develop strategies for APIs. Their influence extends beyond coding to include strategic metrics and proposals.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Impact and Influence as a Staff-Plus Engineer

Transitioning from a regular engineer to a principal role affords Keavy more trust and respect, facilitating engagement with executives and shaping strategic initiatives. Advocacy plays a crucial part of her role, involving collaborative exercises for steering technical choices rather than direct directives.

Advocacy and Design Documents

Keavy emphasizes the importance of creating design documents for API changes before coding begins, which helps clarify user workflows and interface designs. This approach aims to address pain points commonly encountered in engineering discussions.

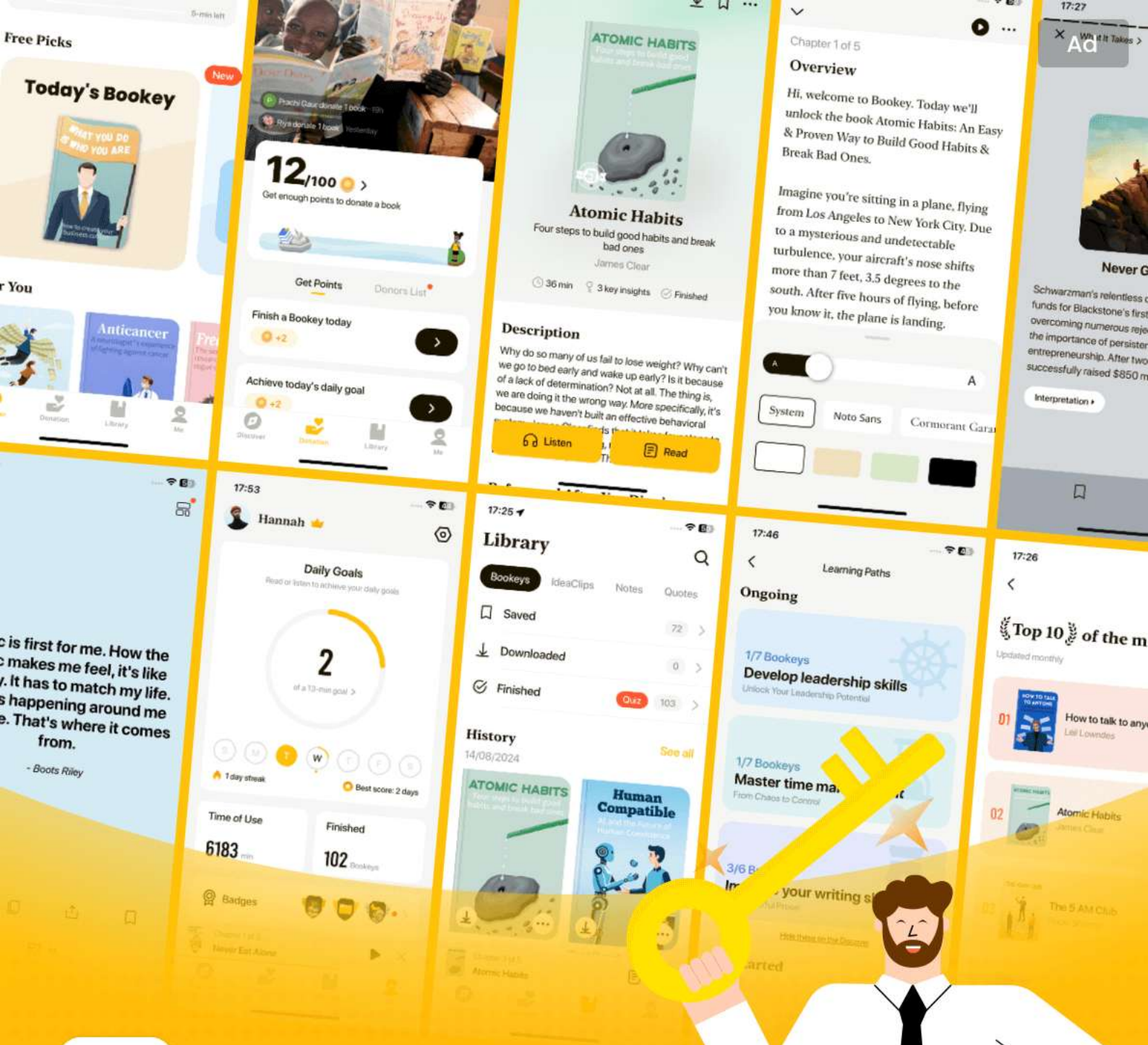
Sponsorship and Building Trust

Install Bookey App to Unlock Full Text and Audio

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It



World' best ideas unlock your potential

Free Trial with Bookey

Scan to download

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play

Chapter 28 Summary : Katie Sylor-Miller - Frontend Architect at Etsy

Summary of Chapter 28 from "Staff Engineer" by Will Larson

Introduction to Bert Fan

- Bert Fan is a Senior Staff Engineer at Slack, involved in developing the Slack Platform to improve user experience for developers and customers through various features and collaborations.

Role of Staff-plus Engineers

- Staff-plus engineers at Slack have diverse roles depending on their team's size, business needs, and can act as tech leads for projects, mentoring others and enhancing engineering culture.
- Bert focuses on the technology's enabling aspects rather than specific implementations, experimenting with product

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

ideas, documenting insights, and participating in strategy discussions while maintaining developer experience.

Maintaining Relevance in Engineering

- Regular one-on-ones with engineers help Bert understand the state of engineering and foster open communication, enabling candid exchanges devoid of promotional implications.

Factors Influencing Progression to a Staff Role

- Bert attributes his progression to a supportive background, strategic job choices, and networking within the industry. He emphasizes the importance of building trust with management and actively participating in impactful projects to facilitate promotions.

Advice for Aspiring Staff Engineers

- Bert speaks about transparency in work and networking with higher management as vital aspects to promotion. He encourages developing a good reputation and understanding the transition from technical roles to roles focusing on

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

influence and collaboration without formal authority.

Maintaining Empathy and Developer Awareness

- Networking is crucial for staying connected with engineers across teams. Engaging in mentorship, forums, and actively involving oneself in community discussions enhances connection and organizational pulse.

Sponsorship and Empowerment of Others

- Bert values sponsorship as an essential aspect of his role, exemplified by initiatives like the Product Engineering Confab to uplift others and provide opportunities for visibility and leadership experiences.

Characteristics of Successful Staff Engineers

- Effective communication, proactiveness in identifying and solving problems, and a passion for empathy in user experiences are pivotal for a Staff Engineer's success.

Navigating Uncertainty in Senior Roles

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

- Emphasizes the need for resilience, self-awareness, and adaptability to pivot away from unsuccessful strategies while maintaining leadership through influence.

Continuous Learning and Role Models

- Bert highlights influential personas in the field. He mentions learning resources such as blogs and talks that help define pathways and practices for growth in engineering roles.

This chapter encapsulates Bert's journey and insights related to the responsibilities, challenges, and growth opportunities as a Staff Engineer, providing valuable lessons for aspiring engineers in similar roles.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 29 Summary : Ritu Vincent - Staff Engineer at Dropbox

Summary of Chapter 29 - Katie Sylor-Miller's Insights on Staff Engineering at Etsy

Current Role and Responsibilities

Katie Sylor-Miller is a Frontend Architect at Etsy, an online marketplace for handmade goods. She works on the Frontend Systems team, focusing on frontend architecture, including a PHP view rendering framework. Currently, her efforts are centered around improving web performance, acting in an advisory capacity to enhance monitoring and reporting systems.

Understanding Staff Engineer Role

At Etsy, the term "Staff Engineer" encompasses two profiles:

1.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Tech Leads

- Focused on driving their teams' technical approach and project management.

2.

Architects

- Broaden their scope of influence to address cross-cutting issues and create systems that benefit multiple teams. Katie identifies as a Staff Engineer II and views her role as an architect responsible for guiding the future of frontend engineering at Etsy.

Day-to-Day Activities

Katie spends her time in meetings (approximately 50%) and varies her remaining workload through documentation, data analysis (SQL), and cross-team communications. Her significant calendar commitments often limit her coding time, focusing her efforts on identifying improvement opportunities rather than direct software development.

Measuring Impact

Quantifying her work is a challenge for Katie, who now relies on comprehensive tracking of tasks and performance

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

metrics. This reflection allows her to showcase her efforts during performance reviews and recognize her contributions to the company's direction.

Influence as a Staff Engineer

Katie enjoys creatively solving problems by synthesizing input across teams and advocating for impactful projects. She believes frontend engineers can provide significant leverage, emphasizing that user experience is vital and should be valued within a company.

Networking and Sponsorship

Katie emphasizes the importance of networking, particularly in her remote working environment. She actively participates in employee resource groups and mentors junior engineers. Sponsorship of peers is critical; she highlights her role in establishing forums that aid communication and celebrate team achievements, contributing to a culture of support and growth.

Navigating Promotion to Staff Engineer

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Katie's promotion to Staff Engineer was facilitated by her proactive identification of issues and proposing improvements, coupled with a strong relationship with her manager. She suggests developing a network and maintaining open communication about career aspirations with higher-level management.

Final Thoughts

Katie's insights underscore the dual focus on technical proficiency and interpersonal skills in staff engineering. She advocates for clarity in communication, a strong personal brand within the company, and a commitment to user empathy, stressing that understanding and supporting team dynamics is crucial for success in the role.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 30 Summary : Rick Boone - Strategic Advisor to Uber’s VP of Infrastructure

Ritu Vincent's Role at Dropbox

Ritu Vincent, a Staff Engineer at Dropbox, discusses her journey in tech and her current position where she leads an internal incubator to foster innovation amid growing competition.

Current Role and Responsibilities

- Ritu returned to Dropbox to manage an incubator focused on innovation.
- The incubator involves engineers pitching ideas for funding and support.
- She is part of a permanent scouting team that autonomously develops new concepts.

Staff Engineer Profiles at Dropbox

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

- Two types of Staff Engineers: Tech Leads and Specialists.
- Tech Leads coordinate and drive projects, while Specialists focus on deep technical expertise.

Daily Activities as a Staff Engineer

- Ritu now spends her time prototyping compared to a previous role where she managed teams and worked on recruiting and diversity initiatives.

Making an Impact

- Ritu played a key role in revamping Dropbox's engineering levels, which affected all engineering roles.
- She also worked on complex projects, aiding team growth and confidence.

Advocacy and Sponsorship

Install Bookey App to Unlock Full Text and Audio

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Try Bookey App to read 1000+ summary of world best books

Unlock 1000+ Titles, 80+ Topics

New titles added every week

Brand | Leadership & Collaboration | Time Management | Relationship & Communication

ness Strategy | Creativity | Public | Money & Investing | Know Yourself | Positive P

Entrepreneurship | World History | Parent-Child Communication | Self-care | Mind & Spi

Insights of world best books

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 31 Summary : Nelson Elhage - Formerly Staff Engineer at Stripe

Summary of Chapter 31 - Staff Engineer by Will Larson

Current Role and Responsibilities

Rick Boone serves as the Strategic Advisor to Uber's Vice President of Infrastructure, playing a crucial role within a leadership team of around 700 engineers across various sub-organizations. His responsibilities encompass formulating technical and cultural strategies, assessing technology needs, prioritizing innovation, and facilitating communication between teams.

Comparison to Other Roles

Rick distinguishes his role from that of a Technical Program Manager and Chief of Staff. While Program Managers focus on operational aspects, Rick’s role emphasizes strategic

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

insights and problem-solving on a personal and organizational level, requiring a deep understanding of technology and culture.

Importance of Alignment with Leadership

Rick underscores the necessity of aligning closely with his VP, emphasizing shared values and effective communication. His ability to act as a representative of the VP requires an understanding of the VP's worldview and the ability to advocate for his vision to the engineers.

Mentorship and Sponsorship

Rick finds fulfillment in mentoring engineers, particularly minorities, and holding regular sessions to support new hires. His approach to mentorship stems from recognizing the significant impact mentors have had on his own career.

Career Evolution and Vision

Rick’s path to becoming a Strategic Advisor was unplanned and resulted from positive prior interactions with leadership. Through a mix of fortunate events and alignment with

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

company values, he cemented his role. He is currently focused on fostering relationships and mentoring others while balancing technical interests with organizational needs.

Advice for Aspiring Staff Engineers

Rick advises aspiring Staff Engineers to cultivate their passions beyond technical skills, develop relationships with engineering leadership, and maintain a focus on prioritization amid various responsibilities. Building broad context and understanding organizational dynamics is deemed vital for effective problem-solving and collaboration.

Continuous Learning and Influence

Rick remains active in learning about behavioral science and organizational strategies, recognizing their importance in tech organization dynamics. He emphasizes the significance of cross-team interactions and staying engaged with his engineering background to understand the realities on the ground.

Concluding Thoughts on Role Fulfillment

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Ultimately, Rick's journey reflects a blend of technical acumen, organizational insight, and a commitment to mentorship, demonstrating how personal interests and strategic roles can intertwine effectively in career development within the tech industry.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 32 Summary : Diana Pojar - Staff Data Engineer at Slack

Chapter Summary: Nelson Elhage's Experience as a Staff Engineer at Stripe

Introduction

Nelson Elhage shares insights from his time as a Staff Engineer at Stripe, emphasizing the architecture of payment processing in a rapidly growing technology startup.

Current Role and Team Structure

- Nelson worked on the Payments Architecture team at Stripe, focusing on codebase for payment processing.
- The team, consisting of senior engineers, aimed to enhance financial infrastructure and ensure the architecture supported ongoing expansion across geographical boundaries.

Nature of Staff-plus Engineers at Stripe

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

- Staff-plus Engineers work on significant technical projects and drive initiatives that have organizational impact.
- Their role varies, encompassing deep technical work, cross-cutting architecture projects, and vision management for teams.

Day-to-Day Responsibilities

- Nelson's work varied between coding and project management, emphasizing communication across teams and promoting architectural best practices.
- Tasks included facilitating meetings, tracking tasks, writing design documents, and advocating for architectural improvements to the leadership.

Impact and Influence

- Nelson reflected on the measurable impact of his projects, particularly the Sorbet type checker, which facilitated a major transition in Stripe's coding practices.
- He noted that having a Staff title increased his ability to influence company direction and encouraged mentoring junior engineers.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Advocacy and Sponsorship

- A significant portion of his time was dedicated to advocating for technology and process improvements, highlighting the culture of incident management enhancements.
- Nelson emphasized the importance of lifting others and sponsoring junior engineers to promote a collaborative environment.

Career Progression

- Nelson began at Stripe as an early engineer, gradually building a broad context and awareness of the organization, which aided his rise to Staff Engineer.
- He described not needing a formal "Staff Project," focusing instead on impactful initiatives.

Advice for Aspiring Staff Engineers

- Nelson advises future Staff Engineers to prioritize focus and not get overwhelmed by numerous potential projects.
- He emphasizes building relationships with leadership,

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

understanding organizational dynamics, and developing technical and soft skills.

Concluding Thoughts

- Understanding organizational relationships and effective communication is crucial for a successful transition to a Staff Engineer role.
- Continuous self-assessment and nurturing a global perspective within the company significantly contribute to career growth and effectiveness in the role.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 33 Summary : Dan Na - Staff Engineer and Team Lead at Squarespace

Chapter 33: Insights from Staff Engineers at Slack and Squarespace

Diana Pojar: Staff Data Engineer at Slack

Current Role and Responsibilities

- Diana Pojar, a Staff Data Engineer and Technical Lead at Slack's Data Platform team, joined Slack in February 2016.
- Her role involves building infrastructure for long-term analytics and enabling company-wide access to data for various departments.
- The Data Platform team provides services and frameworks to help process data effectively in the Data Warehouse.

Day-to-Day Activities

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

- Staff-plus engineers focus on strategic projects that add value to the company.
- Responsibilities can range from depth (specialists) to breadth (generalists). Diana prefers a broader focus involving mentorship, technical leadership, and coding.
- Her time is split between technical leadership and hands-on engineering tasks, with changes occurring quarterly based on team needs.

Impact and Trust

- The title of Staff Engineer provides greater influence and respect, allowing for impactful participation in business-critical projects.
- Diana emphasizes the importance of mentoring junior engineers and advocating for their growth.

Advocacy for Change

Install Bookey App to Unlock Full Text and Audio

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Why Bookey is must have App for Book Lovers

30min Content
The deeper and clearer interpretation we provide, the better grasp of each title you have.

Text and Audio format
Absorb knowledge even in fragmented time.

Quiz
Check whether you have mastered what you just learned.

And more
Multiple Voices & fonts, Mind Map, Quotes, IdeaClips...

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 34 Summary : Joy Ebertz - Senior Staff Software Engineer at Split

Chapter 34 Summary: Dan Na - Staff Engineer at Squarespace

Current Role

Dan Na is a Staff Engineer and Team Lead at Squarespace, a platform for building online presences. He oversees the Internationalization Platform team, which focuses on creating localized products through foundational internationalization tools.

Responsibilities of a Staff-plus Engineer

At Squarespace, Staff-plus engineers have varied responsibilities based on their role. Dan's position includes accountability for his team's output, engaging with multiple stakeholders to align the team's roadmap with business priorities, and reviewing technical documents. His role has

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

shifted from hands-on coding to strategic oversight.

Impact as a Staff-plus Engineer

Dan feels impactful by participating in higher-level engineering discussions that address broader technical and non-technical issues. He acknowledges the importance of owning challenges that affect engineering output, including strategy and culture, and leveraging his title for credibility in discussions.

Advocacy and Influence

Dan doesn't categorize advocacy, focusing instead on improving the engineering team and product. He created initiatives like pairing engineering staff for coffee chats and a book club for Engineering Management, promoting collaboration and support among engineers.

Promotion to Staff Engineer

Dan was promoted from Senior Software Engineer II after contributing to significant projects and initiatives. He balanced technical contributions with cultural initiatives,

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

facilitating his manager's case for promotion to the Staff level.

Advice for New Staff Engineers

For those starting as Staff engineers, Dan emphasizes that advancement requires a broader focus on engineering outputs and responsibilities, moving from technical expertise to leadership and mentoring.

Importance of Sponsorship

Dan believes that sponsoring others is vital for growth within an engineering team. He highlights the importance of giving opportunities for exposure, encouraging contributions to discussions, and recognizing achievements.

Reflection on Management vs. Technical Roles

Having contemplated engineering management, Dan values the overlap in responsibilities between management and Staff roles, emphasizing mentorship and broader technical vision, while still enjoying his technical contributions.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Learning from Others

Dan draws inspiration from various colleagues and resources, appreciating the diverse perspectives and learning opportunities that arise from collaboration and engagement with others in the field.

This chapter provides insights into the responsibilities and impact of Staff Engineers like Dan Na at Squarespace, highlighting the evolution of roles, the importance of collaboration, and the balance between leadership and technical expertise.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 35 Summary : Damian Schenkelman - Principal Engineer at Auth0

Summary of Chapter 35 from "Staff Engineer" by Will Larson

Joy Ebertz's Current Role

Joy Ebertz is a Senior Staff Software Engineer at Split.io, focusing on the backend for their Center of Excellence (COE) team. Split is known for its feature flagging and experimentation framework, enabling customers to separate deployment from release in CI/CD and conduct A/B testing. Her team handles the main business logic, data storage, and APIs of the web application.

Staff-plus Engineer Responsibilities

Ebertz describes her current ramp-up phase as a new employee, spending half to three-quarters of her time on

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

tasks within her scrum team, while also engaging in long-term architecture and strategy discussions. She recently took on leadership of the backend chapter, prioritizing technical vision, tech projects, and standards discussions.

Impact and Ownership

Ebertz feels impactful when she helps establish a clear technical vision, encouraging a shared understanding among her colleagues. She highlights the transformation in her ownership and accountability, taking on roles and responsibilities that were previously seen as someone else's tasks.

Advocating for Change

A significant aspect of her role involves advocating for technology, processes, and architectural changes. Ebertz has successfully pushed for improvements in their email notification system and participated in redesigning authorization frameworks.

Sponsoring Other Engineers

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Ebertz emphasizes the importance of sponsoring growth opportunities for other engineers, such as recommending them for leadership roles and encouraging their development.

Promotion Process at Box

Joy shares her journey to becoming a Staff Engineer at Box, explaining the promotion process that involved submitting a promotion case supported by managerial recommendations. This involved a committee review that emphasized context-driven evaluations.

Key Factors in Career Advancement

Ebertz identifies company culture, visibility, and opportunities as significant factors in her career progression. She stresses the importance of being known for one’s work and actively participating in discussions to enhance visibility.

Advice for Aspiring Staff Engineers

Joy advises new Staff Engineers to focus on amplifying their strengths, maintaining patience as they transition into broader roles, and emphasizing effective communication. She

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

highlights the importance of documenting processes as a way to scale their influence.

Consideration of Engineering Management

Ebertz briefly considered management but found it was not her preferred path. However, her management experience enriched her understanding of organizational dynamics.

Learning and Inspiration

Ebertz draws inspiration from various sources and relationships at different levels within her organization. She appreciates learning from both peers and junior team members alike, emphasizing that every interaction has the potential for growth.

Conclusion

Joy Ebertz's insights reflect the multifaceted responsibilities and impactful strategies of a Staff Engineer. She emphasizes vision-setting, team sponsorship, advocacy for improvement, and the importance of ongoing learning as key components of achieving success in senior engineering roles.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 36 Summary : Dmitry Petrashko - Tech Advisor to the Head of Infra at Stripe

Section	Summary
Current Role and Responsibilities	Damian Schenkelman is a Principal Engineer at Auth0, focusing on strategic initiatives, technical strategy, architecture decisions, and guidelines in the Systems Architecture group.
Differences in Roles	Staff Engineers lead teams in specific domains, while Schenkelman operates in "breadth mode," overseeing technical strategy and leading the Design and Architecture workgroup (DNA).
Daily Activities	His week includes numerous meetings, 1:1s with managers, and team discussions, while he reserves time for strategic planning and documentation.
Impactful Contributions	Schenkelman believes his greatest impact comes from influencing the company's direction and aligning teams on common goals rather than solving individual technical issues.
Challenges and Opportunities	He notes the challenge of clarity in fast-growing companies and advocates for documented technical strategies to assist decision-making.
Sponsoring Engineers	Sponsoring engineers is vital; he helps others grow while maintaining a balance between mentorship and sponsorship.
Path to Principal Engineer	Starting as one of Auth0's early engineers, he moved from Director of Engineering to Principal Engineer through mentoring and leading initiatives.
Advice for New Staff Engineers	He advises defining expectations early, being patient, and focusing on impactful communication, with documentation as key to scaling influence.
Considerations on Management	Schenkelman valued the individual contributor role over management, preferring the impact he can have while learning management skills.
Learning Resources	He seeks inspiration from influential figures and educational materials covering both technical and management aspects, emphasizing continuous learning and collaboration.

Summary of Chapter 36: Damian Schenkelman - Principal Engineer at Auth0

Current Role and Responsibilities

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Damian Schenkelman is a Principal Engineer at Auth0, an Identity as a Service platform, working in the Systems Architecture group. His team focuses on strategic initiatives, technical strategy, architecture decisions, and guidelines. Schenkelman serves as a tech lead for a major product feature in Identity and Access Management (IAM) and drives reliability and scaling initiatives across various teams.

Differences in Roles

At Auth0, Staff Engineers typically lead teams in a specific domain, contributing to various initiatives. Schenkelman, as a Principal Engineer, operates in "breadth mode," overseeing technical strategy and leading the Design and Architecture workgroup (DNA), which establishes guidelines and decisions for technology direction.

Install Bookey App to Unlock Full Text and Audio

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

App Store
Editors' Choice

22k 5 star review

Positive feedback

Sara Scholz

tes after each book summary
erstanding but also make the
and engaging. Bookey has
ding for me.

Fantastic!!!

Masood El Toure

I'm amazed by the variety of books and languages Bookey supports. It's not just an app, it's a gateway to global knowledge. Plus, earning points for charity is a big plus!

Fi
Ab
bo
to
my

José Botín

ding habit
p's design
ual growth

Love it!

Wonnie Tappkx

Bookey offers me time to go through the important parts of a book. It also gives me enough idea whether or not I should purchase the whole book version or not! It is easy to use!

Time saver!

Bookey is my go-to app for
summaries are concise, ins
curated. It's like having acc
right at my fingertips!

Awesome app!

Rahul Malviya

I love audiobooks but don't always have time to listen to the entire book! bookey allows me to get a summary of the highlights of the book I'm interested in!!! What a great concept !!!highly recommended!

Beautiful App

Alex Walk

This app is a lifesaver for book lovers with busy schedules. The summaries are spot on, and the mind maps help reinforce wh I've learned. Highly recommend!

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 37 Summary : Stephen Wan - Staff Engineer at Samsara

Chapter Summary: Dmitry Petrashko - Tech Advisor at Stripe

Current Role and Responsibilities

Dmitry Petrashko serves as a Staff Engineer and Technical Advisor to the Head of Infrastructure at Stripe. His team is responsible for foundational infrastructure services, which includes computing, networking, storage, databases, data engineering, performance, efficiency, observability services, and developer tools. His task is to empower Stripe engineers by enhancing developer productivity through the development of tools and processes.

Role of a Staff-plus Engineer at Stripe

At Stripe, being a Staff Engineer is not just a role but a level indicating expectations regarding impact, communication,

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

and leadership. Dmitry's current focus as a Technical Advisor involves researching critical topics, brainstorming technical solutions, and assisting in urgent technical matters without making direct technical decisions.

Day-to-Day Activities

On an ideal week, Dmitry spends time in meetings and collaborative sessions on Mondays, Wednesdays, and Fridays, while coding on Tuesdays and Thursdays. He emphasizes the need to maintain coding practices to stay connected with engineering demands and balance business priorities.

Impact as a Staff Engineer

Dmitry identifies significant impact in improving project proposals, helping teams refocus on opportunities, and ensuring alignment with engineering constraints. He affirms that he has consistently enabled engineers to undertake impactful projects, which enhances their professional development.

Advocacy for Technical Change

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

He has been an advocate for introducing type-checking and improving reliability at Stripe, emphasizing the importance of affective communication and strategic alignment with organizational needs. Dmitry's involvement in projects is typically early-stage, where he aims to develop future leaders.

Connections with Team and Engineers

Dmitry remains in touch with engineering realities by engaging with internal customers and gathering feedback through surveys. He often participates in informal discussions to learn about the challenges engineers face, thereby ensuring that his advisory role is informed by the actual needs of teams.

Sponsorship of Engineers

Dmitry values sponsoring fellow engineers, helping them to take up new opportunities and responsibilities. He distinguishes between mentorship and sponsorship, viewing both as crucial for empowering others and driving organizational effectiveness.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Professional Growth and Transition to Staff Engineer

He was not initially hired as a Staff Engineer and had to undergo promotional evaluations to reach that level. Dmitry highlights the significance of impact-focused work, collaboration, and technical knowledge in his journey. He expressed that other influences, including his educational background in building maintainable compilers, have shaped his approach to engineering at scale.

Reflections on Leadership and Management

Dmitry does not personally pursue engineering management, as he believes in making a greater impact through individual contribution. However, he acknowledges the advantages of learning management skills in enhancing his effectiveness as a Staff Engineer.

Advice for Aspiring Staff Engineers

He advises new Staff Engineers to clearly understand their role's impact and maintain open communication regarding

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

compromises. Dmitry underscores the importance of addressing interpersonal aspects alongside technical work to be truly effective in delivering results.

Final Thoughts

Contributions to impactful projects and collaboration with other engineers remain critical themes in his narrative, reinforcing the importance of continuous learning, adaptability, and connection within technical fields. Dmitry's experience serves as a guide for those aspiring to grow within their technical careers while actively engaging in organizational growth and development.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 38 Summary : Additional resources on Staff-plus engineering

Resources

Additional Resources on Staff-plus Engineering

Many Staff Engineers credit their success to networking and extensive reading. This chapter provides a curated list of resources to aid in professional development.

Your Network

Peer networks and mentors are invaluable for Staff-plus engineers. If you have limited time for personal development, focus on building connections with colleagues in similar roles. Recommended Slack community: **#staff-principal-engineering** in Rands Leadership.

What Do Staff-plus Engineers Do?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Key writings include:
- *Being a Principal Engineer* by Nicky Wrightson
- *Defining a Distinguished Engineer* by Jessie Frazelle
- *An Engineer's Role at Heroku* by Amy Unger
- Various other insights from recognized leaders in engineering, including Tanya Reilly and Joy Ebertz.

Becoming a Staff-plus Engineer

Resources outline the transition to Staff Engineer roles and include interviews and guidance from industry leaders. Notable mentions:
- *Becoming a Technical Leader* by Gerald Weinberg
- *How does one become a Staff Software Engineer at Google?*

Books

Although many Staff engineers value personal mentorship, several influential books have been recommended:
- *Accelerate* by Forsgren, Humble, and Kim
- *A Philosophy of Software Design* by John Ousterhout
- *The Pragmatic Programmer* by Hunt and Thomas

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

- *The Phoenix Project* by Kim, Behr, and Spafford

Talks

Staff-plus engineers find giving talks more beneficial than attending them. Noteworthy resources for talks include:
- Cindy Sridharan's blog summarizing annual tech talks.

Papers

While not all staff engineers read extensively from academic papers, foundational papers are important. Begin with summaries like Adrian Colyer’s *the morning paper* and advance to recommended papers, such as:
- *Dynamo* by Amazon
- *Bigtable*
- *Kafka*

Other Nice Things

Additional valuable resources that provide insights into industry practices:
- Both *Testing in Production* guides by Cindy Sridharan.
- Candid reflections and analyses by industry professionals.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Feel free to share more resources that could enhance this collection!

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Chapter 39 Summary : Where do Staff-plus engineers fit into the org?

Additional Resources on Staff-Plus Engineering

Networking as a Key Resource

Staff-plus engineers emphasize the importance of networking, often crediting it as their most valuable learning resource. Building relationships with peers and mentors can significantly enhance professional development. A recommended Slack community for this purpose is #staff-principal-engineering in the Rands Leadership Slack.

Recommended Reads and Resources

A variety of articles and writings from various engineers are highlighted, discussing their experiences and roles as Staff engineers, such as:
- "Being a Principal Engineer" by Nicky Wrightson
- "Defining a Distinguished Engineer" by Jessie Frazelle

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

- "Operating as a Staff Engineer at Heroku" by Amy Unger
- "The Nuts and Bolts" by Tanya Reilly

Various resources covering becoming a Staff-plus engineer include interviews with professionals and articles on team dynamics and technical decision-making.

Books of Note

Although many staff engineers don’t read extensively, specific books have been cited as impactful, including:

- "A Philosophy of Software Design" by John Ousterhout
- "Accelerate" by Forsgren, Humble, and Kim
- "High Output Management" by Andy Grove
- "The Phoenix Project" by Kim, Behr, and Spafford

Additional lists of recommended books can be found in various sources, enhancing one's understanding of engineering practices.

Install Bookey App to Unlock Full Text and Audio

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Read, Share, Empower

Finish Your Reading Challenge, Donate Books to African Children.

The Concept

BOOKS FOR AFRICA × ×

This book donation activity is rolling out together with Books For Africa. We release this project because we share the same belief as BFA: For many children in Africa, the gift of books truly is a gift of hope.

The Rule

Earn 100 points → **Redeem a book** → **Donate to Africa**

Your learning not only brings knowledge but also allows you to earn points for charitable causes! For every 100 points you earn, a book will be donated to Africa.

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 40 Summary : Managing Staff-plus engineers

Staff-Plus Engineers in Organizational Design

Organizational Mathematics

In designing engineering organizations, each team ideally has one manager and six to eight engineers. Managers of managers should support four to six managers. These numbers help establish a functional organizational structure, yet challenges arise in determining where senior engineers should report.

Common Reporting Configurations

1.
Tech Leads
: Usually report to a manager of one team; sometimes to a manager of multiple teams.
  - Example: Dan Na reported to the manager for the

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Internationalization Platform.

2.
Architects
: Typically report to a senior manager or a manager of managers, often responsible for horizontal slices in their area.
- Example: Keavy McMinn reported to the CTO.

3.
Solvers
: Commonly found in companies with a “weak team concept”; reporting hierarchies may be less defined.
- Example: Ritu Vincent worked in an incubator reporting to the CEO.

4.
Right Hands
: Report to a senior leader, often overseeing large teams.
- Example: Rick Boone reported to the VP of Infrastructure; Michelle Bu reported to the Chief Product Officer.

Understanding how these archetypes fit into reporting structures can help clarify organizational design.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

The Office of the CTO

This setup usually includes two to eight Staff-plus engineers who report directly to the CTO or CEO, primarily without much management support. This configuration often arises to address organizational problems, such as mistrust or lack of delegation by the CTO. It’s important to recognize that implementing this early may indicate avoidance of underlying issues.

Managing Staff-Plus Engineers

Key strategies for effectively managing Staff-plus engineers include:

1. **Sponsor and Support**
: Shift from directing to supporting, allowing them autonomy.

2. **Rewire Definition of Success**
: Help them understand the longer-term nature of their roles compared to immediate feedback loops.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

3.

Frequent Feedback

: Offer consistent, honest feedback about their priorities and direction.

4.

Keep Informed

: Actively share information to keep them updated and supported in decision-making.

5.

Engage in Planning

: Involve them in discussions about prioritization to foster alignment with business needs.

6.

Agree on Independence

: Clarify how they can operate independently while remaining aligned with leadership.

7.

Create Space for Thought

: Balance between urgent tasks and time for deeper work output.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

8.

Role Model Responsibility

: Remind them they set examples for others in the organization.

9.

Minimize Managerial Overflow

: Avoid overloading Staff-plus engineers with managerial tasks to sustain focus.

10.

Delegate Broadly

: Encourage them to define problems and solutions rather than providing specific directives.

11.

Cede Leadership Space

: Enable them to hold their teams accountable for technical quality.

12.

Appreciate Contributions

: Recognize the independence and contributions of Staff-plus

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

engineers regularly.

13.
Alignment with Business Goals
: Ensure they understand the relevance of their technical work to business objectives.

14.
Increase Accountability
: Provide constructive feedback on leadership development and hold them to higher standards.

15.
Facilitate Meeting Management
: Be strategic about meeting attendance for efficiency.
Supporting Staff-plus engineers requires a balance of guidance, autonomy, and alignment with business needs. Understanding these dynamics can lead to a more effective and productive organization.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 41 Summary : Designing a Staff-plus interview loop

Managing Staff-plus Engineers

While gathering feedback on "Staff Engineer," a common request emerged for more guidance on managing Staff-plus engineers. Although this topic doesn't fit the primary theme—focusing on the engineers themselves rather than the company or manager—it's essential and worth discussing as an appendix.

Differences in Management Approach

Effective management of Staff-plus engineers differs from that of Senior engineers, with strategies influenced by company-specific Staff archetypes. Here are critical approaches to managing Staff-plus engineers effectively:

Sponsor and Support Over Direct

- Staff engineers shouldn't require daily direction but need

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

sponsorship and feedback for growth.
- Help redefine their success metrics, acknowledging that their impact is often less immediate compared to team members in product roles.

Provide Frequent Feedback

- Consistent feedback is vital for their growth, especially regarding their priorities and battles.

Keep Them Informed

- Share organizational context as they may have limited access to information compared to managers.
- Consider using chat channels or weekly updates for sharing context.

Involve Them in Planning

- Participation in planning helps them understand the priorities and advocate for the necessary technical work.

Align While Allowing Independence

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

- As Staff-plus engineers take on leadership roles, they will sometimes surprise their managers. Establish alignment while empowering them to lead independently.

Create Space for Reflection

- Encourage time for deep thinking while ensuring they stay connected to day-to-day realities.
- Balance firefighting tasks with time for strategic thinking.

Model Positive Behavior

- Remind them of their role as a model for others, encouraging them to embody the organization's values.

Minimize Managerial Overflow

- Limit transferring management responsibilities to Staff-plus engineers, aiming for temporary overflow only.

Assign Unrefined Problems

- Allow Staff-plus engineers to define the problem space, leveraging their judgment for meaningful solutions.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Cede Leadership Space

- Empower them with ownership over their teams to foster leverage and responsibility.

Express Appreciation

- Regularly show up for one-on-ones to maintain their engagement and reaffirm their value during crises.

Align with Business Goals

- Ensure their technical work aligns with business priorities to reinforce their leadership role.

Hold Them Accountable

- Provide honest feedback about leadership and behavioral gaps, supporting their development toward meeting full role expectations.

Facilitate Access without Status Inflations

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

- Avoid treating meeting attendance as a status symbol; instead, distribute attendance to optimize time.

Supporting Transition from Senior to Staff-plus

- This transition represents a major shift in responsibilities, and managers can help ease this adjustment through the aforementioned strategies.

Designing a Staff-plus Interview Loop

When designing an interview process for Staff-plus engineers, recognizing the unique challenges in assessing this role is crucial.

Common Challenges

Many existing loops fail by confusing the qualifications of senior engineers with those of Staff-plus engineers. This can lead to misaligned expectations and ineffective assessments.

Critical Signals to Capture

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Focus on signals important for identifying successful Staff-plus engineers, including:

- **Self-awareness**: Accountability and demonstrated growth.
- **Judgment**: Ability to navigate complex challenges creatively.
- **Collaboration**: Partnership capability across various levels and departments.
- **Communication**: Effectiveness in sharing ideas and facilitating understanding.
- **Development**: Commitment to growing the organizational capability around them.

Interview Formats and Structures

Effective interview formats should assess critical skills and

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

behaviors required for daily success. Recommended formats include:

- **Structured Presentations**: For evaluating structured thinking and communication.
- **Code Reviews**: Assessing feedback quality for empathy and clarity.
- **Mentorship Panels**: Observing potential in mentoring through real discussions.

Evolving the Process

Designing an interview loop involves continually refining it based on data and candidate feedback to ensure its effectiveness. Engage with peers to uncover insights on their innovative approaches.

Conclusion

While the guidance provided is a starting point for managing and assessing Staff-plus engineers, ongoing refinement and adaptation will bolster your effectiveness in these leadership roles.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 42 Summary : Staff-plus career ladders

Designing a Staff-plus Interview Loop

Introduction

Designing an effective interview loop for Staff-plus engineers is challenging, with confidence lacking in existing processes. Many loops erroneously seek senior engineers who are quick problem solvers, while others focus solely on communication skills. A few attempt to assess candidates' fit within the existing team instead of evaluating their capabilities.

Challenges in Interviewing

1. **Misidentifying Roles**
: Many loops equate Staff-plus engineers to enhanced Senior engineers, misjudging their skills and responsibilities.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

2.

Inflated Titles

: Companies may inflate titles without adjusting role expectations, leading to confusion about actual responsibilities.

3.

Familiarity Bias

: Interviewers may prefer candidates who align closely with the existing team's dynamics, which can overshadow a candidate's actual potential.

4.

Undervaluation of Skills

: Earlier career interviewers often struggle to recognize the strengths of Staff-plus candidates, focusing instead on performance comparable to mid-level engineers.

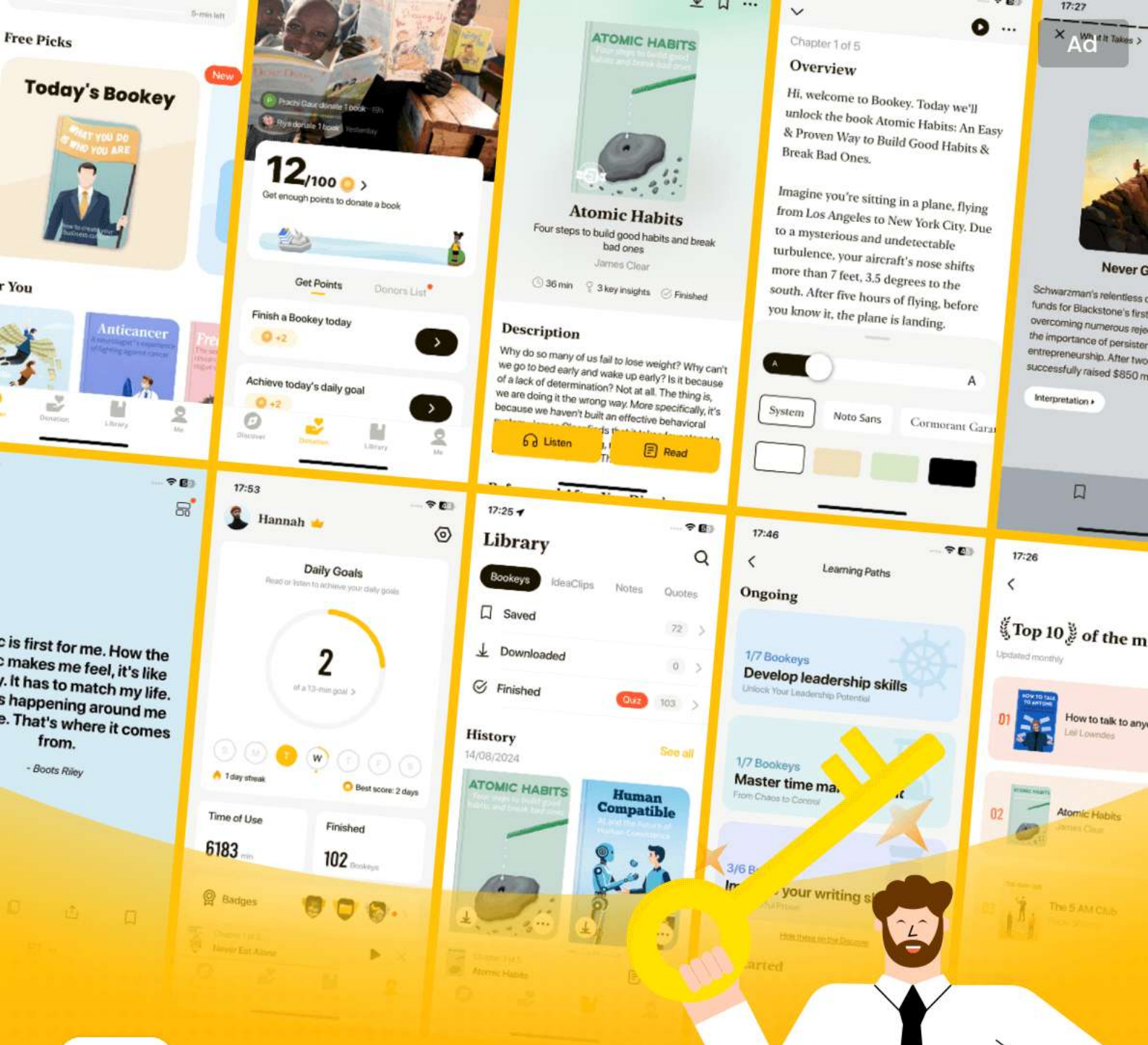
Important Signals to Assess

Install Bookey App to Unlock Full Text and Audio

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It



World' best ideas unlock your potential

Free Trial with Bookey

Scan to download

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play

Best Quotes from Staff Engineer by Will Larson with Page Numbers

View on Bookey Website and Generate Beautiful Quote Images

Chapter 1 | Quotes From Pages 2-4

1. Every one of those stories is a unique voice and well worth reading.
2. The cover illustration is by Luciana Guerra, harkening back to old nautical maps where sailors navigated through the same uncertainty that currently obscures the role of Staff engineer.
3. I’m equally grateful to the folks who contributed stories to staffeng.com, whose stories aren’t in this book.
4. Tanya Reilly’s foreword is amazing, and I’m eagerly waiting for Tanya to publish the canonical book on Staff engineering that replaces this one.

Chapter 2 | Quotes From Pages 5-13

1. The skills and behaviours we require from our role model engineers will have a direct impact on the code we write, the algorithms we deploy, the

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

decisions we make, and the patterns we consider acceptable.

2. As our industry matures and tackles ever-bigger problems, more and more companies are recognising the need for engineers who have 'seen some things' to drive technical strategies, lead projects that cross teams and organisations, and raise everybody's game by modeling what good engineering looks like.
3. Success will often mean interpreting business needs, communicating a clear direction, defusing a looming crisis, convincing teams to agree on tradeoffs, or just being a good influence.

Chapter 3 | Quotes From Pages 14-26

1. For engineers who have chosen the 'technical leadership' career path, building skills can often mean feeling like you're in the wrong room.
2. Success will often mean interpreting business needs, communicating a clear direction, defusing a looming crisis, convincing teams to agree on trade-offs, or just being a

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

good influence.

3. This isn’t intentional neglect: managers just don’t always know how to support their most senior engineers.
4. I hope to write a book about infrastructure engineering one day, but I’m trying to spend less time thinking about infrastructure for the next few years.
5. I hope Staff Engineer helps you refine your vision of what technical leadership can be, and how you can grow towards that vision.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

Download Bookey App to enjoy

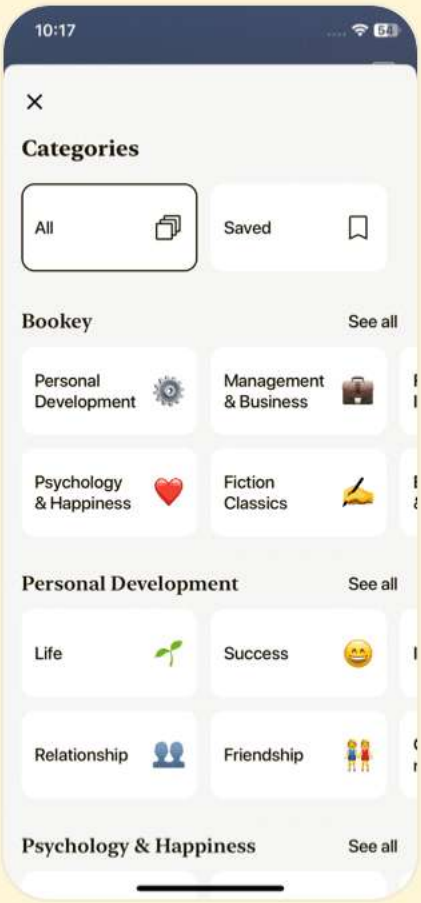
1 Million+ Quotes

1000+ Book Summaries

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 4 | Quotes From Pages 28-41

1. If you aim for such a role, I hope this book will provide pragmatic aid in its pursuit.
2. The Tech Lead role is, for many folks, their first experience as a Staff engineer.
3. Success in these roles requires remaining engaged; it's essential to understand what kinds of work energize you.
4. This taxonomy is more focused on being useful than complete, but so far, I've been able to fit every Staff-plus engineer I've spoken to into one of these categories.
5. The Architect role tends to evolve in relatively large companies, companies with exceptionally complex or coupled codebases, and companies that are struggling to repay the technical debt they created in their initial sprint to product-market fit.

Chapter 5 | Quotes From Pages 42-63

1. Most career ladders define a single, uniform set of expectations for Staff engineers operating within the company.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

2. The role of a Staff-plus engineer depends a lot on what the team needs and also what the particular engineer's strengths are.
3. Technology cannot speak for itself and requires effective advocates on its behalf.
4. You're far more likely to change your company's long-term trajectory by growing the engineers around you than through personal heroics.
5. The impact and the personal growth lives in those longer timeframes.

Chapter 6 | Quotes From Pages 64-82

1. From my experience, the responsibilities of a Staff-plus engineer can change over time. Still, usually, their main focus is working on projects/efforts that have strategic value for the company while driving technical design and up-leveling their team.
2. Much as the Lorax speaks for the trees in his popular children's book, Staff engineers speak for their companies'

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

technology. Technology cannot speak for itself and requires effective advocates on its behalf.

3. The best way to grow those around you is by creating an active practice of mentorship and sponsorship.
4. In earlier roles, you may have tried to influence decisions towards technology choices you were motivated by; in senior positions, you’re accountable to the business and organization first and yourself second.
5. The impact and the personal growth lives in those longer timeframes, and while everyone I spoke with wished they’d occasionally get more time to code, and admitted worrying some days that they weren’t accomplishing much, none of them regretted their transition into their current roles.
6. If you’re more focused on hitting Staff than on setting yourself up to do work that energizes you, it’s easy to end up stuck in a role you don’t want.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

Download Bookey App to enjoy

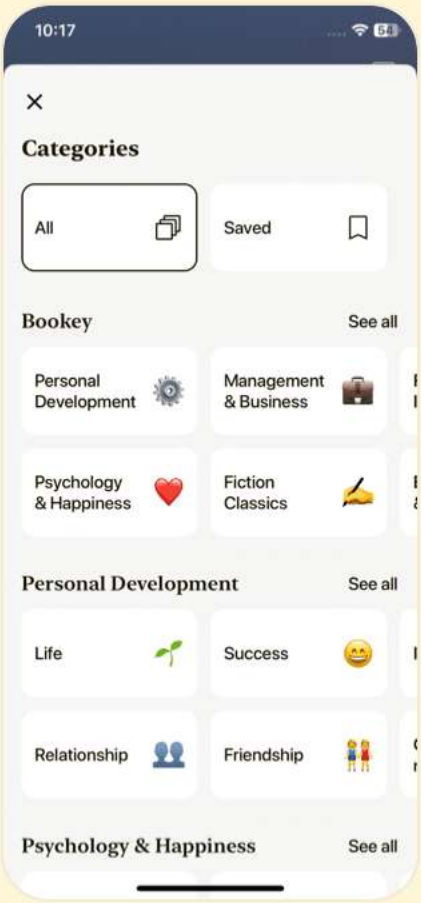
1 Million+ Quotes

1000+ Book Summaries

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 7 | Quotes From Pages 84-99

1. There’s a misconception that you become a Staff engineer and then you’ll be in control of the work you do, and everyone will listen to you and do what you want them to do. That’s absolutely the opposite of what happens!" - Katie Sylor-Miller
2. Finding energizing work is what has kept me at Stripe for so long, pursuing impactful work." - Michelle Bu
3. To lead, you have to follow. Having a vivid sense of how things ought to work is a powerful leadership tool, but it’s also essential to learn to blend your vision with the visions from your peers and leadership.
4. Your early wins will slowly get eroded by indifference and misalignment, and your initial impact will be reclaimed by the sands of time.
5. Time spent getting work finished is always time well spent.
6. Teaching a company to value something it doesn’t care about is the hardest sort of work you can do, and it often fails, so you should do as little of it as you can, but no less.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 8 | Quotes From Pages 100-123

1. Finding energizing work is what has kept me at Stripe for so long, pursuing impactful work.
2. Only through pacing your career to your life can you sustain yourself for the long-term.
3. Stop snacking... There's a tremendous opportunity cost versus doing something higher impact.
4. If you're not deliberately tracking your work, it's easy to catch yourself doing little to no high-impact work.
5. Nothing else will matter if it doesn't get addressed.
6. One area that's often underinvested in is growing the team around you.
7. Time spent getting work finished is always time well spent.
8. Focus on work that matters, do projects that develop you, and steer towards companies that value genuine experience.

Chapter 9 | Quotes From Pages 124-164

1. Few companies understand their engineering strategy and vision.
2. Good engineering strategy is boring, and it's easier to write

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

an effective strategy than a bad one.

3. When the future’s too hazy to identify investments worth making, it’s time to write another vision.
4. Write five design documents and pull the similarities out. That’s your engineering strategy.
5. Good strategies guide tradeoffs and explain the rationale behind that guidance.
6. Start where you are.
7. Be opinionated. Good strategies are opinionated.
8. Measure technical quality to guide deeper investment.
9. Don't hoard impact.
10. Start small and add slowly.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

Download Bookey App to enjoy

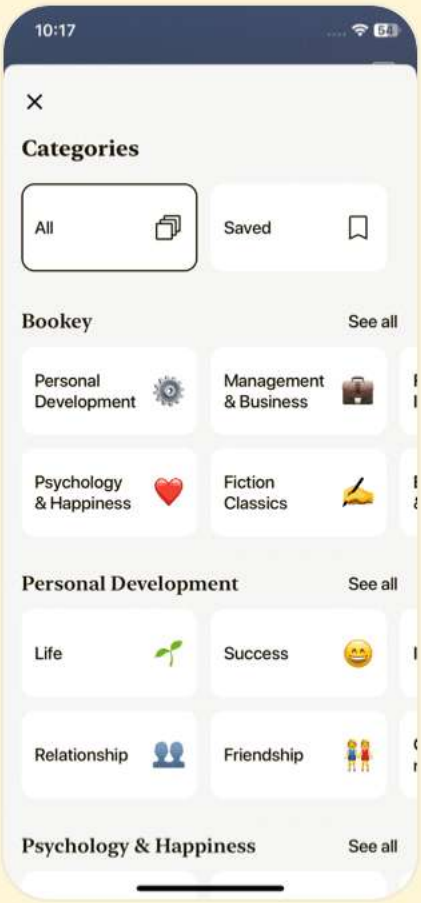
1 Million+ Quotes

1000+ Book Summaries

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 10 | Quotes From Pages 165-200

1. In such cases, having a well-structured plan can help substantially reduce the scope while getting to most of the value, and thus demonstrate impact sooner." - Dmitry Petrashko
2. When you accept the premise that low technical quality results from poor decision-making, you start looking for bad judgment, and someone at the company must be the culprit.
3. Closing the gap between your current and target technical quality is a routine, essential part of effective engineering leadership.
4. Technical quality is a long-term game. There’s no such thing as winning, only learning and earning the chance to keep playing.
5. A rushed process is a failed process.
6. Do fewer things, but do them better.
7. The program isn’t the goal. The goal is to create technical quality.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 11 | Quotes From Pages 201-212

1. To lead, you have to follow.
2. The most effective leaders spend more time following than they do leading.
3. You couldn't be an effective long-term leader until you learn how to follow.
4. What you can accomplish alone is far from what you can accomplish by creating leaders.

Chapter 12 | Quotes From Pages 213-224

1. To lead, you have to follow.
2. The most effective leaders spend more time following than they do leading.
3. To be a great leader, take your time learning to follow.
4. I’ve never seen that style work well.
5. The most effective engineers go into each meeting with the goal of agreeing on the problem at hand, understanding the needs and perspectives within the room, and identifying what needs to happen to align on an approach.
6. If these behaviors don’t come naturally to you, that’s okay;

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

the opportunity to practice is all around.

7. More complex projects get derailed by personal conflict than by technical complexity.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

Download Bookey App to enjoy

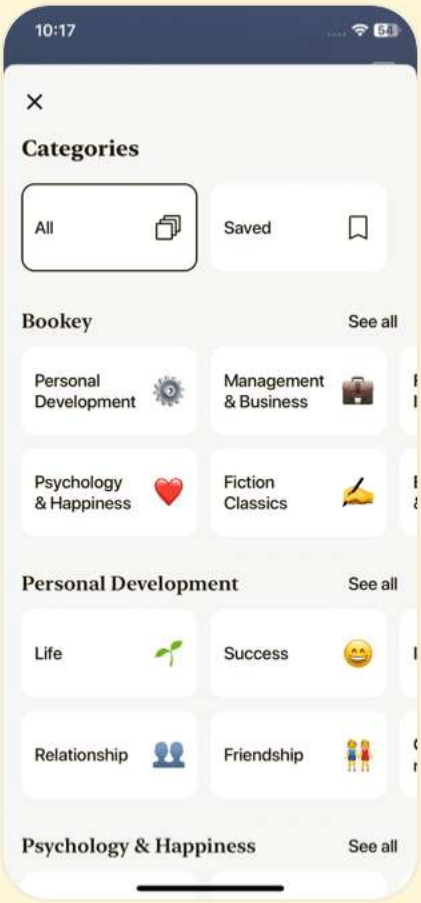
1 Million+ Quotes

1000+ Book Summaries

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 13 | Quotes From Pages 225-239

1. Learn to never be wrong." - Keavy McMinn
2. Create space for others." - Michelle Bu
3. Change your mind.
4. If you want to avoid that fate, learn to never be wrong and never stop practicing.
5. What could be both successful with and grown by this work?

Chapter 14 | Quotes From Pages 240-254

1. One of the best measures of your long-term success as a Staff-plus engineer is that the organization around you increasingly benefits from, but doesn’t rely upon, your contributions.
2. When you’re focused on maximizing your personal impact, a good discussion is one that ends quickly with a reasonable answer, alignment among the participants, and positive feelings among the participants.
3. Change your mind. One of the biggest signs of respect for your coworkers is listening to them and then changing your

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

mind afterward.

4. Instead of involving them in your work, make the work theirs.
5. Build a network of peers.

Chapter 15 | Quotes From Pages 255-271

1. What's been most impactful for me is having a lot of people who I think of as mentors, usually friends, former managers, and folks that I've worked with. I have a decent number of recurring monthly lunches, coffee chats, and dinners with people who've worked with me in the past, know me, and I trust. It's those conversations about career challenges and growth that have gotten me to where I am in my career.
2. The thing that springs to mind is to find your peers or support network. Just like management, it gets lonely the higher up you go, and it's important to find peers that will still challenge you, and you can brainstorm ideas with.
3. When you have personal connections, you can get very

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

unvarnished views of the problems people are seeing and the solutions they're considering.

4. Rather than focusing on public speaking and writing, Katie Sylor-Miller's networking advice was to build your internal network within your current company. Networking, networking, networking, you have to be really cognizant of who you're talking to and make sure that you have connections across multiple teams and multiple groups to leverage those networks.
5. If the idea of building a network this way feels uncomfortable, then building an ambient network can be a good starting step in the right direction.
6. Instead, focus on slowly building with folks you genuinely trust, respect, and are inspired by. That's what'll create a truly powerful network to help you solve the hardest problems and trickiest situations that come your way.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

Download Bookey App to enjoy

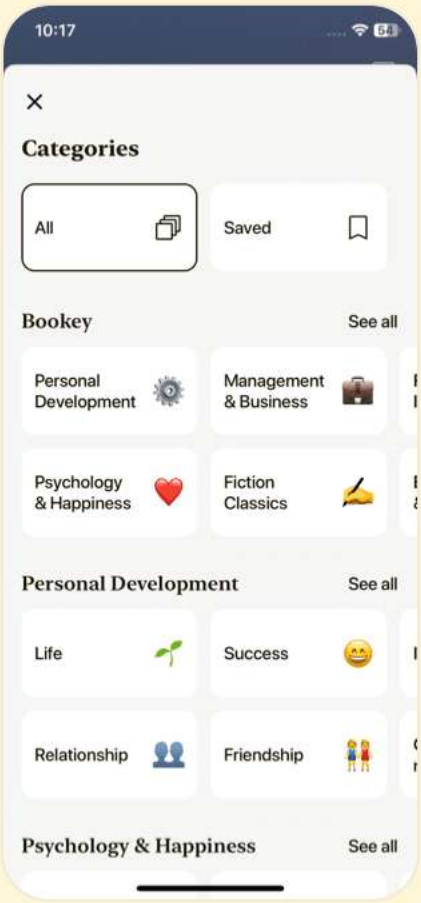
1 Million+ Quotes

1000+ Book Summaries

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 16 | Quotes From Pages 273-286

1. The best advice I've heard is that often reaching Staff is a combination of luck, timing, and work." - Bert Fan
2. Sometimes the folks who already have Staff engineer titles are protective of diluting their prestige.
3. A Staff engineer isn't a better Senior engineer, but someone who's moved into fulfilling one of the Staff archetypes.
4. If pursuing that sort of role is your goal, then take the promotion to your career level as an opportunity to reset your approach to navigating your career.
5. Your promotion packet is your foundational tool to demystify the Staff promotion, prioritize the right personal development, and activate your internal sponsors and network in support of your progression.
6. Opportunity is unevenly distributed.
7. If you want to give management a try, you should.
8. You can only change a system with sponsorship from

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

within.

9. Temper your expectations. Promotions, especially at this level, are built over quarters, halves, and years.
10. It takes a certain amount of fortitude to try again and again after many rounds of feedback.

Chapter 17 | Quotes From Pages 287-299

1. Some folks think of their promotion packet as the capstone of reaching a Staff-plus role, but I've seen many folks succeed by taking the opposite approach: starting to write their first Staff promotion packet long before they think they're likely to be promoted to Staff, much the way they might use a brag document.
2. It's useful to spend some time to write out those answers yourself, but getting promoted into a leadership role isn't a solo activity – it's something you can only accomplish with a team of folks supporting you along the way.
3. A mistake I made early on in my one-on-ones was telling my manager what I thought they wanted to hear, instead of

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

what I actually felt.

4. Promotions, especially at this level, are built over quarters, halves, and years. Avoid the expectation of instant results.
5. Finding your sponsor... this is the person speaking up for your work in forums of influence and when advocating for constrained resources.
6. Don’t play team games alone; you’ll lose.
7. Activating your sponsor... is about facilitating those things happening.

Chapter 18 | Quotes From Pages 300-315

1. Don’t play team games alone, you’ll lose.” - Julia Grace
2. I’m looking to be recognized as a Staff engineer.” - Ritu Vincent
3. If I don’t get promoted this cycle, what are some of the likely causes?
4. You’ll cheat yourself if you immediately try to switch teams or companies after running into friction with your manager.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

5. There isn’t an explicit expectation, nor is it listed anywhere as a formal requirement, but it is understood that you’ll complete a Staff Project to get promoted.” - Ritu Vincent

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

Download Bookey App to enjoy

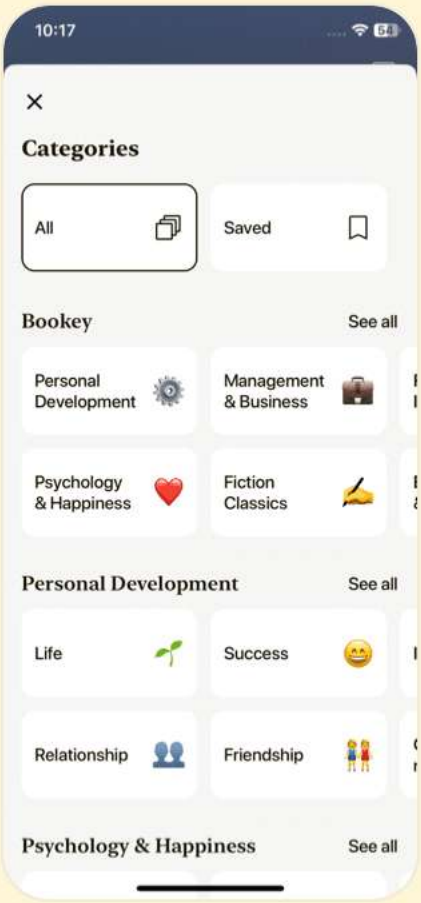
1 Million+ Quotes

1000+ Book Summaries

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 19 | Quotes From Pages 316-332

1. '...it is understood that you'll complete a Staff Project to get promoted.'
2. '...if you're pursuing a Staff-plus role, it's important to pierce the mythology of these projects and focus on the experiences of folks who've walked the path before you.'
3. '...my advice is, that although you can attain a Staff-plus role without completing a Staff project, they're a particularly valuable opportunity to develop yourself as an engineer.'
4. 'Getting access to Staff projects depends on your management chain trusting you enough to bet on your success.'
5. 'Once you've entered the room, be sure to show up and engage.'
6. 'If any given room doesn't feel useful, exit the room.'

Chapter 20 | Quotes From Pages 333-347

1. Get in the room, and stay there.
2. There will always be another room to enter.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

3. To get into the room, you need to bring something useful to the room that the room doesn't already have.
4. Your sponsor is allocating their social capital towards your inclusion, and their peers will judge them based on your actions within the room.
5. Be low friction.
6. While there are infinite rooms to be in, there's no room where the work actually happens.
7. Your goal is to be known for good things while minimizing the organizational bandwidth you consume to do so.
8. If any given room doesn't feel useful, exit the room.

Chapter 21 | Quotes From Pages 349-365

1. If those circumstances change, they tend to either leave shortly thereafter or spend a while burning out and then leave after exhausting their emotional reservoir.
2. Even with all your internal credibility, sometimes leaving is the most effective path forward.
3. If you're planning to leave due to a lack of interest,

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

excitement, support, or opportunity, it’s worthwhile to at least explore the internal waters first.

4. There are only a few magic spells to attain a Staff-plus role: negotiate for the title while switching roles or find a supportive environment.
5. If your internal reputation is damaged or if you’ve been repeatedly on the cusp of promotion but a victim to a moving criteria line, then you should seriously consider switching roles if the title is important to you.
6. This is a daunting decision to make, and picking the right company for you will have a considerable impact on whether you attain a Staff-plus role.
7. Getting a Staff-plus offer at a new company requires someone inside that company who believes in you and is willing to push through a fair amount of organizational friction to get you the title.
8. Throughout a forty-year career, there are times when you're rested and looking for a challenging, enveloping role. There are going to be other times when you're drained and

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

worn out.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

Download Bookey App to enjoy

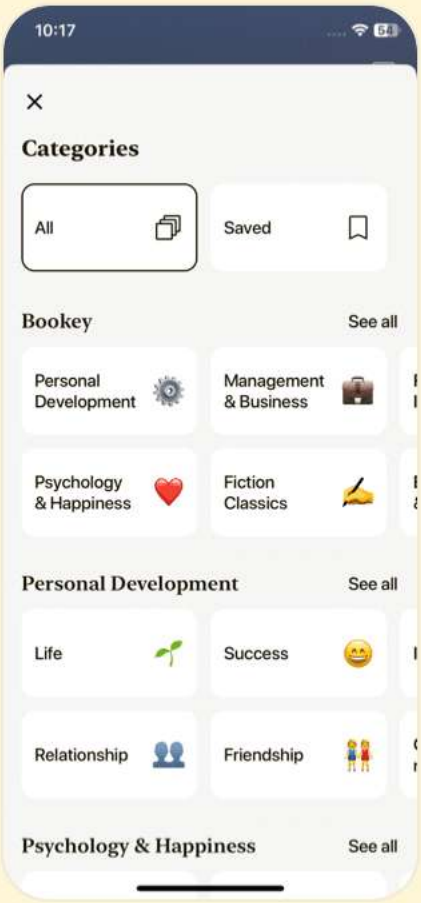
1 Million+ Quotes

1000+ Book Summaries

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 22 | Quotes From Pages 366-380

1. The most important reagent in both spells is picking the right company to perform them at.
2. If career velocity is your aim, then join a company that, for whatever reason, disproportionately values what you're good at.
3. Without an empowered leader within a company who's willing to invest their organizational capital in you, you can't get a leadership role.
4. Derisk durability by ensuring you join companies with business models that actually work and work for leaders who are values-aligned with their organization's senior-most leadership.
5. The easiest sponsors to find are folks who you've worked with before.
6. Job searches for leadership roles are much slower than the typical software search, taking months rather than weeks.
7. Don't allow momentum to pull you into a process that doesn't support your goals.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 23 | Quotes From Pages 381-390

1. Getting comfortable navigating ambiguity is a core part of the Staff-plus role, so a particularly optimistic person might view the state of Staff-plus interviewing as a good opportunity to demonstrate your skills.
2. Draw your lines. The engineering leadership phase of your career may last twenty years, but if you think of that in terms of roles, how you spend that time will likely come down to four or five pivotal decisions.
3. Don’t allow momentum to pull you into a process that doesn’t support your goals. It’s particularly valuable to understand when leveling happens within the company’s progress.
4. The last mile is the easiest as long as you take the time to walk it.
5. Your goal is to find the best available leadership opportunity, not the first available opportunity.

Chapter 24 | Quotes From Pages 392-418

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

1. Finding energizing work is what has kept me at Stripe for so long, pursuing impactful work.
2. I care a lot about the people I work with—they're the main reason I feel energized to go to work.
3. Your job as a Staff-plus Engineer is specific to your team and organization, and it’s important to avoid taking advice that doesn’t apply to your situation.
4. I’ve learned that it’s sometimes difficult for folks to say no to me.
5. Being extremely transparent but also explicit about whether or not you’re ready for feedback has landed well with folks who care about the topic.
6. It’s a lot harder to do this for the project I’m working on right now because it involves defining the idealized architecture...
7. I was confident enough (and trusted enough by the organization) to give them strong feedback on their collaboration so that I could ensure things like this weren’t happening to others like me.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

Download Bookey App to enjoy

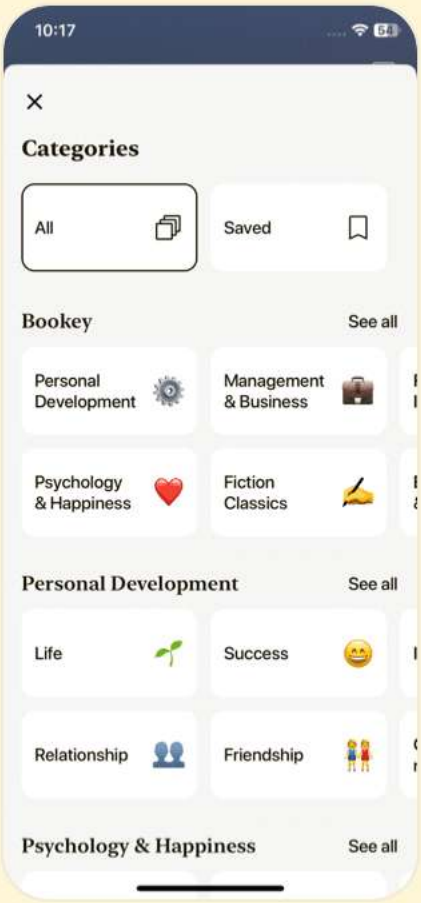
1 Million+ Quotes

1000+ Book Summaries

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 25 | Quotes From Pages 419-460

1. Finding energizing work is what has kept me at Stripe for so long, pursuing impactful work.
2. I measure my impact based on their progress and, more importantly, the directionality of that progress and the alignment of their work to the company’s goals.
3. I care a lot about the people I work with—they're the main reason I feel energized to go to work.
4. Being extremely transparent, but also explicit about whether or not you’re ready for feedback has landed well with folks who care about the topic.
5. A big component of being successful as a Staff-plus Engineer is being able to identify and scope net-new impactful work and to convince others of its value and impact.

Chapter 26 | Quotes From Pages 461-497

1. It's about thinking globally. That means partnering with other members of that cohort to understand the company-wide business/product

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

strategy and distilling that into an Engineering-wide technical strategy that seeks to enable execution for Product, Marketing, and our peers across other functions.

2. Once you become a Staff Engineer at Mailchimp, you're a member of "Engineering Leadership". It's about taking that global thinking and applying it locally.
3. It's always a rewarding feeling if I can end the work day and feel like I've helped my peers get unblocked and maintain momentum.
4. The people/social aspects of engineering don't go away; in fact, they are key to getting anything done.
5. It's definitely a rewarding part of my work day, so I welcome it. Often, industry peers tend to make the case that titles don't matter. But I disagree 100% with this statement; my personal experiences have shown me otherwise.

Chapter 27 | Quotes From Pages 498-525

1. When you have a title, you don't have to spend so much energy putting your credentials on the table.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

2. I present what I think is the best case for us, and people can disagree with that. And, you know, they often do.
3. I believe strongly that that shouldn't be your primary motivating factor [for pursuing management].
4. Find your peers or support network. Just like management, it gets lonely the higher up you go, and it's important to find peers that will still challenge you, and you can brainstorm ideas with.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

Download Bookey App to enjoy

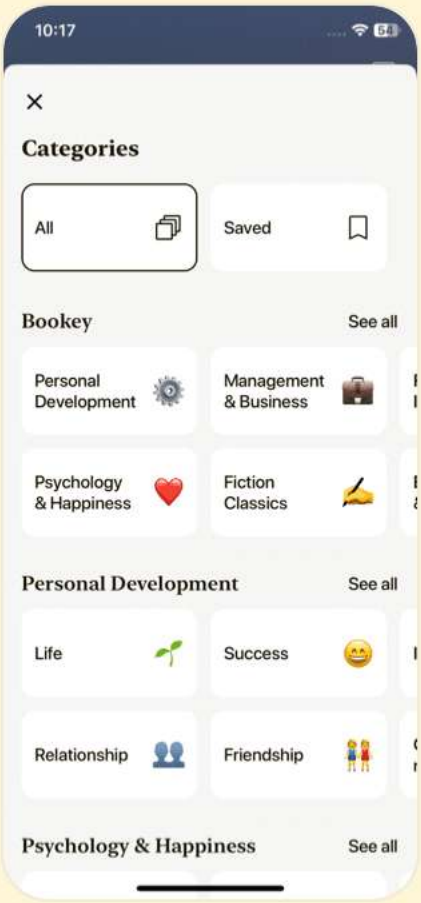
1 Million+ Quotes

1000+ Book Summaries

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 28 | Quotes From Pages 526-562

1. Staff-plus is all about enabling other people to do better work – to be a force multiplier.
2. You have to put a lot of effort into making sure your accomplishments are out there and they're known.
3. I've done a lot of experimentation with various product ideas in the last year, some of which have evolved into actual features of our Platform.
4. You're always going to be your best advocate, but that's even more true as a remote.
5. You need to develop your network and start meeting with your Director or your VP, because those are the people who are in the room making the decision about whether you're getting promoted or not.
6. The desire to write code isn't black and white since there are tech lead manager positions where you write code and Staff-plus engineer roles where you never write a line of production code.
7. It's more about working better with other people – trusted

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

them and giving them the freedom to make technical decisions... understanding other people's motivations.

8. This industry is not a meritocracy, and your professional network is important.
9. Sometimes the only way to get promoted would be to leave the company and do something else.
10. You have to be ready to kill your darlings, pivot, and try something new.

Chapter 29 | Quotes From Pages 563-619

1. When I started at Etsy, we had a great performance culture thanks to folks like Lara Hogan, but due to organizational changes a few years ago, we no longer had a web performance team, and I think that as an organization, we rested on our laurels and deprioritized web performance.
2. I think about all that, and advocate for the technical approaches that will get us there at the company level.
3. What I absolutely love to do the most is to identify a new

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

or unique problem that hasn’t been tackled before, come up with a wild idea to solve the problem, and then my brilliant coworkers take that idea and really run with it to build something awesome.

4. User empathy is a superpower that frontend people bring to the table.
5. I think it’s important to remember that there are lots of smaller and less-well-known companies with amazing people who do Staff engineering type work, but aren’t called staff engineers; they’re acknowledged as technical-track leaders in other ways.
6. A big part of being promoted to Staff is making sure that your work is visible, that people know your name, and you have a good reputation.
7. If an approach you’re taking doesn’t work, don’t try to force it.
8. Your manager is really on your team. They’re looking for a way to make you grow, be productive, be happy, and become the best engineer you can be.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 30 | Quotes From Pages 620-664

1. I've had to learn to think of impact in longer timescales, not in terms of what I'm shipping today, but what I could influence the company to ship in the future.
2. It's important to always push beyond what you're doing and not be scared of asking for things you think are too hard for you... that's okay, you've got to try it.
3. I want to try to help them figure out their path.
4. When I started mentoring and managing, I definitely found myself thinking about career growth very differently.
5. Somewhere along the way I realized that your manager is really on your team. They're looking for a way to make you grow, be productive, be happy, and become the best engineer you can be.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

Download Bookey App to enjoy

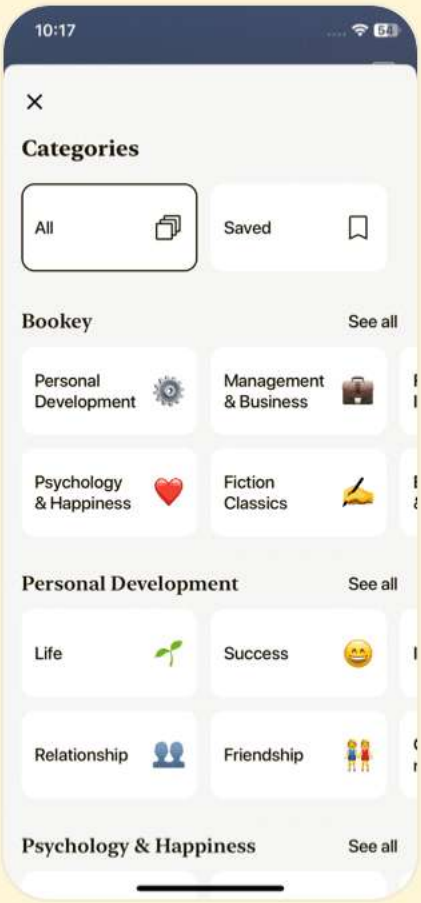
1 Million+ Quotes

1000+ Book Summaries

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 31 | Quotes From Pages 665-698

1. I love to mentor people, but sometimes folks aren't sure if they're getting the strategic advisor working for the benefit of the organization and company or the mentor, working for the benefit of that person and their career.
2. If it's what you love, if it's what you're passionate about, then you have to go for it.
3. It's essential to develop and maintain a deep understanding of his worldview. That's essential for me to retain the very deep trust required to be his representative and effectively carry out his strategy and vision.
4. I want to be visible as a Black engineer, showing others that we are here, and this is doable.
5. It's important to follow my passions. I've never been a pure engineer that's just deep in the code 24/7...I've had to make my peace with that.
6. You need to know what their incentives are and what problems they perceive that you don't perceive. Having

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

better alignment with leadership makes a lot of things much easier.

7. You’re my representative; you should feel free to push on and perform things using my name and role.

Chapter 32 | Quotes From Pages 699-741

1. One lesson that I learned was the importance of focus and prioritization. That's especially true when you have the broad organizational context that I talked about earlier.
2. By starting early, you have a huge competitive advantage relative to someone starting later who tries to reverse engineer the architecture and organizational dependencies.
3. A significant amount of my time is actually spent on advocating for technical solutions, processes, architectural or cultural changes - it’s not only all about writing code.
4. I really believe that we need to lift each other up.
5. What got you to senior level will not get you to Staff+.

Chapter 33 | Quotes From Pages 742-777

1. The main factor to get to Staff Engineer is to

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

actually believe that YOU CAN DO IT and don’t let the impostor syndrome win.

2. Having the title strongly correlates with one’s ability to influence the organization/company roadmap and priorities - basically, you get to be in the 'room where it happens.'
3. I’ve found this extremely valuable, because it makes me take a step back and assess what I am currently doing, to ask if I’m still growing in my current environment and think about new opportunities.
4. Sponsoring is actually an important area for me, as I focus on building amazing relationships with many people that I work with and I strongly believe that we need to lift each other up.
5. What got you to senior level will not get you to Staff+.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

Download Bookey App to enjoy

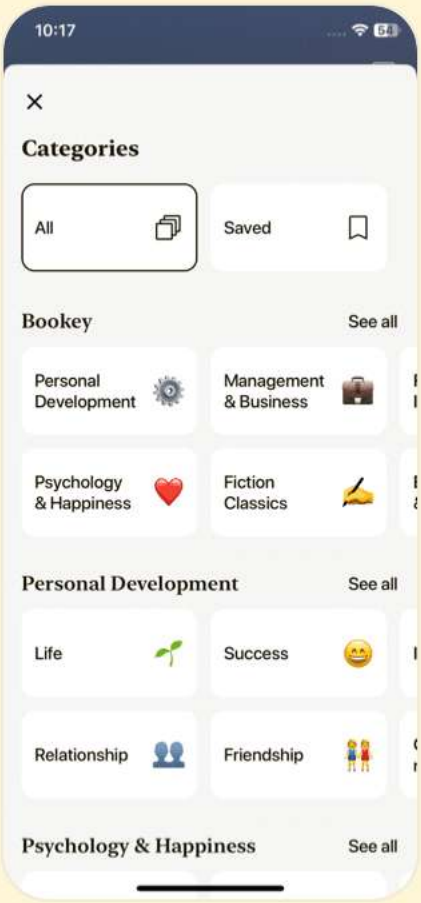
1 Million+ Quotes

1000+ Book Summaries

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 34 | Quotes From Pages 778-809

1. I’m a Staff Engineer at Squarespace. Squarespace is the leading all-in-one platform to build a beautiful online presence: websites, domains, online stores, marketing tools, scheduling appointments, etc.
2. Caring about more things is hard.
3. I think a key responsibility of Staff-plus is a willingness to own all of the things that contribute to (or block) engineering output, which includes both technical strategy and culture.
4. I’d feel comfortable surfacing what I perceive as shortcomings in the engineering onboarding process in this type of meeting.
5. Sponsoring is one of the most powerful ways we can grow those around us and I would say that growing others is one of the most important aspects of our role.
6. The more senior you get, the less your job is about code.
7. I think it’s possible to advance at a lot of companies.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

However, I found that being at a fast-growing startup really helped me out.

Chapter 35 | Quotes From Pages 810-861

1. I feel most impactful when I can facilitate setting a technical vision for an area and get people moving toward that vision.
2. Having a clear idea of what we want allows us to work with Product to get it prioritized.
3. The vision alone isn’t enough, we need everyone to understand that vision and internalize it.
4. Sponsoring is one of the most powerful ways we can grow those around us and... growing others is one of the most important aspects of our role.
5. The more senior you get, the less your job is about code.
6. What is important is that you stay connected with what your peers are doing and the challenges they’re facing.
7. Focus on amplifying your strengths; how can you turn something you're good at into your superpower?
8. You need to document your thoughts, plans, reasoning, and

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

standards. Writing down something scales better than just talking about it.

9. Luck is what happens when preparation meets opportunity.
10. It’s possible to advance at a lot of companies. However, I found that being at a fast-growing startup really helped me out.

Chapter 36 | Quotes From Pages 862-897

1. The biggest impact comes from being able to help achieve 'people scale', positively influencing the work of as many people as possible internally.
2. Luck is what happens when preparation meets opportunity.
3. Being patient, progressively influencing people, and teaching others pays off long term.
4. When you document something, you make it easy for anyone to access it and read in the future; it is better than 'just talking about it': it scales better and reduces misunderstandings.
5. I’ve been privileged enough to be able to approach my career in a way that maximizes learning and opportunities

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

for hard problem-solving.

6. As a Principal Engineer, I try to find opportunities/gaps that I believe will set a direction for as many people as possible in the long term.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

Download Bookey App to enjoy

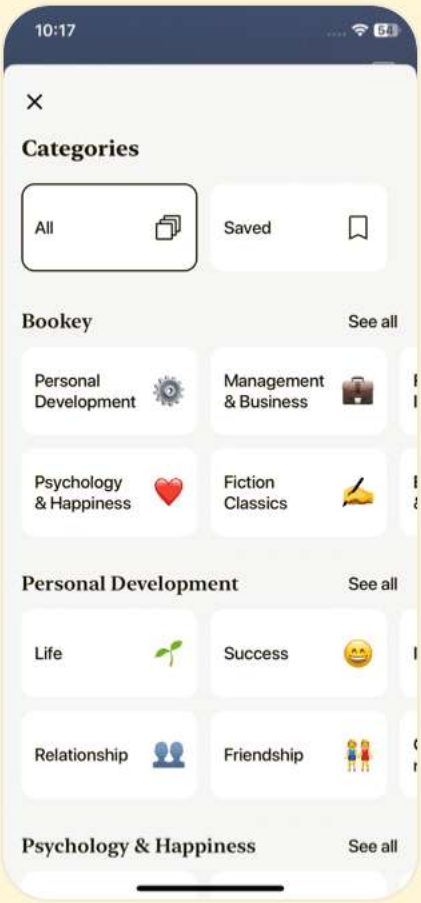
1 Million+ Quotes

1000+ Book Summaries

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 37 | Quotes From Pages 898-931

1. Staff Engineers, and Pillar Tech Leads, in particular, frequently help set direction for a new project.
2. One helpful resource for that is the Stripe-wide engineer survey that Developer Productivity group organizes, where we are looking to find what are the biggest things keeping our engineers from being productive.
3. While, sponsoring other engineers isn’t required for a Staff Engineer, I believe it helps to succeed as one, as it helps you deliver more impact by creating opportunities for others and helping them succeed.
4. Get comfortable talking a lot. I think a big step-change between Senior and Staff roles ends up being the focus on people: reconciling competing priorities, clearing up miscommunication, aligning folks on the same page.
5. Every time I considered it in the past, it was by asking myself and others around me, 'would it be a way to bring more impact?' So far, every time the answer was, 'seems

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

like no.'

Chapter 38 | Quotes From Pages 936-943

1. If you only have one hour to develop yourself as an engineer, your best bet would be building a network of people in similar roles.
2. Almost unanimously, Staff-plus engineers' most valuable learning resources wasn't a book, blog, talk, or paper, but instead their network of peers and mentors.
3. They had blog posts and tech talks they might mention related to a more specific problem, but they were most changed by this larger, more papery format.
4. Learning to have an engineering vision is crucial.
5. Understanding project management will improve your developer job.

Chapter 39 | Quotes From Pages 944-957

1. None of the Staff Engineer I spoke with got there alone. Most got there either through voracious reading or building a powerful network of colleagues.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

2. If you only have one hour to develop yourself as an engineer, your best bet would be building a network of people in similar roles.
3. The Staff-plus engineers I've chatted with have generally mentioned giving talks as more valuable to them than listening to talks, but there certainly are some excellent talks out there.
4. Understanding how these different archetypes typically report differently into the organization helps decode some of the seeming arbitrariness of reporting structures.
5. Most companies struggle to set up this sort of organizational infrastructure to fully support Staff-plus engineers as genuine leaders, so you should look at this as a problem you want to make progress on over years, rather than one that'll get fixed overnight.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

Download Bookey App to enjoy

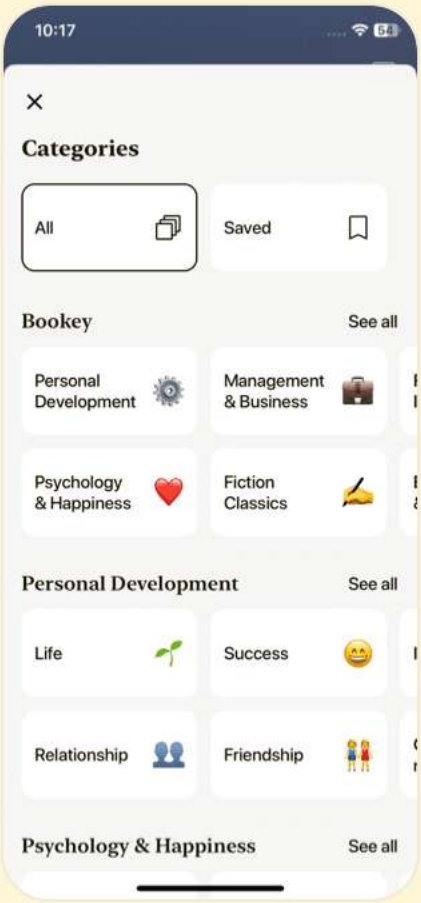
1 Million+ Quotes

1000+ Book Summaries

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 40 | Quotes From Pages 958-973

1. When I work on the organization design of an engineering organization, I think a lot about ‘organizational mathematics,’ the guideline that each team should have one manager and six to eight engineers.
2. If you find yourself reporting to someone who you believe is the wrong manager, it’s a reasonable conversation to have with your manager.
3. The reporting structure is a form of authority, and generally, folks overestimate how authority will help them.
4. The transition from Senior to Staff-plus engineer is a major one that changes the sort of work being done.
5. Sponsor and support more than you direct.

Chapter 41 | Quotes From Pages 974-991

1. Sponsor and support more than you direct.
2. Give feedback. One particularly important strategy for rewriting their definition of success—and to keep them growing—is to give frequent feedback.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

3. Create space for them to think without detaching them from the day-to-day realities of the organization.
4. Appreciate them. Great Staff-plus engineers operate fairly independently, so it can be easy to deprioritize them when the organization is on fire.
5. Hold them responsible for the full role. While few folks reach Staff-plus roles with major technical weaknesses, it's my lived experience that many folks reach these roles hampered by significant leadership or behavioral challenges.

Chapter 42 | Quotes From Pages 992-1002

1. Even if no one feels great about their loop, there is still a body of collective learnings to incorporate into your attempt to design a loop, which is what we'll cover here.
2. The best interview loops reason forward from the signals you want to capture back to the interview topics and format.
3. If mentorship is the most important activity, don't rely on

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

them talking about mentorship, but instead find a way to see them mentoring someone.

4. When you're hiring your first Staff-plus engineers, you'll often find some earlier career interviewers who undervalue the candidate's strengths, and instead anchor on the candidate's capability to perform the interviewer's current role.
5. Too title-oriented? At a certain level of accomplishment, people don't care much about internal leveling, generally because they're already financially secure.
6. It's interesting to note that many would not consider these to explicitly be technical skills.
7. Whatever interviews you end up using, test them, gather candidate feedback, and keep evolving them to be better!

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

Download Bookey App to enjoy

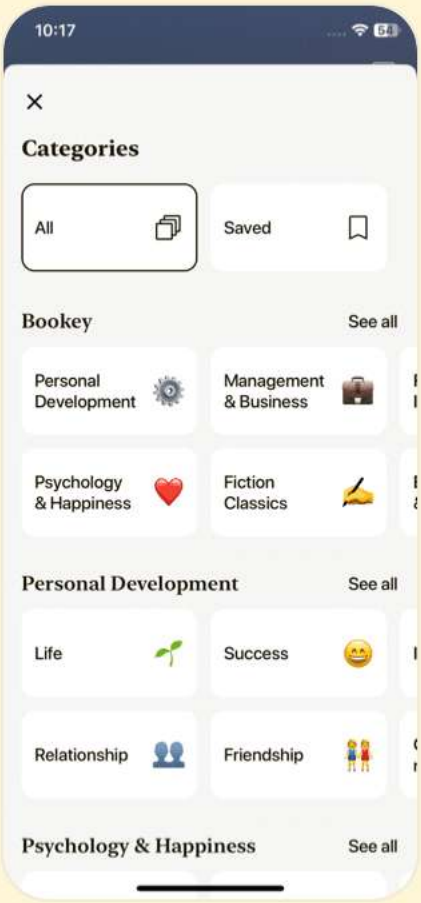
1 Million+ Quotes

1000+ Book Summaries

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Staff Engineer Questions

View on Bookey Website

Chapter 1 | Acknowledgments| Q&A

1.Question

What motivates a person to write and share their stories with others?

Answer:There is a deep motivation in sharing stories that resonates with the shared human experience. It allows individuals to connect, reflect, and find solace in the fact that they are not alone in their challenges and triumphs. Like the author's gratitude towards those who contributed their voices, every unique story adds richness to the collective narrative.

2.Question

How did the chaotic events of 2020 influence the creation of this book?

Answer:The chaos of 2020 served as both a challenge and a catalyst for creativity. In times of uncertainty, literature can

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

often provide guidance and perspective. The author acknowledges that despite the turmoil, collaboration and community support became fundamental in driving the book forward, indicating that sometimes adversity can bring out the best in people.

3.Question

Why is community important in the process of writing and publishing?

Answer:The process of writing can be isolating, but the community acts as a support system that enriches the work. It provides feedback, encouragement, and diverse insights that refine the narrative and improve its delivery. As highlighted, the collective input from various individuals transformed a solitary endeavor into a shared journey.

4.Question

What significance does the cover illustration hold in relation to the book's theme?

Answer:The cover illustration, reminiscent of old nautical maps, symbolizes navigation through uncertainty—a core

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

theme in the role of a Staff engineer. Just as sailors used maps to chart their courses through unknown waters, engineers must navigate their careers and challenges, finding their way in a complex professional landscape.

5.Question

What role does gratitude play in the success of a project?

Answer:Gratitude fosters connections and recognizes the contributions of others, which is vital for collaboration. It creates an environment where individuals feel valued and motivated to contribute further. The author's expressions of thankfulness demonstrate how acknowledging others enhances teamwork and encourages ongoing support.

6.Question

What can be learned from acknowledging diverse voices within a community?

Answer:Acknowledging diverse voices allows for a more comprehensive understanding of a subject. It unearths different perspectives and experiences, which can lead to innovative ideas and solutions. The author's reference to

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

various contributors emphasizes the importance of inclusivity and representation in professional discourse.

7.Question

How can challenges shape the narrative of a work?

Answer:Challenges can add depth and authenticity to a narrative. They often serve as pivotal moments that propel action and development within a story. In this context, the upheaval of 2020 may have provided profound reflections and lessons that shaped the direction of the content, making it more relatable and impactful.

8.Question

What does ‘staff engineering’ mean within the context of the book?

Answer:Staff engineering represents a role that combines technical expertise with leadership responsibilities. It involves not only solving complex engineering problems but also mentoring others and influencing broader organizational strategies. The role can often feel ambiguous, hence the need for navigation as discussed in the introduction.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 2 | Foreword| Q&A

1.Question

What role do stories play in shaping the understanding of the staff engineer position?

Answer:Stories shared by individuals who have experienced the staff engineering role provide unique perspectives and insights that collectively illuminate the complexities and challenges of the position. They not only validate feelings of uncertainty but also offer practical examples of how to navigate the ambiguous aspects of the role.

2.Question

Why is it confusing for engineers promoted beyond the senior level?

Answer:Engineers at this level often grapple with undefined roles, expectations of 'impact,' and feedback mechanisms that are less frequent and more generalized than they are use to. This lack of clarity can lead to feelings of isolation and confusion regarding how to effectively contribute to their

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

organizations.

3.Question

How do current resources fall short for senior engineers?

Answer:There’s a scarcity of dedicated resources that address the specific challenges faced by senior engineers. Much of the advice available tends to be geared towards management, leaving technical leads without adequate support for their unique needs.

4.Question

What is the significance of the term 'staff-plus' in engineering?

Answer:The term 'staff-plus' provides a necessary linguistic framework to describe engineers who are beyond the senior level in a clear manner, facilitating communication and understanding about the expectations and roles within organizations, which can significantly differ.

5.Question

What are the essential skills a staff engineer needs according to Will Larson?

Answer:A staff engineer should excel in interpreting business

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

needs, effective communication, crisis management, and influencing teams towards consensus. These skills often transcend technical ability and are crucial for driving impactful engineering strategies.

6.Question

What does the community around staff engineering offer to its members?

Answer:The community provides crucial support, shared experiences, and resources that empower engineers to learn from each other and navigate their careers effectively. It helps cultivate a sense of belonging and validation for those pursuing technical leadership.

7.Question

What is the relationship between technical skills and business acumen in engineering roles?

Answer:As engineers advance in their careers, merely possessing technical skills is insufficient; they must also develop the ability to understand and influence business needs, making it essential to bridge the gap between

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

technology and business.

8.Question

How can engineers ensure they are working on the 'right things'?

Answer:To impactfully navigate their roles, staff engineers need to engage in active discussions with their peers and management, seeking clarity on priorities and alignment with organizational goals, as well as articulating their understanding of 'impact' within the larger context.

Chapter 3 | Preface| Q&A

1.Question

What does it mean to navigate a technical leadership career path?

Answer:Navigating a technical leadership career path often involves feeling like you’re in the wrong room, especially in environments where traditional management skills are emphasized over technical expertise. As companies recognize the need for seasoned engineers to drive technical strategies and

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

mentor others, the challenge lies in finding communities and resources that support this growth. Technical leadership means integrating technical skills with an understanding of business needs, effective communication, and influencing teams to make decisions.

2.Question

Why is there a lack of resources specifically for senior engineers?

Answer:The lack of resources for senior engineers can be attributed to the ambiguous nature of their roles. Promoted engineers often find themselves in undefined positions where determining their impact and priorities becomes a struggle. Unlike other professions where clear career trajectories exist, engineering lacks a universal career ladder, resulting in confusion and isolation for those at advanced levels.

3.Question

What are the core challenges faced by engineers when reaching the Staff level?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:Engineers who reach the Staff level often struggle with unclear job expectations and the pressure of defining their impact. They may find themselves grappling with feedback cycles that extend over longer periods compared to sprint-based cycles, making it difficult to assess progress and effectiveness. Understanding which areas to focus on and how to influence the organization's technology direction becomes a daunting task.

4.Question

How can technical leaders effectively support their teams?

Answer:Technical leaders can support their teams by fostering an environment of open communication, ensuring that engineers feel valued and involved in shaping solutions. This involves guiding their team members on crucial projects, helping define the challenges the team should tackle, and advocating for their visibility and contribution within the larger organizational context.

5.Question

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

What is the significance of the 'staff-plus' term in engineering?

Answer:The term 'staff-plus' provides a unifying label for varying elevated engineering roles, which previously lacked common terminology. With 'staff-plus,' engineers can better understand where they fit into the hierarchy and what is expected of them, facilitating clearer career discussions and development paths.

6.Question

What insights does Will Larson offer regarding the staff engineer role?

Answer:Will Larson highlights that the staff engineer role encompasses not just technical skills but also the ability to navigate organizational structures and influence outcomes. His insights cover the importance of communication, strategic decision-making, and understanding the fluid dynamics of technology within the company, reflecting the evolving expectations for engineers at this level.

7.Question

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

What practical advice can emerging technical leaders retrieve from this book?

Answer:Emerging technical leaders can glean pragmatic advice on how to embrace their roles effectively, focusing on building influence, enhancing communication skills, and understanding the broader impact of their work on the organization. The book also emphasizes real-life experiences and varied paths taken by successful engineers, providing relatable and actionable strategies.

8.Question

Why is it essential for engineers to find a community for learning?

Answer:Finding a community for learning is crucial as it offers the necessary support, resources, and guidance that can foster personal and professional development. These communities mitigate the feeling of isolation many engineers experience at advanced career stages and create opportunities for mentorship and shared learning.

9.Question

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

What can readers expect to gain from the different interviews presented in the book?

Answer:Readers can expect to learn through diverse experiences and insights from various engineers at different stages of their careers. The interviews illustrate the unique pathways individuals take to reach staff roles and how they navigate the challenges associated with those roles, providing inspiration and realistic guidance for readers facing similar transitions.

10.Question

How does Will Larson's perspective help demystify the staff engineer role?

Answer:Will Larson demystifies the staff engineer role by clearly defining its expectations and responsibilities, breaking down the complexities of the position into understandable components. His narrative balances technical advice with organizational insights, allowing engineers to visualize their growth trajectory and understand how they can exert a positive influence on their teams and the broader

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

company.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Try Bookey App to read 1000+ summary of world best books

Unlock 1000+ Titles, 80+ Topics

New titles added every week

Brand | Leadership & Collaboration | Time Management | Relationship & Communication

ness Strategy | Creativity | Public | Money & Investing | Know Yourself | Positive P

Entrepreneurship | World History | Parent-Child Communication | Self-care | Mind & Spi

Insights of world best books

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 4 | Staff engineer archetypes| Q&A

1.Question

What are the key skills needed to transition from a Senior engineer to a Staff engineer?

Answer:To transition to a Staff engineer role, engineers should focus on developing not only technical skills but also leadership abilities, communication skills, and the capability to influence and guide teams. This includes being adept at scoping complex tasks, maintaining relationships across teams, and driving the technical vision of the team.

2.Question

How do companies support dual-track career paths for engineers?

Answer:Many companies provide a two-track system where engineers can choose between advancing in technical leadership or moving into engineering management. This dual-track system acknowledges the diverse paths engineers

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

can take, allowing them to lead technically without the need for people management responsibilities.

3.Question

What should an engineer consider when deciding between different archetypes of Staff-plus roles?

Answer:Engineers should reflect on their personal strengths and the types of work that energize them. For instance, if they enjoy deep collaboration with teams, the Tech Lead role may suit them. If they prefer tackling specific complex problems, then the Solver archetype could be more fitting. It's essential to align their interests with the available roles in their organization.

4.Question

Why is there ambiguity around the Staff-plus roles in companies?

Answer:The ambiguity comes from the varied interpretations of Staff-plus roles across different companies. Each organization has its own definition and expectations for these roles, leading to confusion about what skills and behaviors

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

are truly necessary for success.

5.Question

How can insights from others in Staff-plus roles benefit an aspiring engineer?

Answer:Insights from existing Staff-plus engineers provide a broader perspective on the challenges and expectations of the role. Learning from their experiences can help aspirations formulate a clearer path to achieving a Staff-plus role and understanding the nuances that might not be captured in formal descriptions.

6.Question

What are the four archetypes of Staff-plus roles and their significance?

Answer:The four archetypes—Tech Lead, Architect, Solver, and Right Hand—represent different focuses and approaches within Staff-plus roles. Understanding these can help engineers identify where they fit best and how they can leverage their strengths to contribute meaningfully within their organizations.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

7.Question

What steps can an engineer take to effectively prepare for a Staff-plus role?

Answer:An engineer can prepare by seeking mentorship from current Staff engineers, actively participating in cross-functional projects, enhancing their technical and leadership skills, and taking on responsibilities that align with the archetype they aspire to fill.

8.Question

How do the archetypes differ in terms of their interactions and team engagement?

Answer:Tech Leads typically work closely with teams on ongoing projects, fostering a strong sense of community and collaboration. Conversely, Solvers and Right Hands often engage in a more transactional manner, bouncing between urgent issues and having less opportunity for deep team relationships.

9.Question

What should a candidate keep in mind regarding fulfillment in their chosen archetype?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:It's important for a candidate to consider not only the responsibilities of the archetype but also their personal fulfillment and passion for the work involved. Choosing a role that resonates with their values and interests can lead to greater job satisfaction and effectiveness.

10.Question

Can engineers switch between archetypes throughout their careers?

Answer:Yes, engineers can experiment with different archetypes throughout their careers. Each stage offers unique learning opportunities, and gaining experience in various roles can enhance their versatility and adaptability in the workplace.

Chapter 5 | What do Staff engineers actually do?| Q&A

1.Question

What are the four common archetypes of Staff-plus engineers?

Answer:The four common archetypes of Staff-plus roles are: the Tech Lead, the Architect, the Solver,

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

and the Right Hand. Each archetype embodies different responsibilities based on organizational needs.

2.Question

How does the role of a Tech Lead differ from that of an Architect?

Answer:A Tech Lead guides the approach and execution of a particular team, collaborating closely with managers and enabling team members to unlock their potential. On the other hand, an Architect is responsible for a specific technical domain, focusing on its long-term strategy and overall quality, often combining deep technical knowledge with leadership.

3.Question

What is the purpose of a Solver within an organization?

Answer:The Solver takes on complex, critical problems as designated by organizational leadership, working until solutions are identified and implemented. This role emphasizes individual problem ownership rather than team

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

collaboration.

4.Question

What does being a Right Hand entail in a company?

Answer:Being a Right Hand means acting as a trusted adviser to an executive, extending their attention and authority to tackle complex organizational issues without direct managerial responsibilities.

5.Question

Why is mentorship important for Staff-plus engineers?

Answer:Mentorship allows Staff-plus engineers to grow their teams and improve overall performance by sharing experiences and fostering a supportive environment. It's crucial for developing future leaders and creating a cohesive engineering culture.

6.Question

How do Staff-plus engineers manage their coding responsibilities compared to lower-level engineers?

Answer:While Staff-plus engineers may have less time to code than junior engineers, they still engage in coding to stay connected to the technical aspects of their roles. However,

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

their focus often shifts more towards mentoring and strategic decision-making.

7.Question

What role does technical direction play for a Staff-plus engineer?

Answer:Staff-plus engineers are responsible for setting technical direction, which involves defining a shared vision for their projects, aligning with the needs of the organization, and ensuring that technical strategies support long-term goals.

8.Question

What are some characteristics of effective Staff-plus engineers based on the interviewees?

Answer:Effective Staff-plus engineers engage in mentorship and sponsorship, adapt to longer project timeframes, facilitate communication across teams, and possess the foresight to address technical and strategic challenges faced by their organizations.

9.Question

How can one determine which Staff-plus archetype fits

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

them best?

Answer:To determine which archetype fits you best, reflect on the types of work that energize you, assess the roles available in your organization, and consider your personal strengths and preferences in collaborative problem-solving.

10.Question

What challenges do Staff-plus engineers face with longer timeframes in their work?

Answer:Staff-plus engineers often grapple with the perception of slower work and the emotional strain of feeling unproductive. However, embracing these longer timeframes can lead to significant impacts and personal growth in the long run.

Chapter 6 | Does the title even matter?| Q&A

1.Question

What is the primary focus of Staff engineers?

Answer:Staff engineers primarily focus on working on projects that have strategic value for the company, driving technical design, and up-leveling

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

their team. They also set and edit technical direction, provide mentorship, and inject engineering context into organizational decisions.

2.Question

How does mentorship differ from sponsorship in the context of Staff engineers?

Answer:Mentorship involves sharing experience and advice, whereas sponsorship is more proactive, involving directly advocating for someone's advancement and ensuring they receive opportunities that can influence their career.

3.Question

Why is it important for Staff engineers to 'be the glue' in organizations?

Answer:Being the glue means performing necessary but often invisible tasks that help keep the team moving forward and ensuring important work gets completed. It highlights the value of collaboration and support in driving organizational success.

4.Question

What role does a Staff engineer play in shaping technical

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

direction?

Answer:A Staff engineer facilitates the setting of a technical vision and helps the group reach a shared understanding of their goals. They focus on long-term trends and the real needs of the organization rather than just personal interests in technology.

5.Question

What are the long-term challenges associated with a Staff engineer role?

Answer:Staff engineers often face longer timeframes for feedback and outcomes. Their work may not yield immediate results, which can be demoralizing; however, the impact and personal growth come from these extended timeframes and the strategic nature of their responsibilities.

6.Question

How does the title of Staff engineer affect one's position and opportunity in a company?

Answer:The title can provide advantages like bypassing informal gauges of seniority, gaining access to higher-level

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

discussions ('being in the room'), and potentially increasing compensation. However, it comes with increased accountability and expectations.

7.Question

What should someone consider before pursuing a Staff engineer title?

Answer:They should assess whether they genuinely want the responsibilities that come with the role, as being a Staff engineer is significantly different from being a Senior engineer, and it may shift focus away from the technical work they enjoy.

8.Question

What do organizations benefit from when they have capable Staff engineers?

Answer:Organizations benefit from effective Staff engineers through improved technical decision-making, better mentorship and sponsorship opportunities for other engineers, and enhanced collaboration that propels projects forward.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

9.Question

How do Staff engineers contribute to the organization's exploration and innovation?

Answer:Staff engineers are often trusted with exploratory projects, allowing them to address important ambiguities that the company's systems are not well-equipped to tackle, leading to significant discoveries and innovative solutions.

10.Question

In what way does the responsibilities of a Staff engineer expand compared to their earlier roles?

Answer:While earlier roles may focus heavily on coding and individual contributions, Staff engineers prioritize mentorship, project management, strategic decision-making, and setting engineering direction, balancing these broader responsibilities with less hands-on coding.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Why Bookey is must have App for Book Lovers

30min Content
The deeper and clearer interpretation we provide, the better grasp of each title you have.

Text and Audio format
Absorb knowledge even in fragmented time.

Quiz
Check whether you have mastered what you just learned.

And more
Multiple Voices & fonts, Mind Map, Quotes, IdeaClips...

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 7 | Work on what matters| Q&A

1.Question

What is the primary misconception about becoming a Staff engineer?

Answer:Many believe that once they become a Staff engineer, they will have full control and their ideas will be immediately accepted by others. In reality, the role involves more collaboration, mentorship, and less direct control over projects.

2.Question

How does the feedback cycle differ for Staff engineers compared to coding?

Answer:Staff engineers often face a slower feedback cycle because their work involves strategic planning, mentorship, and relationship building, rather than immediate coding results which provide quick feedback.

3.Question

What is one essential aspect of leadership that Staff engineers must learn?

Answer:They must learn to blend their vision with the

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

visions of their peers and leaders, rather than insisting on their singular viewpoint.

4.Question

What does it mean to 'work on what matters' as a Staff engineer?

Answer:It involves focusing on impactful work that aligns with business objectives, rather than getting drawn into low-impact tasks that may feel rewarding but don't contribute to meaningful progress.

5.Question

Why is it important to pace your career with your life commitments?

Answer:Balancing career advancements with personal life can prevent burnout and ensure long-term sustainable growth. It's crucial to manage the increasing expectations of your role without sacrificing personal well-being.

6.Question

What is 'preening' in the context of engineering roles?

Answer:Preening refers to spending time on low-impact work that is highly visible rather than genuinely impactful.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

It's often a trap where engineers focus on recognition rather than meaningful contributions.

7.Question

How should engineers approach existential risks within their companies?

Answer:Engineers should focus their efforts on addressing significant existential risks their companies face, as these are critical for survival and can significantly shape the direction of their work.

8.Question

What is the importance of fostering growth in the team around you?

Answer:Investing time in mentoring and supporting team members can have a prolonged impact on the organization’s output and can create a lasting legacy beyond individual contributions.

9.Question

What does 'editing' mean in the context of a Staff engineer's work?

Answer:Editing involves making small adjustments or

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

facilitating conversations that can lead to significant improvements in a project, often helping team members find the right direction to success.

10.Question

What types of work should Staff engineers prioritize that only they can do?

Answer:They should focus on unique contributions that leverage their expertise and passions, such as strategic decisions or transformative projects that would not progress without their input.

Chapter 8 | Writing engineering strategy| Q&A

1.Question

What is the importance of focusing on "energizing" work instead of just "impactful" work?

Answer:Focusing on "energizing" work allows individuals to invest their finite time in projects that personally inspire and motivate them, leading to long-term engagement and fulfillment. This inward-looking approach is crucial for sustaining a

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

successful career and aligning professional ambitions with personal well-being.

2.Question

How can professionals avoid the pitfalls of snacking, preening, and chasing ghosts?

Answer:To avoid these pitfalls, professionals should critically assess their tasks and prioritize high-impact work that contributes meaningfully to their goals. Instead of engaging in low-impact, easy tasks (snacking), seeking visibility rather than value (preening), or pursuing unproductive endeavors based on past experiences (chasing ghosts), they should focus on tasks that genuinely align with their career development and the company's needs.

3.Question

What strategies should one adopt to identify work that genuinely matters?

Answer:Professionals should begin by identifying existential risks facing their company, engaging with projects that address these challenges. Additionally, they should look for

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

opportunities where their efforts can make a significant impact but may require more attention. They should also focus on nurturing team growth and mentoring, as this often leads to long-lasting effects on the organization.

4.Question

Why is it important to foster growth in your team, and how might this influence your legacy?

Answer:Fostering growth within the team ensures a continuous cycle of knowledge transfer and skill enhancement, which often outlasts individual contributions to projects. Investing time in mentoring and coaching can amplify the collective capacity of the team, creating an enduring legacy of leadership that shapes future company success.

5.Question

What is the significance of writing a good engineering strategy, and how does it relate to effective decision-making?

Answer:A well-structured engineering strategy is essential as it provides a framework for decision-making and aligns team

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

efforts toward common goals. By basing strategies on concrete, detailed design documents, teams can avoid ambiguity and ensure that everyone is on the same page, facilitating quicker and more confident decision-making.

6.Question

How can professionals ensure their strategies are effective and relevant over time?

Answer:To ensure strategies remain effective, professionals should regularly review and synthesize feedback from past strategies, making adjustments based on current contexts. Additionally, keeping strategies grounded in the company's user base and core values promotes alignment and helps maintain their relevance as the business evolves.

7.Question

What role does specificity play in creating both strategy and vision documents?

Answer:Specificity is crucial in strategy and vision documents as it facilitates alignment among team members and provides clarity on the goals and methods of execution.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Specific statements reduce misunderstandings and create a shared understanding of objectives, ultimately leading to more effective collaborative efforts.

8.Question

In what ways can one contribute uniquely in their role, and why is this important?

Answer:Contributing uniquely usually involves leveraging specific skills or insights that significantly impact projects or organizational direction. This uniqueness not only forwards one’s career trajectory by establishing a personal brand but also fills critical gaps that otherwise would remain unaddressed, enhancing the overall success of the team and company.

9.Question

What should one consider when writing a vision for the future of their team or organization?

Answer:When writing a vision, one should look to span two to three years ahead, grounding the vision in service to users and the business while being optimistic yet achievable.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Keeping it concise and engaging while connecting with the leadership team's goals facilitates buy-in and fosters a roadmap that everyone strives to achieve.

Chapter 9 | Managing technical quality| Q&A

1.Question

Why is writing about engineering strategy often perceived as difficult?

Answer:Writing about engineering strategy is often perceived as difficult because good strategy can be seen as boring and mundane. It involves synthesizing complex ideas into clear, actionable documents, which many may find tedious or mystical, despite its practical importance in guiding teams and decisions.

2.Question

How can one effectively write an engineering strategy?

Answer:To write an effective engineering strategy, start by drafting five design documents. Analyze them for common themes and decisions, which will help you distill your

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

organization’s design philosophy into a cohesive strategy. This process grounds the strategy in reality, making it relatable and actionable.

3.Question

What is the purpose of creating engineering strategies and visions?

Answer:Engineering strategies provide proactive alignment for teams, enabling quicker, more confident decision-making. They also serve to narrow potential futures into realistic pathways, while visions extrapolate those strategies into broader, long-term implications, guiding the organization's direction.

4.Question

When should you create an engineering strategy?

Answer:You should create an engineering strategy when discussions about future direction start to feel repetitive or when the future seems uncertain and you need clarity on what investments are worthwhile. This indicates that it's time to formalize the strategy to move forward productively.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

5.Question

How can one transition from strategies to a broader vision?

Answer:To transition from specific strategies to a broader vision, you should identify five strategies, extrapolate their implications over two to three years, and weave them together to illustrate how they relate. This helps create a cohesive vision that provides a robust belief in the future.

6.Question

What are some practical steps for advancing an organization's engineering strategy?

Answer:Practical steps include initiating discussions about existing strategies, gathering input from team members, writing clear design documents for major projects, and iterating on feedback from peers. Each contribution, even if not directly your responsibility, can enhance the overall strategy.

7.Question

What are essential qualities of an effective engineering vision?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:An effective engineering vision should be grounded in user needs and business goals, specifically detailed, optimistic yet achievable, and brief enough to engage readers without losing them in complexity. It should resonate with the organization’s core values.

8.Question

How can you ensure that your quality program remains effective?

Answer:To ensure effectiveness, establish clear, sustainable metrics, communicate program goals with a path to success for teams, and adapt based on feedback. Regularly review program status alongside sponsors to maintain alignment with organizational priorities.

9.Question

What mindset should be applied when addressing quality problems in engineering?

Answer:Adopt a performance engineer’s mindset focused on directly measuring and addressing the root causes of quality issues. Begin with 'hot spots', and prioritize small,

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

manageable changes before attempting complex solutions. This helps maintain momentum and learning.

10.Question

What role does user research play in building effective tools for engineering teams?

Answer:User research is critical as it helps understand the needs and pain points of engineers using the tools. This insight allows for the development of tools that are not only powerful but also user-friendly, ultimately increasing adoption and efficacy.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

App Store
Editors' Choice

22k 5 star review

Positive feedback

Sara Scholz

tes after each book summary
erstanding but also make the
and engaging. Bookey has
ding for me.

Fantastic!!!

Masood El Toure

I'm amazed by the variety of books and languages Bookey supports. It's not just an app, it's a gateway to global knowledge. Plus, earning points for charity is a big plus!

Fi
Ab
bo
to
my

José Botín

ding habit
p's design
ual growth

Love it!

Wonnie Tappkx

Bookey offers me time to go through the important parts of a book. It also gives me enough idea whether or not I should purchase the whole book version or not! It is easy to use!

Time saver!

Bookey is my go-to app for
summaries are concise, ins
curated. It's like having acc
right at my fingertips!

Awesome app!

Rahul Malviya

I love audiobooks but don't always have time to listen to the entire book! bookey allows me to get a summary of the highlights of the book I'm interested in!!! What a great concept !!!highly recommended!

Beautiful App

Alex Walk

This app is a lifesaver for book lovers with busy schedules. The summaries are spot on, and the mind maps help reinforce wh I've learned. Highly recommend!

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 10 | Stay aligned with authority| Q&A

1.Question

What is the importance of managing technical quality in engineering leadership?

Answer:Managing technical quality is crucial for engineering leadership because it ensures the delivery of effective solutions that meet user needs while maintaining the integrity of the technology. A structured approach to technical quality helps align engineering efforts with business goals, addresses immediate operational issues, and fosters a culture of continuous improvement.

2.Question

How should one approach improving technical quality when faced with existing problems?

Answer:The best approach to improving technical quality is to start with the lightest weight solutions that can quickly address current issues. This may involve fixing specific hot spots causing immediate problems before integrating more

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

comprehensive quality programs. Quick wins allow teams to learn faster and iterate on improvements as needed.

3.Question

Why is it important to avoid premature processes when managing technical quality?

Answer:Premature processes can add unnecessary friction and bureaucracy to an organization. It’s crucial to ensure that processes are tailored to the specific maturity and needs of the team to avoid stifling innovation and efficiency. As organizations evolve, processes should be adapted rather than enforced rigidly.

4.Question

What role do 'hot spots' play in identifying technical quality issues?

Answer:Hot spots are specific areas within a system that are prone to problems or failures. Focusing on these hot spots allows organizations to target their efforts effectively, resolving the most pressing quality issues and preventing them from escalating before applying broader improvements.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

5.Question

How can the introduction of best practices impact technical quality?

Answer:Introducing best practices can enhance technical quality by standardizing effective methods across teams. However, this should be done after addressing immediate hot spots to ensure teams have matured sufficiently to adopt these practices. Well-implemented best practices can create a sustainable environment for ongoing improvement.

6.Question

What are leverage points, and why are they significant in maintaining quality over time?

Answer:Leverage points are critical areas in a system where investments in quality can yield significant returns. Addressing these points—such as interfaces, stateful systems, and data models—can prevent future quality failures and reduce the cost of maintaining quality as the system evolves.

7.Question

How important is it to balance immediate quality fixes

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

with longer-term strategic planning in technical quality management?

Answer:It is essential to find a balance between immediate fixes and long-term strategic planning. While urgent issues need to be addressed promptly, maintaining an eye on future quality standards and scalability helps ensure that immediate solutions do not lead to future complexities.

8.Question

What strategies can be employed to align technical vectors across teams?

Answer:Key strategies include facilitating open communication, providing direct feedback, and creating workflows that reinforce desired behaviors. Establishing a shared vision and documenting strategies will help align decisions made by different teams towards common goals.

9.Question

Why is measuring technical quality crucial for an organization?

Answer:Measuring technical quality helps organizations

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

identify gaps in their performance, track improvements, and make informed decisions about resource allocation. Clear metrics enable an organizational response to quality issues, ensuring that improvements are based on concrete data rather than intuition.

10.Question

How can a quality program help enhance technical quality in a company?

Answer:A quality program systematically promotes and maintains high technical quality across the organization. It involves identifying goals, supporting teams with best practices, and providing clear paths for improvement, ensuring that quality becomes an integral part of the development process rather than an afterthought.

Chapter 11 | To lead, you have to follow| Q&A

1.Question

How can I effectively represent my manager's vision in my role?

Answer:To effectively represent your manager's

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

vision, develop a deep understanding of their worldview and strategies. Ask yourself questions like 'What would my manager do in this situation?' This mental habit fosters trust and confidence, allowing you to embody their perspective even when they are not physically present.

2.Question

What should I do to maintain alignment with my organizational authority?

Answer:Maintaining alignment with your organizational authority involves regular communication with your manager, avoiding surprises, and proactively sharing relevant information from your team. Establishing a feedback loop will ensure you're aligned with their expectations and objectives.

3.Question

How can I transition from a role with a safety net to a leadership role without falling?

Answer:Transitioning to a leadership role involves

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

embracing responsibility for setting your team and the organization up for success. It’s about recognizing that you may no longer have a safety net and proactively aligning your initiatives with the broader company strategy.

4.Question

What is the difference between leadership and management?

Answer:Management is a profession focusing on organizing and controlling people and resources, whereas leadership is a mindset that can be applied across various professions. Effective leaders have a clear vision of 'how things ought to work' and take action to bridge the gap between that vision and reality.

5.Question

Why is it important for leaders to also learn to follow?

Answer:Effective leaders often spend more time following than leading. By understanding various perspectives and supporting others, you foster collaboration and improve overall team success. Recognizing the right moments to step

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

back allows the team to progress even if it deviates from your vision.

6.Question

What proactive measures can I take to avoid surprises for my manager?

Answer:Keep your manager informed with regular updates regarding your projects and any potential issues. Establish a routine for sharing challenges and developments, ensuring that they are not caught off guard by significant changes affecting your work.

7.Question

How can I cultivate a strong partnership with my manager?

Answer:A strong partnership with your manager involves transparency, trust, and proactive communication. Seek feedback regularly, understand their priorities, and work collaboratively to align your initiatives with their goals.

8.Question

What mindset is needed for influencing others within an organization?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:Adopting a long-term perspective is key for influencing others. Understand that organizational change takes time and requires deliberate efforts to align your vision with others while being patient as people adapt.

9.Question

How can I recognize opportunities to provide feedback without being obstructive?

Answer:Frame your feedback as supportive rather than critical. Use non-blocking language, such as classifying suggestions as optional, which allows others to assess your input without feeling compelled to adopt it immediately.

10.Question

What is the significance of aligning team initiatives with organizational strategies?

Answer:Aligning your team's initiatives with organizational strategies ensures that your work contributes to the larger goals of the company, fostering collaboration and enhancing efficiency across teams.

Chapter 12 | Learn to never be wrong| Q&A

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

1.Question

What is the key lesson that effective leaders learn over time?

Answer:The most important lesson learned is that to be an effective long-term leader, one must learn how to follow. This approach emphasizes that effective leaders actually spend more time following others than leading themselves.

2.Question

How can leaders align their team’s work with broader organizational strategies?

Answer:Leaders should translate the company's business and product strategies into actionable goals for their team's immediate projects. This requires constant collaboration with team members and managers to adopt successful practices that benefit the entire organization.

3.Question

What should one consider when deciding to follow rather than lead in a given situation?

Answer:A helpful question to ask is, 'Will what we do here

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

matter to me in six months?' If the answer is no, it's an opportunity to step back and support others leading the project.

4.Question

How should feedback be delivered to maintain team dynamics?

Answer:Feedback should be given in a way that is non-blocking and supportive. It can be presented as optional comments or perspectives without implying an intention to change the direction of the project.

5.Question

What are the three essential approaches to effective meetings?

Answer:The three essential approaches are: 1) Listen through questions to understand others' perspectives, 2) Define the purpose of the meeting to clarify goals, and 3) Read the room to gauge the mood and dynamics of the discussion.

6.Question

What challenges can arise when interacting with difficult individuals, and how should they be handled?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:When dealing with difficult individuals, or 'jerks', it is beneficial to include someone they respect in the meeting or to align with them beforehand to ensure their concerns are heard and to mitigate possible derailments in the discussion.

7.Question

What distinguishes effective leaders from those who dominate discussions?

Answer:Effective leaders prioritize finding the best outcomes for everyone and demonstrate a willingness to adapt their positions. They avoid dominating conversations and create space for others to share their insights.

8.Question

Why is learning to never be wrong a crucial skill for leaders?

Answer:This skill helps avoid conflict and fosters collaboration, allowing leaders to remain approachable and open-minded, which is essential for building sustainable relationships and maintaining team dynamics.

9.Question

How can one practice becoming more effective in

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

meetings and discussions?

Answer:Practice can occur in everyday interactions such as comments on documents or participating in meetings. One should deliberately choose a skill to focus on each week and practice applying it in various scenarios.

10.Question

What is the potential impact of personal conflict on complex projects?

Answer:Personal conflicts can derail projects more significantly than technical challenges. Building cooperative relationships can help mitigate tensions and foster teamwork, leading to smoother project execution.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Read, Share, Empower

Finish Your Reading Challenge, Donate Books to African Children.

The Concept

BOOKS FOR AFRICA × ×

This book donation activity is rolling out together with Books For Africa. We release this project because we share the same belief as BFA: For many children in Africa, the gift of books truly is a gift of hope.

The Rule

Earn 100 points → **Redeem a book** → **Donate to Africa**

Your learning not only brings knowledge but also allows you to earn points for charitable causes! For every 100 points you earn, a book will be donated to Africa.

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 13 | Create space for others| Q&A

1.Question

What does it mean to 'never be wrong' in a leadership context?

Answer:To 'never be wrong' means to approach situations with the mindset of seeking the best outcome for everyone, rather than insisting on your personal perspective. It involves creating a space where others can share their ideas and contribute to the discussion, allowing for collaborative decision-making that respects diverse viewpoints.

2.Question

How can engineers create space for others in discussions?

Answer:Engineers can create space for others by actively listening and asking thoughtful questions, clarifying the purpose of the discussion, and ensuring that everyone's perspectives are heard. This shifts the focus from a debate to collaborative problem-solving.

3.Question

What is the importance of reading the room during

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

meetings?

Answer:Reading the room is crucial because it helps understand the emotional climate and level of agreement among participants. By sensing whether the group is ready to reach a consensus or whether further discussion is needed, a leader can facilitate more productive meetings.

4.Question

Why is it important for leaders to practice listening and questioning in meetings?

Answer:Practicing listening and questioning is important because it fosters a culture of openness and collaboration. By demonstrating a willingness to learn from others, leaders can generate richer discussions and empower their teams to contribute meaningfully.

5.Question

What strategies can leaders employ when dealing with difficult personalities in meetings?

Answer:Leaders can handle difficult personalities by involving others who can mediate or provide support, and by

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

investing time to align with the individual prior to the meeting. Gathering feedback on their perspective before discussions can also reduce conflict.

6.Question

How can sponsorship help in leadership roles?

Answer:Sponsorship helps by empowering team members to take ownership of critical projects, fostering their development as leaders. A sponsor provides guidance and support, allowing the team to grow and take on significant challenges while ensuring that the work is collaborative.

7.Question

What shift occurs when a technical leader moves from being the 'go-to' person to creating space for others?

Answer:The shift involves transitioning from a role focused on personal contributions to one that emphasizes facilitating team success. This change encourages collaboration and enables others to step up, which ultimately benefits the organization by distributing knowledge and leadership.

8.Question

How can documenting decision-making processes

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

enhance team learning?

Answer:Documenting decision-making allows others to understand the rationale behind choices, fostering an environment of transparency. By following the thought process, team members can learn from both successes and failures instead of becoming dependent on directives.

9.Question

What role do good questions play in effective discussions?

Answer:Good questions can help clarify misunderstandings, spark engagement, and encourage deeper exploration of ideas. They shift the focus from defending a position to collaboratively uncovering solutions, thereby enriching the discussion.

10.Question

What is the relationship between personal impact and creating space for others?

Answer:Personal impact increases when leaders empower others by creating space for their contributions. This collaborative approach enhances team dynamics, fosters

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

innovation, and ultimately leads to better project outcomes.

Chapter 14 | Build a network of peers| Q&A

1.Question

What does it mean to create space for others in an organization?

Answer:Creating space for others means empowering your team to take initiative, make decisions, and lead projects rather than relying solely on your contributions. It's about fostering an environment where everyone feels safe to advocate for their ideas and contribute meaningfully, ultimately growing the organization's capability while reducing dependence on you.

2.Question

Why is it crucial for a Staff-plus engineer to involve others in discussions and decisions?

Answer:Involving others helps build trust, encourages diverse perspectives, and fosters a sense of ownership among team members. This leads to better decision-making while

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

also freeing you from the burden of being the sole contributor, allowing others to grow their skills and leadership capabilities.

3.Question

How can asking the right questions during discussions create a more inclusive environment?

Answer:By asking the right questions, you guide the conversation in a way that encourages participation from others. It shifts the focus from just providing answers to facilitating dialogue, making it easier for team members to contribute without feeling overshadowed by more dominant voices.

4.Question

What techniques can be employed to ensure quieter participants are engaged in discussions?

Answer:One effective method is to directly address quieter individuals, inviting them to share their thoughts one at a time. This targeted approach helps reduce the intimidation factor and encourages their participation without

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

overwhelming the group.

5.Question

What is the significance of separating style feedback from substance in decision-making?

Answer:Focusing on substance rather than style prevents unnecessary disruptions in the decision-making process. If feedback on style doesn't meaningfully impact the project's success, it may be better to keep it private, allowing decisions to be made more efficiently and effectively.

6.Question

What role does sponsorship play in leadership?

Answer:Sponsorship involves advocating for others to take on important work, providing the support they need to succeed. It is a way to cultivate talent within the organization, allowing others to step into leadership roles while sharing the recognition and rewards of collective success.

7.Question

How can senior staff maintain their context in projects while also prioritizing sponsorship?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:While sponsoring others is vital, it’s also necessary for senior staff to remain actively involved in certain projects to keep their understanding of the organization’s tools and processes relevant. Balancing both direct participation and sponsorship ensures ongoing growth and influence in leadership.

8.Question

How can building a personal network be beneficial for career advancement in engineering?

Answer:Having a network of peers provides support, accountability, and diverse insights that help navigate challenges in your career. It opens doors to mentorship, honest feedback, and collaborative opportunities, fostering growth and inspiration.

9.Question

What is the difference between visibility in a professional network and internal networking?

Answer:Visibility in a professional network entails being recognized and engaged outside your company, often

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

through public speaking, writing, or attending industry events. Internal networking focuses on building relationships within your organization to improve collaboration and access to resources.

10.Question

How can someone who is introverted successfully network with peers?

Answer:Introverts can effectively network by reaching out to individuals they respect with specific questions or requests for advice. Keeping it low-pressure and focused on mutual benefit can help build genuine connections over time.

Chapter 15 | Present to executives| Q&A

1.Question

Why is it important to build a personal network of peers as a Staff-plus engineer?

Answer:Developing a personal network allows you to have mentors and trusted individuals who can provide honest feedback, share experiences, and help you navigate career challenges. They offer

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

valuable perspectives and help you grow in your role.

2.Question

What strategies can I use to effectively build my network?

Answer:Two common strategies are being easy to find and networking internally. You can contribute to discussions, write about your experiences, or attend conferences to meet individuals in your field. Building relationships within your company is often more organic and can lead to quicker connections.

3.Question

How can attending conferences and speaking at them benefit my career?

Answer:Conferences are an excellent way to meet peers, share insights, and even discover job opportunities. Speaking at conferences can position you as a thought leader within your field and expand your network significantly.

4.Question

What is considered the best approach for communicating with executives during a presentation?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:Understand the purpose of your communication, which is often to report, plan, or resolve misalignment. Structure your documents clearly and address topics strategically to align with the executive's priorities and ensure productive discussions.

5.Question

How can I avoid common pitfalls during executive presentations?

Answer:Some pitfalls include resisting feedback, evading responsibility, presenting problems without solutions, and fixating on desired outcomes. It's crucial to embrace feedback, be upfront about issues, propose solutions, and remain open to evolving discussions.

6.Question

What role does social media play in building a network?

Answer:Using platforms like Twitter can help create an ambient learning network. By following industry leaders and engaging with relevant content, you can stay informed and expose yourself to new ideas and potential connections.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

7.Question

How should I approach someone I wish to network with?

Answer:Start by sending a brief email or message with a specific question, expressing your respect for their work. Following up afterward and progressing the conversation naturally over time can help build a meaningful connection.

8.Question

What is the significance of quality over quantity when building a network?

Answer:Focusing on trustworthy and inspiring relationships creates a more impactful network. It's not about the number of connections, but rather the depth and quality of those connections that will assist you in solving significant problems.

9.Question

What can I do if I'm introverted and struggle with networking?

Answer:Start small by reaching out to individuals you respect with specific inquiries. Gradual engagement will help you build confidence and relationships over time without

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

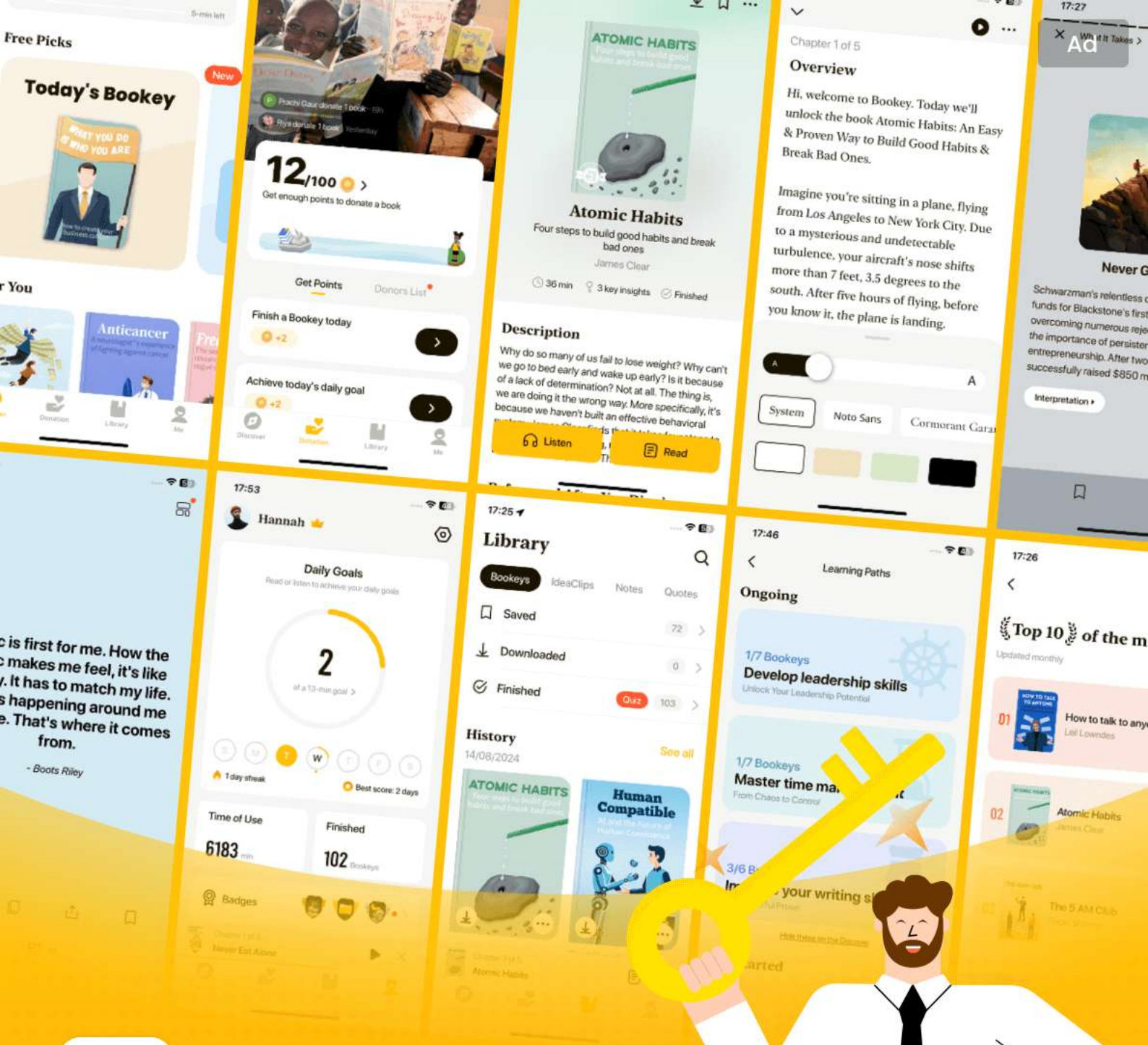
feeling overwhelmed.

10.Question

How do structured documents aid in effective communication?

Answer:They help refine your thoughts, clearly present the information needed by the audience, and align your ideas with the priorities of your audience, particularly in an executive setting.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It



World' best ideas unlock your potential

Free Trial with Bookey

Scan to download

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play

Chapter 16 | Promotion packets| Q&A

1.Question

What is the most common hindrance to becoming a Staff engineer within a company?

Answer:Promotion systems can impede progress after reaching the Senior level, as many companies have rigid expectations and protective cultures around Staff titles.

2.Question

How can one better prepare for the transition to a Staff engineer role?

Answer:Start writing your promotion packet long before you think you're ready for a Staff role; treat it like a roadmap that outlines your goals and progress.

3.Question

Why is visibility important for advancement to a Staff-plus role?

Answer:You won't get promoted if leadership doesn't know who you are. Becoming visible involves applying techniques consistently to get recognized internally.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

4.Question

What should an engineer do if the opportunities for advancement are unevenly distributed in their company?

Answer:Assess the fixability of such issues, realign your approach accordingly, and seek a senior sponsor to help address technological inequalities.

5.Question

Is management a necessary step to reaching the Staff level?

Answer:Not necessarily. Many successful Staff engineers do not come from management but trying management can provide valuable perspectives for future roles.

6.Question

What's a key mindset shift needed as you transition from being managed to self-directed in your career?

Answer:Recognize that the promotion and performance system is no longer designed for you; you need to take control of your progression and navigation.

7.Question

How can engineers ensure their promotion packet is

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

effective?

Answer:Continuously iterate on the packet with input from trusted peers and managers, focusing on clarity, gaps to address, and quantifiable impacts.

8.Question

What does it mean to temper your expectations regarding promotions?

Answer:Understand that promotions, especially to higher levels like Staff, can take time, and expect consistent effort over months or years rather than instant results.

9.Question

What is the relationship between a Staff engineer's role and leadership?

Answer:Staff-plus titles are leadership roles that require you to be seen as part of the leadership team; entitled individuals often find it easier to transition into these roles.

10.Question

How important is it to align personal ambitions with values in pursuing a Staff role?

Answer:Aligning your pursuits with what genuinely

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

energizes you is crucial; chasing a title for its own sake can lead to dissatisfaction in your career.

Chapter 17 | Find your sponsor| Q&A

1.Question

What is a common misconception about promotion packets for Staff-plus roles?

Answer:Many people view their promotion packet as the final step toward achieving a Staff-plus role, treating it as a capstone project. In reality, it's more effective to begin writing your promotion packet early, using it as a roadmap to guide your career development and goals.

2.Question

How should one approach building a promotion packet?

Answer:Start by documenting your achievements and projects, including specifics about their impact. Use a general template that covers key areas like the complexity of projects, improvements to the organization, mentoring efforts, and recognized contributions. This packet serves as a

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

guide, not just a final submission.

3.Question

What is the role of feedback in creating a promotion packet?

Answer:Feedback is crucial at every stage. Share your draft with trusted peers who are already in Staff-plus roles for insights, and then involve your manager for a more tailored review. Their perspective can help identify gaps and strengthen your case for promotion.

4.Question

What should be one’s mindset regarding expectations for promotion?

Answer:It's important to temper your expectations and understand that promotions take time. They are built over quarters and years, so avoid seeking instant results and instead focus on consistent development and proactive engagement.

5.Question

Why is having a sponsor important in the promotion process?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:A sponsor advocates for your work within the organization and helps navigate the promotion process. They play a critical role in highlighting your contributions during discussions and reviews, ensuring your efforts are recognized.

6.Question

How can one activate their sponsor's support?

Answer:To activate your sponsor, openly communicate your career goals and how they can assist you in achieving them. Build a collaborative effort by involving them in reviewing your promotion packet and seeking specific feedback about how to develop further.

7.Question

What can you do if your manager hasn’t promoted anyone before?

Answer:If your manager lacks experience with promotions, seek additional sponsors further up the hierarchy. Building relationships with skip-level managers can help ensure they are familiar with your work and impact when the time for

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

promotion discussions arises.

8.Question

How should one handle situations where their manager is not supportive?

Answer:If you and your manager are not working well together, it might hinder your promotion prospects. It’s crucial to put effort into improving the relationship first. If, after six months of proactive engagement, things don’t improve, it might then be time to explore moving teams or companies.

9.Question

What should you remember about the promotion process?

Answer:Remember, the promotion process is a team effort—not a solo endeavor. Consistently build relationships within your organization, seek feedback, and create avenues for your work to be recognized.

Chapter 18 | Staff projects| Q&A

1.Question

Why is having a sponsor crucial for career advancement

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

in engineering?

Answer:A sponsor is vital because they advocate for your work in influential spaces and help articulate your accomplishments in ways that management understands. Without a sponsor, your impact may go unrecognized, even if it is substantial.

2.Question

What is the difference between a Staff Engineer and a Senior Engineer?

Answer:A Staff Engineer is not merely a faster Senior Engineer; they operate at a higher impact level, often guiding projects and influencing outcomes across teams, whereas a Senior Engineer typically focuses more on technical execution.

3.Question

How can one activate their sponsor effectively?

Answer:To activate your sponsor, it’s essential to explicitly communicate your career goals, such as saying, 'I’m looking to be recognized as a Staff Engineer.' Additionally, you

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

should regularly engage with your sponsor, ask for their advice on gaps you're working to close, and seek out how you can assist them.

4.Question

What should you do if your working relationship with your manager is not strong?

Answer:If you and your manager are not effectively collaborating, you are unlikely to get promoted. It's advisable to invest effort in making the relationship work first. If it’s been six months and progress has not been made, consider discussing the situation with your skip-level manager for potential changes.

5.Question

What are the key characteristics that define a Staff project?

Answer:A Staff project typically is complex and ambiguous, requiring navigation through unclear problems, involves a variety of stakeholders, and is crucial enough to attract significant visibility within the organization.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

6.Question

Are Staff projects necessary for promotion to a Staff-plus role?

Answer:No, completing a Staff project is not universally required for promotion, but many companies informally enforce this expectation. It's possible to reach a Staff-plus title through other means, including a strong track record over time or transitioning through leadership roles.

7.Question

How can one demonstrate they are capable of handling a Staff project?

Answer:To demonstrate readiness for a Staff project, it's essential to align with your leadership, exhibit technical aptitude, and build recognition within your team. Show that you can handle previous responsibilities effectively.

8.Question

What types of questions should you ask your sponsor or manager to gain helpful feedback?

Answer:Ask specific questions that require detailed responses, such as, 'What caused my last promotion attempt

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

to be unsuccessful?' or 'How could I have handled the recent API refactor project more effectively?'. These questions help focus on areas for improvement.

9.Question

What distinguishes a minimal effort from a committed approach to working with sponsors?

Answer:A minimal effort might involve only reaching out to sponsors at promotion time, while a committed approach involves building a long-term relationship, consistently communicating, and actively supporting their initiatives throughout the year.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Try Bookey App to read 1000+ summary of world best books

Unlock 1000+ Titles, 80+ Topics

New titles added every week

Brand | Leadership & Collaboration | Time Management | Relationship & Communication

ness Strategy | Creativity | Public | Money & Investing | Know Yourself | Positive P

Entrepreneurship | World History | Parent-Child Communication | Self-care | Mind & Spi

Insights of world best books

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 19 | Get in the room, and stay there| Q&A

1.Question

What is the purpose of a Staff project in the context of promotion to a Staff-plus role?

Answer:A Staff project serves as a complex, significant undertaking that demonstrates an engineer's capacity to manage large, impactful initiatives. Completing a Staff project can serve as an indicator of readiness for promotion, showcasing both technical expertise and leadership skills. However, it's important to note that not all engineers pursue or need to complete a Staff project to achieve a Staff-plus title.

2.Question

Is it necessary to complete a Staff project to be promoted to a Staff-plus role?

Answer:No, it is not strictly necessary to complete a Staff project to achieve a Staff-plus role. Many engineers attain this title through a track record of success, switching

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

companies, or taking different career paths. While some companies may impose this requirement, a significant number do not, thus opening various avenues for promotion.

3.Question

What are the characteristics of a typical Staff project?

Answer:A typical Staff project is characterized by its complexity and ambiguity, involving ill-defined problems that require a thorough understanding and approach. They often include multiple stakeholders with diverging opinions and have high visibility within the organization, making the outcomes pivotal for both the company and the individual engineer.

4.Question

How can an engineer gain access to a Staff project?

Answer:To gain access to a Staff project, an engineer must build trust with their management, demonstrating technical aptitude and maintaining alignment with leadership. This includes being visible in the organization, actively communicating interest in taking on such a project, and

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

having a clear understanding of the pressing needs that the project addresses.

5.Question

What should an engineer consider when deciding whether to pursue a Staff project?

Answer:An engineer should weigh their goals for promotion against their aspiration for self-growth. While a Staff project can enhance skills and experience, pursuing such a project may not be optimal for immediate promotion if it distracts from other critical responsibilities. Long-term growth should be a significant factor in this decision.

6.Question

What strategies can an engineer use to effectively stay in decision-making rooms?

Answer:To stay in decision-making rooms, engineers should continue to bring valuable context into discussions, communicate clearly and concisely, remain flexible, and engage actively. Understanding the room's purpose and aligning with its objectives while maintaining a posture of

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

collaboration is key to being regarded as a meaningful contributor.

7.Question

What common mistakes can lead to being removed from important meetings?

Answer:Common pitfalls include misunderstanding the room's purpose, being dogmatic, withholding consent among peers, dominating conversations without contributing value, embarrassing one's sponsor, and failing to show up consistently. Avoiding these behaviors while aligning with the group's goals is crucial for maintaining a presence in such environments.

8.Question

How does leading a Staff project contribute to personal and professional development?

Answer:Leading a Staff project offers a unique opportunity for growth, as it challenges engineers to tackle significant problems, navigate ambiguity, and coordinate diverse stakeholders. The experience gained is invaluable, as it

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

builds confidence, hones problem-solving abilities, and prepares an engineer for higher levels of responsibility within the organization.

9.Question

Why is it important to bring something unique into the decision-making room?

Answer:Bringing something unique into the room enhances the collective problem-solving capacity of the group. It sets individuals apart, ensuring that their contributions are relevant and needed, which fosters greater engagement and positions them as valuable team members.

10.Question

What should engineers do if they find themselves in a meeting that feels unproductive?

Answer:If a meeting seems unproductive, it’s advisable to exit and seek more valuable opportunities elsewhere. However, while exiting, engineers should consider sponsoring someone else to take on the opportunity they are leaving, ensuring a continued flow of innovative

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

contributions in the organization.

Chapter 20 | Being visible| Q&A

1.Question

What is the significance of being 'in the room' when it comes to decision-making in a company?

Answer:Being 'in the room' means having access to discussions and decisions that directly affect you and your work. It provides context and insight into the company's direction, ensuring your contributions are informed and relevant.

2.Question

How can an engineer effectively get into the right room of power?

Answer:To get into the right room, an engineer should: bring something unique and useful, have a sponsor who advocates for their inclusion, and align with the group's goals while effectively communicating.

3.Question

Why is it important to stay in the room once you've entered?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:Staying in the room requires ongoing value contribution, understanding the room's purpose, and adapting to the discussions at hand. It's not just about getting in, but about being an engaged and adaptable participant.

4.Question

What tactics can someone use to ensure they are seen as a valuable member of the room?

Answer:To be seen as valuable, one can stay aligned with leadership, minimize friction in discussions, speak clearly and concisely, volunteer for tasks, and be prepared for meetings.

5.Question

What should you do if you feel a room is no longer beneficial?

Answer:If a room feels unproductive, it’s crucial to exit gracefully. Focus on finding and entering more relevant opportunities, while potentially sponsoring someone else for the opportunity you’re leaving.

6.Question

How does visibility within an organization influence your

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

career progression?

Answer:Visibility is crucial for promotions to leadership roles because it ensures that decision-makers recognize your contributions and abilities. Building a good reputation and being known for your work makes you a more attractive candidate for advancement.

7.Question

What are effective ways to increase internal visibility?

Answer:Engaging in high-impact projects, distributing important documentation, leading forums, sharing updates on your work, and actively participating in team discussions can all enhance internal visibility.

8.Question

Why is communication important when seeking visibility?

Answer:Effective communication ensures that your achievements are recognized, making it easier for leaders to acknowledge your work and potential for leadership roles.

9.Question

What are the potential pitfalls of being overly dogmatic in

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

discussions within a room?

Answer:Being dogmatic can create friction and slow down discussions, making it difficult for the group to make progress and potentially leading to removal from the room.

10.Question

How can someone balance the need for visibility with allowing others their opportunities?

Answer:It's vital to assess your visibility needs without overshadowing others. Focus on being a supportive team member and measure your visibility efforts against the collective needs and goals of the group.

Chapter 21 | Finding the right company| Q&A

1.Question

What should be considered when deciding whether to switch companies for a Staff-plus role?

Answer:You should evaluate your current company's potential for promotion, your internal reputation, and whether you feel you can grow within your current role. If after exploring these

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

factors you still feel stagnant or unsupported, switching companies may be worth considering.

2.Question

How can interviewing for a new role benefit you in your pursuit of a Staff-plus title?

Answer:Interviewing for new roles provides you with the chance to find a company that values your skills more highly. During the interview process, you gain a sponsor in the hiring manager who is incentivized to advocate for your promotion.

3.Question

What are the potential risks of staying at a company too long?

Answer:Staying in a stagnating role can hinder your growth and career trajectory, especially if you consistently miss out on promotion opportunities due to organizational constraints or a lack of sponsorship.

4.Question

How can internal mobility within the same company be beneficial?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:Switching roles internally can help you maintain your existing network while gaining new experiences and challenges without the need to build credibility from scratch in a new company.

5.Question

What steps should you take if you're feeling burned out in your role?

Answer:Explore the possibility of taking a sabbatical to recharge. If that's not feasible, evaluate your internal options for a role change or consider leaving without another job lined up if you are financially secure and have marketable skills.

6.Question

Why is finding a supportive company important for career advancement?

Answer:A supportive company will allow you to thrive and progress toward a Staff-plus title by providing ample opportunities for visibility, mentorship, and sponsorship from leaders who believe in your potential.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

7.Question

What characteristics should you look for in a potential new employer?

Answer:Look for a company that values your skills, has a culture aligned with your values, and offers opportunities for professional growth. Also, consider their stability and the potential for internal advancement.

8.Question

How does the company's growth rate impact career advancement opportunities?

Answer:Fast-growing companies typically have more leadership opportunities opening up as they expand, whereas slower-growing companies may limit the availability of Staff roles due to budget constraints or existing organizational structures.

9.Question

What can you do to ensure your job search for a leadership role is effective?

Answer:Utilize your network, target companies that value your specific skills, and thoroughly research the company's

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

culture, leadership, and opportunities for advancement to ensure alignment with your goals.

10.Question

What role does company sponsorship play in achieving a Staff-plus position?

Answer:Having a strong sponsor within the company who advocates for you can significantly enhance your chances of receiving a Staff-plus title. Without this endorsement, navigating organizational challenges becomes much more difficult.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Why Bookey is must have App for Book Lovers

30min Content
The deeper and clearer interpretation we provide, the better grasp of each title you have.

Text and Audio format
Absorb knowledge even in fragmented time.

Quiz
Check whether you have mastered what you just learned.

And more
Multiple Voices & fonts, Mind Map, Quotes, IdeaClips...

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 22 | Interviewing for Staff-plus roles| Q&A

1.Question

What should be considered when looking for a company to support a Staff-plus role?

Answer:The most critical factor is choosing a company that disproportionately values your skills and contributions. Identify companies that are aligned with your strengths, like Fastly valuing API design or Stripe appreciating compiler work. It's essential to find an environment conducive to your growth, where you are championed for your abilities rather than just fitting a mold.

2.Question

What is the difference between meritocratic and proceduralist companies?

Answer:Meritocratic companies rely heavily on exceptions and celebrate individual achievements, often valuing those who align with their definition of potential. Proceduralist companies, on the other hand, focus on consistent policies

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

and practices that ensure fairness but may come off as rigid or bureaucratic. You'll want to assess which style aligns with your career aspirations and personal working style.

3.Question

How can company growth impact the opportunities for obtaining a Staff-plus role?

Answer:In fast-growing companies, new leadership opportunities often arise organically, providing more pathways to roles like Staff-plus. Conversely, in slower-growing companies, you may need to wait for existing leaders to vacate positions, significantly slowing down your career trajectory.

4.Question

Why is having a sponsor important for achieving a Staff-plus role?

Answer:Securing a Staff-plus position requires an internal advocate who believes in your potential and is willing to navigate organizational challenges to get you promoted. Without a sponsor, advancing to such roles can be nearly

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

impossible.

5.Question

What factors contribute to the durability of a company when seeking a Staff-plus role?

Answer:It’s vital to evaluate a company’s long-term viability. Consider the sustainability of its business model and the alignment of your potential sponsors’ values with the company’s leadership. This alignment helps ensure that even if individual sponsors leave, their successors are likely to support your ambitions.

6.Question

What should be done before entering the interview process for a Staff-plus role?

Answer:Invest time refining your criteria for the types of companies you wish to join and the interview processes you are willing to engage in. Establish lines that you are not willing to cross, such as a company that overly emphasizes programming speed over thoughtful contributions.

7.Question

What approach can be taken if the interview process

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

seems unclear or poorly structured?

Answer:Ask the recruiting team for detailed insights about the interview structure. Successful candidates should fully understand the evaluation criteria, how interviews are formatted, and who will be assessing their skills. This clarity is crucial for effective preparation.

8.Question

What is the importance of networking in finding a good sponsor?

Answer:Building a strong external presence can attract potential sponsors who recognize your skills through your work, like presentations or writing. A broad network increases the chance of getting advocates who may champion you during the hiring process and subsequent promotions.

9.Question

How should candidates handle feedback from interview panels that may not have senior engineers?

Answer:If the interview panel lacks senior-level engineers who can adequately assess your expertise, raise your

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

concerns constructively. Engage the recruiting team to discuss how the structured evaluation process may better reflect the competencies needed for a Staff-plus role.

10.Question

Why is it important to finish the interview process well?

Answer:Closing the interview process thoughtfully—by following up with interviewers, providing references, and discussing role details—leaves a positive impression. This final step reflects professionalism and reinforces a candidate's interest, increasing the likelihood of receiving an offer.

Chapter 23 | Negotiating your offer| Q&A

1.Question

What should you do to prepare for a Staff-plus role interview compared to a Senior engineer role interview?

Answer:Unlike the more predictable process for Senior engineer interviews, preparing for a Staff-plus interview requires you to navigate ambiguity. You should spend time refining your

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

criteria for the kinds of processes you're willing to participate in and understand what the company looks for in Staff-plus interviews.

2.Question

Why is it important to draw lines when choosing interview processes?

Answer:Drawing lines helps you make deliberate decisions regarding your career trajectory. By establishing clear criteria for your interview processes, you can avoid roles that may not respect or utilize your skills effectively, ultimately ensuring you focus on opportunities that align with your long-term goals.

3.Question

How can you debug the interview process before it begins?

Answer:Ask the recruiting team and hiring manager for details about the interview format, what they will evaluate, and who will conduct the interviews. Understanding the process is vital to tailor your preparation and ensure it’s

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

suitable for a Staff-plus level.

4.Question

What signals might indicate a poor Staff-plus interview process?

Answer:If your interview panel predominantly consists of early-career and mid-level engineers, or if there are no opportunities for deep dives into your past accomplishments, it suggests the process may not effectively evaluate the expertise required for a Staff-plus position.

5.Question

What strategy can you employ to negotiate your offer after an interview?

Answer:Be proactive and strategic in your negotiations, focusing on aspects beyond just salary, like equity flexibility or additional vacation days. Frame your requests in a narrative that highlights their importance to you, making it easier for the company to understand your motivations.

6.Question

How does the company size influence the negotiation flexibility for a Staff-plus position?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:Larger companies with hundreds or thousands of employees are more likely to negotiate bespoke terms for senior roles since they have the operational capacity to do so. Conversely, smaller companies might have more rigid offers.

7.Question

What should you remember when finishing the interview process?

Answer:Always negotiate the details of the offer and follow up thoughtfully with interviewers. Send thank you emails, ask insightful questions, and ensure you leave a positive impression, as the last steps can significantly impact your transition into a new role.

8.Question

How can you gauge whether an interview process supports your goals effectively?

Answer:Evaluate whether the interview structure aligns with your career objectives and whether it allows you to demonstrate your strengths. If the process doesn’t seem fit, raise concerns constructively, ensuring it supports the

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

competencies required for a Staff-plus role.

9.Question

What common themes emerge in preparing for and navigating Staff-plus role interviews?

Answer:Preparation, self-advocacy, and clarity on your career goals are crucial. Understanding the interview process, asking the right questions, and reflecting on company signals will help you secure a position that truly matches your aspirations and expertise.

10.Question

What should you focus on when preparing for specific interview questions?

Answer:Take notes on your approach for different types of interview questions, prepare materials for any presentation formats, and research the interviewers to tailor your questions to their expertise—this helps you present yourself as a well-prepared candidate.

Chapter 24 | Michelle Bu - Payments Products Tech Lead at Stripe| Q&A

1.Question

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

What did you learn about the impact of feedback on your journey to becoming a Staff-plus engineer?

Answer:Feedback was crucial in my development as a Staff-plus engineer, especially because of my imposter syndrome. It drove me to seek feedback on every aspect of my work, which in turn helped me grow and improve. By being open to learning, I developed strong skills in listening and empathy, which became superpowers in my role.

2.Question

How did your perception of impact change when you transitioned to a leadership role?

Answer:In my previous role, impact felt tangible because it was directly linked to my work with users and projects. Now, I see impact as a result of empowering teams and shaping their paths. I feel energized by the progress of others rather than just my own contributions. This shift emphasizes creating leverage in my work by helping others succeed.

3.Question

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

What is the significance of being energizing rather than simply impactful in your role?

Answer:Being energizing means focusing on work that not only benefits the company but also keeps one engaged and motivated. For me, feeling energized comes from seeing others succeed or from being part of significant changes within the team. This internal motivation contributes to long-term satisfaction and effectiveness in my role.

4.Question

How do you balance empathy for engineers with less programming time as a Staff-plus engineer?

Answer:To maintain empathy, I engage with engineers through regular one-on-ones and stay connected with incidents reported within the company. This helps me understand their challenges firsthand and advocate for their needs, fostering a connection between leadership and engineering work.

5.Question

What advice do you have for engineers aspiring to reach Staff-plus roles?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:Focus on work that energizes you rather than solely chasing titles. Engage with projects that matter to you, challenge your skills, and align with your interests. Success in Staff roles comes from being able to identify impactful work and advocate for it within your organization.

6.Question

How has your role in sponsoring other engineers influenced your day-to-day work?

Answer:Sponsorship has been a fulfilling part of my role. It allows me to foster and elevate talent, providing space for individual contributors to shine. I find it rewarding to facilitate their growth while ensuring I'm not trying to claim credit for their success.

7.Question

What is your perspective on striking the right balance between personal interests and company goals in your career?

Answer:Finding alignment can be complex, but it's vital. I believe it's important to pursue your interests genuinely while ensuring they also bring value to the organization. This

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

alignment enhances motivation, commitment, and ultimately, success for both the individual and the company.

8.Question

Reflecting on your journey, what were the key factors that contributed to your promotion to the Staff level?

Answer:Key factors included my willingness to learn, deep care for the product and users, and the relationships I built. Being proactive about seeking feedback and taking responsibility for my work allowed me to grow from a high-performing engineer to a Staff-level engineer.

9.Question

What role does transparency play in managing ambitious design projects?

Answer:Transparency in communication and documentation is critical; it fosters trust and clarity among teams. By being explicit about processes, decisions, and encouraging feedback, teams can align better and navigate complexities together, which is essential in broad-scoped projects like API design.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

App Store
Editors' Choice

22k 5 star review

Positive feedback

Sara Scholz

tes after each book summary
erstanding but also make the
and engaging. Bookey has
ding for me.

Fantastic!!!

Masood El Toure

I'm amazed by the variety of books and languages Bookey supports. It's not just an app, it's a gateway to global knowledge. Plus, earning points for charity is a big plus!

Fi
Ab
bo
to
my

José Botín

ding habit
p's design
ual growth

Love it!

Wonnie Tappkx

Bookey offers me time to go through the important parts of a book. It also gives me enough idea whether or not I should purchase the whole book version or not! It is easy to use!

Time saver!

Bookey is my go-to app for
summaries are concise, ins
curated. It's like having acc
right at my fingertips!

Awesome app!

Rahul Malviya

I love audiobooks but don't always have time to listen to the entire book! bookey allows me to get a summary of the highlights of the book I'm interested in!!! What a great concept !!!highly recommended!

Beautiful App

Alex Walk

This app is a lifesaver for book lovers with busy schedules. The summaries are spot on, and the mind maps help reinforce wh I've learned. Highly recommend!

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 25 | Ras Kasa Williams - Staff Engineer at Mailchimp| Q&A

1.Question

How does Michelle define her role at Stripe as a Tech Lead, and how does it differ from the typical Staff Engineer role?

Answer:Michelle Bu describes her role as the Payments Products Tech Lead at Stripe, where she works closely with the Chief Product Officer and is responsible for supporting critical initiatives across the organization. She spends 80% of her time on large cross-organizational design projects and the remaining 20% on technical reviews, especially regarding API design. This differs from a typical Staff Engineer role at Stripe, which often involves working within specific teams; Michelle's focus is on broader projects that impact multiple teams.

2.Question

What is the significance of feeling 'energized' over 'impactful' in Michelle's work?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:Michelle prefers to describe her work as 'energizing' rather than 'impactful,' emphasizing an inward-looking perspective. This reflects her focus on finding fulfillment in her contributions rather than solely measuring success by company metrics. By prioritizing work that captures her interest and passion, she has maintained her motivation and enjoyment in her role at Stripe.

3.Question

Reflect on Michelle's experience of transition from being an engineer to a Tech Lead and the challenges she faced.

Answer:As Michelle transitioned to her role as a Tech Lead, she noticed a shift in expectations regarding her opinions in discussions, which felt isolating at times. She emphasized the importance of remaining engaged in meetings and providing feedback, highlighting the changes in her responsibilities and the social dynamics within her team as she moved into a more visible position.

4.Question

What strategies does Michelle use to maintain empathy for engineers' experiences in her leadership role?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:Michelle actively engages with engineers through one-on-ones and by following reported incidents within Stripe. By staying informed and involved in the day-to-day challenges engineers face, she strives to empathize with their experiences and advocate for their needs to the leadership. This proactive approach helps her cultivate a greater understanding of their realities, despite her reduced time spent on programming.

5.Question

How does sponsoring other engineers play a role in Michelle's experience and responsibilities?

Answer:Sponsoring is a crucial and rewarding aspect of Michelle's role. She values the opportunity to create spaces for individual contributors to engage in impactful work that excites them. This mentoring and sponsoring role allows her to help elevate others and distribute the recognition for work that might otherwise go unattended.

6.Question

What lessons did Michelle learn about growth and impact in her journey from a junior engineer to a Tech Lead?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:During her initial years, Michelle focused on user support and relationship building instead of technical challenges, which contributed to her eventual success as she developed a reputation for caring about users. Over time, her technical foundation grew through substantial projects, allowing her to move quickly to the Staff level. This highlights the importance of both technical skills and interpersonal relationships in career advancement.

7.Question

What specific advice does Michelle offer to aspiring Staff-plus engineers?

Answer:Michelle emphasizes the importance of pursuing work that energizes and motivates oneself rather than merely focusing on achieving a title. She suggests being proactive about building relationships, creating opportunities for others, and writing extensively to clarify ideas and facilitate effective communication. Engineers should focus on aligning their interests with the company's goals while maintaining their personal enthusiasm in their work.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

8.Question

How does Michelle’s experience debunk the idea that titles don't matter in the tech industry?

Answer:Michelle believes that titles carry weight, as her experiences demonstrate that holding the title of Staff Engineer has granted her greater agency, visibility, and opportunities to mentor others. She contrasts this with her previous experiences where she was less recognized, reinforcing that titles can enhance one's ability to influence and contribute meaningfully within an organization.

9.Question

In what ways did Michelle’s relationships with her peers and other teams contribute to her success?

Answer:Michelle’s ability to build relationships during her early years at Stripe allowed her to navigate challenges effectively, contributing to her promotion. By being helpful and supportive to her colleagues, she established connections that became crucial for collaboration in cross-functional projects, especially during her transition to more influential

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

roles.

10.Question

What lessons about communication and feedback does Michelle share in her journey to becoming a Tech Lead?

Answer:Michelle highlights the value of being open to feedback and actively seeking it throughout her career. She learned to craft narratives that communicate her contributions, using strategies like writing performance reviews in the third person to promote a more objective viewpoint. This approach has helped her build a coherent narrative of her impact and align her goals with organizational needs.

Chapter 26 | Keavy McMinn - Senior Principal Engineer at Fastly| Q&A

1.Question

What does it mean to think globally as a Staff Engineer?

Answer:Thinking globally as a Staff Engineer means understanding the entire company's business and product strategy and translating that into a technical strategy that enables your team to execute

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

effectively. It involves collaboration across departments to improve processes like hiring, onboarding, and production operations and to foster growth in both technical and social skills throughout the organization.

2.Question

How should a Staff-plus engineer spend their day-to-day time?

Answer:A Staff-plus engineer should balance technical leadership, project management, and team development. This includes defining technical strategies, mentoring team members, collaborating with stakeholders, and being involved in project management duties, all while maintaining a connection to hands-on technical work to stay grounded in the team's realities.

3.Question

What is one impactful way a Staff-plus engineer can support their peers?

Answer:One impactful way is by assisting teammates in

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

navigating complex technical problems. This could involve helping them evaluate options, trade-offs, and solutions to empower them to overcome challenges and drive projects forward, creating a collaborative environment that fosters mutual success.

4.Question

What has changed in your responsibilities after becoming a Staff Engineer?

Answer:As a Staff Engineer, I've experienced increased agency over my time and responsibilities, allowing for more organic mentoring and support of peers outside my immediate team. I can dedicate more effort to coaching others, which has become a rewarding aspect of my role.

5.Question

What advice would you give to someone just starting as a Staff Engineer?

Answer:Build relationships early and make a concerted effort to understand the social dynamics within your organization. It’s crucial to treat others’ perspectives kindly, listen

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

actively, and engage meaningfully with your colleagues. Additionally, don't expect to solve all of engineering's problems at once—focus on doing great work to establish your presence and gradually extend your influence.

6.Question

How do titles impact your work as a Staff Engineer?

Answer:Titles matter significantly in engineering roles. As a Staff Engineer, you gain more respect and agency in your projects, as well as a platform to advocate for changes—this enhances both your visibility and your impact within the organization.

7.Question

What are important practices for project management in a team without dedicated PMs?

Answer:Encouraging team members to take ownership of their projects, promoting proactive communication about risks and blockers, and advocating for incremental value delivery are key. This empowers individuals and cultivates a culture of responsibility.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

8.Question

What does effective communication look like for rapidly growing engineers?

Answer:Effective communication involves adapting your messaging based on the audience—whether they're engineering peers, management, or non-technical stakeholders. Sharing clear, concise narratives about technical decisions helps to align everyone's understanding and fosters collaboration.

9.Question

How can a Staff Engineer advocate for technology or process changes?

Answer:A Staff Engineer should engage collaboratively with different groups within the organization to discuss and present recommendations for technology or process changes. It involves doing thorough research and presenting trade-offs while remaining open to feedback.

10.Question

What is the best way to approach mentoring others in your role?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:Approach mentoring intentionally by creating opportunities for co-workers to develop their skills and gain visibility. Encourage them to ask questions and challenge assumptions, allowing them to grow by guiding them through real-world projects and applications.

Chapter 27 | Bert Fan - Senior Staff Engineer at Slack| Q&A

1.Question

How do you perceive your role as a Senior Principal Engineer and how does it differ from earlier roles in your career?

Answer:As a Senior Principal Engineer, I have the opportunity to lead strategic technical direction and decisions without needing to prove my credentials constantly. This trust allows me to carve out time for exploration and innovation that I may not have had as a regular engineer. It enables me to take a holistic view of projects and influence bigger decisions across teams, something I couldn't do at earlier stages.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

2.Question

What advice would you give to someone just starting as a Staff Engineer?

Answer:I recommend finding your support network and peers. As you ascend in your career, it can get lonely at the top. Having trusted colleagues to brainstorm with and challenge you is crucial for personal growth and fostering collaboration.

3.Question

What is your approach to advocating for technology and process changes? Can you provide an example?

Answer:My approach is collaborative; I gather data and present trade-offs rather than dictating decisions. For instance, I advocated for design documents for API changes to address pain points before writing any code. This proactive strategy ensures clarity and effectiveness in the development process.

4.Question

How have you successfully built trust within your organization?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:At Fastly, I was hired with explicit trust to figure out and lead on strategic initiatives. I built this trust by successfully delivering on projects and keeping an open line of communication about my progress and challenges, reinforcing my reliability.

5.Question

In what ways has public speaking influenced your career development?

Answer:Initially, it was a daunting experience for me, but accepting opportunities to speak at conferences opened doors for networking and job opportunities. Sharing knowledge has become an essential part of my professional growth.

6.Question

What are the key factors that contributed to your promotion to a Staff Engineer?

Answer:Changing companies played a significant role in my promotion. It allowed me to reshape my professional identity while demonstrating my skills through successful project deliveries. Additionally, having strong advocates within the

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

company helped elevate my chances.

7.Question

How have you sponsored other engineers in their careers?

Answer:While I haven't focused much on sponsorship recently, at GitHub, I actively supported junior engineers by assigning challenging tasks and advocating for their recognition to management, encouraging them to ask questions and seek clarity in their work.

8.Question

What should one keep in mind when considering moving into engineering management?

Answer:Before pursuing management, evaluate if you genuinely enjoy interacting with people and facilitating their growth. Management is not just about overseeing; it's about supporting and empowering others, which requires a different passion than pure engineering.

9.Question

How did transitioning to remote work impact your career trajectory?

Answer:Working remotely has always been my norm,

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

allowing me to establish connections across distributed teams. It’s been crucial for building relationships and serendipitously sparking conversations, which are vital in advancing my career.

10.Question

What are some recommended resources for aspiring engineers looking to grow?

Answer:Conferences have significantly impacted my learning, along with the works of seasoned engineers like Chad Fowler and Dave Thomas. Their books, 'The Passionate Programmer' and 'The Pragmatic Programmer,' are invaluable resources for anyone in the engineering field.

11.Question

What common pitfalls might one encounter in the journey to becoming a Staff Engineer?

Answer:It’s important to recognize that promotions can be influenced by luck and timing as much as skill. Understand that not every situation is meritocratic, and sometimes a shift to another company might be necessary if progress stalls.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Read, Share, Empower

Finish Your Reading Challenge, Donate Books to African Children.

The Concept

BOOKS FOR AFRICA × ×

This book donation activity is rolling out together with Books For Africa. We release this project because we share the same belief as BFA: For many children in Africa, the gift of books truly is a gift of hope.

The Rule

Earn 100 points → **Redeem a book** → **Donate to Africa**

Your learning not only brings knowledge but also allows you to earn points for charitable causes! For every 100 points you earn, a book will be donated to Africa.

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 28 | Katie Sylor-Miller - Frontend Architect at Etsy| Q&A

1.Question

What is the primary goal of a Senior Staff Engineer at Slack?

Answer:The primary goal is to enable developers to build on top of Slack, making customers' working lives simpler, more pleasant, and more productive.

2.Question

What differentiates a Staff-plus engineer's role from that of junior engineers?

Answer:Staff-plus engineers often serve as tech leads for projects, mentor other engineers, and focus on enabling better work by others, while junior engineers typically focus more on individual tasks and coding.

3.Question

How can a Staff-plus engineer stay connected with the technical work despite spending less time coding?

Answer:Regular one-on-ones with engineers across the company help maintain awareness of the current state of

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

engineering, as they foster candid relationships where engineers feel comfortable sharing their thoughts.

4.Question

What factors contributed most significantly to Bert reaching Staff Engineer level?

Answer:His privileged background, education in computer science without debt, the flexibility to choose job opportunities based on meaningful projects, and establishing trust through successful project deliveries.

5.Question

What advice would you give to someone who just started as a Staff Engineer?

Answer:Focus on developing interpersonal skills, work on building trust with teams, give and receive feedback effectively, and become an engineer that people want to collaborate with.

6.Question

What does the process of getting promoted to Staff Engineer involve?

Answer:It typically requires developing trust with

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

management, delivering impactful projects, and ensuring one's work is visible and recognized within the organization.

7.Question

What is one common misconception about becoming a Staff Engineer?

Answer:Many believe that becoming a Staff Engineer means gaining control and a clear path for work, but it often involves navigating ambiguity and influencing others without authority.

8.Question

What is the role of networking in reaching a Staff Engineer position?

Answer:Developing a strong network, especially with Directors and VPs, is crucial as they have the power to advocate for promotions and ensure your contributions are known.

9.Question

How does Bert recommend keeping a pulse on company culture and engineering practices?

Answer:Participate actively in discussions, hold regular

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

one-on-ones, mentor others, and connect with various teams across the organization.

10.Question

What is a key skill for Staff Engineers that transcends technical expertise?

Answer:The ability to think about engineering decisions as trade-offs and articulate those trade-offs effectively is vital.

Chapter 29 | Ritu Vincent - Staff Engineer at Dropbox| Q&A

1.Question

What is the importance of web performance in today's online marketplaces?

Answer:Web performance is crucial for online retailers like Etsy because it influences search engine rankings, user experience, and ultimately conversion rates. With Google prioritizing web performance as part of its SEO criteria, ensuring fast loading times and responsive interfaces becomes essential in attracting and retaining customers. Companies that neglect this can fall behind competitors that

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

prioritize performance.

2.Question

How do roles and responsibilities differ among staff engineers at Etsy?

Answer:At Etsy, staff engineers can fall into two categories: tech leads who focus on guiding their team and managing projects, and architects who think broadly about cross-team problems and drive systemic improvements. Both roles are vital, but they require different skill sets - tech leads might dive into project coordination, while architects focus on wider technical strategies and influences across the company.

3.Question

How can engineers quantify their impact in staff-level roles?

Answer:Quantifying impact can be challenging in these roles due to the broad scope of responsibilities. Engineers can document their contributions by maintaining logs of meetings, project milestones, and insights they provide to other teams. Reflecting on these notes during goal check-ins

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

helps visualize their cumulative influence, even if daily tasks seem small.

4.Question

What role does networking play in maintaining empathy and awareness in remote engineering?

Answer:Networking is critical for remote engineers to stay connected and understand their organization. Regular one-on-ones, participating in Employee Resource Groups, and interacting across teams help to keep a pulse on developments and issues within the company, ensuring that even without direct development work, engineers remain aware of their colleagues' challenges.

5.Question

What advice do you have for aspiring staff engineers regarding communication and visibility?

Answer:Aspiring staff engineers should be open and candid with their managers about their career aspirations and developments. Establishing a strong, honest relationship promotes visibility and increases opportunities for

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

sponsorship within the organization, essential for career advancement in technical roles.

6.Question

What does it mean to find 'influence without authority' in a staff engineer role?

Answer:'Influence without authority' requires staff engineers to leverage their technical expertise and interpersonal skills to guide decisions and actions of others without formal power. Successful staff engineers advocate for significant changes, align teams around common goals, and inspire colleagues through collaboration and open discussions, rather than through directives.

7.Question

How can engineers effectively identify impactful problems to solve?

Answer:Engineers can effectively identify impactful problems by actively listening to feedback from various teams, understanding user experiences, and analyzing performance data. By synthesizing insights from different

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

departments, they can propose innovative solutions to persistent challenges that enhance productivity and workflow across the organization.

8.Question

What characteristics do successful staff engineers possess?

Answer:Successful staff engineers tend to possess strong communication skills, technical proficiency, strategic thinking, empathy for users, and a proactive mindset, capable of identifying problems and rallying teams to address them. They also understand organizational dynamics and can navigate complex relationships to foster collaboration.

9.Question

How do mentoring and sponsorship influence career growth for engineers?

Answer:Mentoring and sponsorship are crucial in engineering careers as they provide guidance, support, and visibility in the workplace. Engineers who are mentored often gain confidence and are encouraged to pursue

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

challenging projects and leadership roles, while sponsors actively advocate for their progression, helping them secure promotions and opportunities.

10.Question

What is the vital role of empathy in engineering, particularly for frontend engineers?

Answer:Empathy allows engineers, especially those working on front-end systems, to design solutions that resonate with users' needs and experiences. Understanding the user journey enables engineers to create more intuitive interfaces and improve overall product accessibility and usability, leading to supportive and engaging user interactions.

Chapter 30 | Rick Boone - Strategic Advisor to Uber’s VP of Infrastructure| Q&A

1.Question

What is the importance of taking risks and pushing beyond your comfort zone in your career?

Answer:Pushing beyond your comfort zone is essential for growth. Ritu shares that early in her career, she was more inclined to ask for projects she

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

felt she could execute well on, rather than those that were ambiguous and challenging. Moving into a Staff Engineer role requires one to embrace the discomfort of ambiguity and seek out hard projects to truly grow and expand their skills.

2.Question

How does collaboration and visibility within your company play a role in career advancement?

Answer:Visibility is crucial in advancing your career, as demonstrated by Ritu’s experience. By taking on roles outside of her core engineering responsibilities, like assisting with recruiting and running the intern program, she gained recognition across the company. This visibility combined with effective advocacy can accelerate career growth.

3.Question

What advice would you give to someone just starting as a Staff Engineer?

Answer:Ritu emphasizes the importance of being open and honest with your manager about your career aspirations. A

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

common mistake is telling your manager what you think they want to hear, rather than your actual feelings about projects or challenges. Clear communication can foster a supportive relationship that can help you thrive!

4.Question

Why is mentorship significant in your role as a Staff Engineer?

Answer:Mentorship plays a crucial role in Ritu's responsibilities. She focuses on being a visible role model for other engineers, particularly those from underrepresented backgrounds. She believes that providing guidance and support can significantly impact others' careers, potentially offering them the push they need to succeed.

5.Question

How can someone overcome imposter syndrome as they advance in their engineering career?

Answer:Ritu reflects on her realization that many engineers, even the most confident ones, also struggle with imposter syndrome. She encourages others to acknowledge their value

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

and contributions within their teams. Building confidence through supportive mentorship and recognizing shared struggles can help combat feelings of inadequacy.

6.Question

What do you consider a pivotal project in your engineering career?

Answer:One of Ritu's most significant projects was leading a major overhaul of the engineering levels at Dropbox. This initiative, which affected every person in the engineering and product teams, pushed her outside her comfort zone and taught her how to manage cultural and organizational growth within a large team.

7.Question

How do you define your impact in a role like Staff Engineer?

Answer:Ritu believes her impact is measured not just by what she completes in the short term, but by the longer-term influence of her actions on the company’s trajectory. Working on the incubator, her role involves fostering

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

innovation that could lead to future business opportunities for Dropbox.

8.Question

What lessons did you learn from taking on different roles and responsibilities throughout your career?

Answer:Ritu learned that each role provided a different lens through which to view engineering and collaboration. Her varied experiences, from coding to mentoring to managing, help her appreciate the multifaceted nature of organizational dynamics and how to effectively lead diverse teams towards common goals.

9.Question

What are the key attributes of a successful Staff Engineer within a company?

Answer:Key attributes include strong communication skills, technical expertise, the ability to mentor others, and a willingness to embrace ambiguity. Ritu notes that successful Staff Engineers also possess a collaborative spirit and actively contribute to the broader goals of the organization

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

beyond their immediate responsibilities.

10.Question

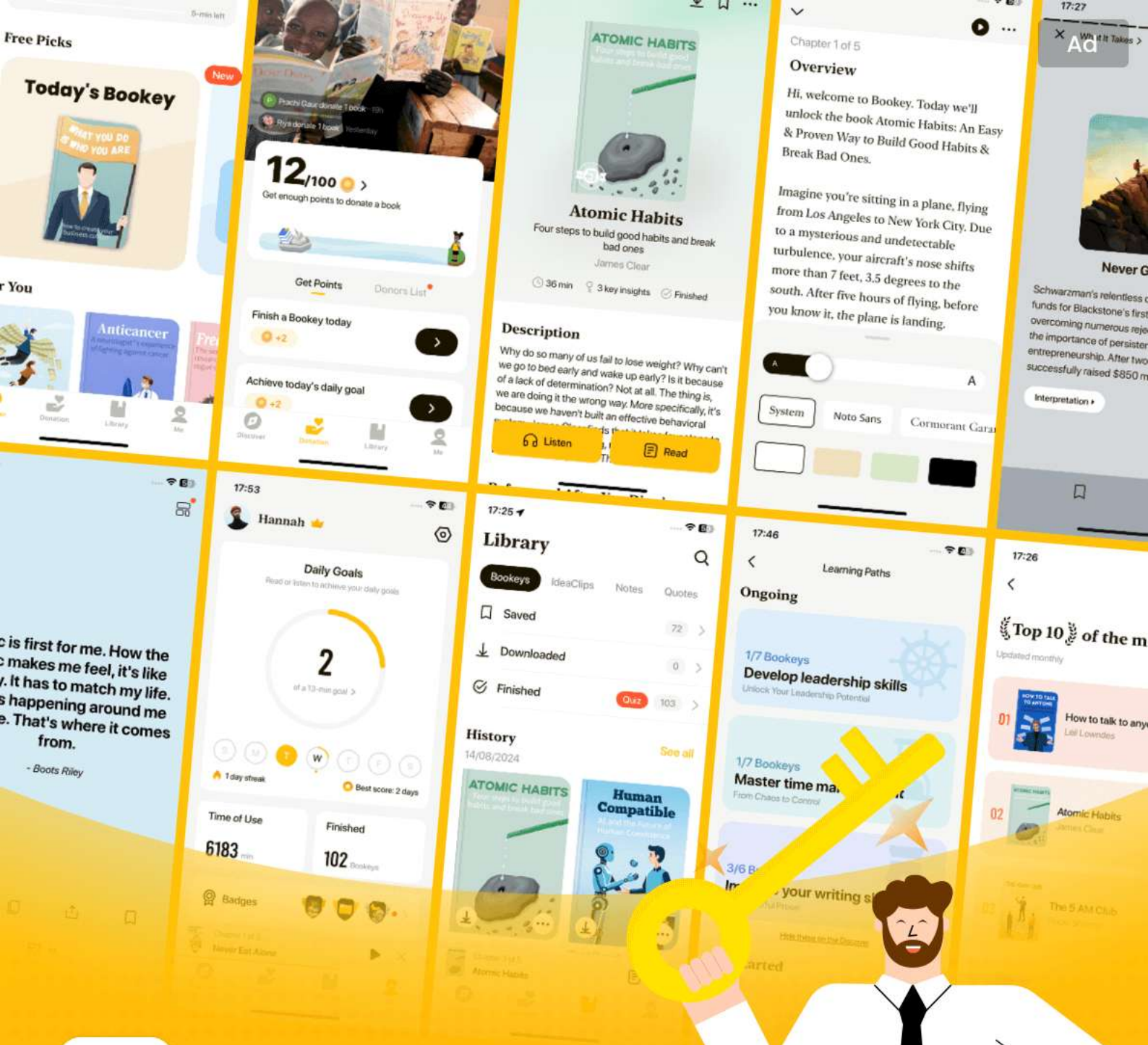
How do you stay current and engaged outside of your immediate technical responsibilities?

Answer:Ritu maintains her technical awareness by sitting near her old team and actively engaging in conversations with colleagues about their challenges. She makes it a point to keep informed about ongoing projects and seeks feedback on developer experience, combining technical discussions with her leadership role.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It



World' best ideas unlock your potential

Free Trial with Bookey

Scan to download

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play

Chapter 31 | Nelson Elhage - Formerly Staff Engineer at Stripe| Q&A

1.Question

What does it mean to be a Strategic Advisor at Uber, according to Rick Boone?

Answer:Being a Strategic Advisor entails a broad role that involves assessing technology needs, prioritizing innovation, streamlining projects, and ensuring alignment between teams, which together contribute to shaping technical and cultural strategy at Uber.

2.Question

How does alignment with a sponsor impact the effectiveness of a role?

Answer:Alignment with a sponsor, like the relationship between Rick and the VP, is crucial for effectiveness as it fosters trust and ensures that the advisor can act as a proxy, communicating and executing strategies faithfully.

3.Question

What unique aspects of Rick Boone's role set it apart

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

from traditional engineering roles, such as Technical Project Managers?

Answer:Unlike Technical Project Managers, who focus on operationalizing projects, Rick's role emphasizes strategic insight, organizational culture, and problem-solving on a more personal level, integrating psychological aspects into engineering decisions.

4.Question

What are some of the challenges Rick faced in his career when stepping into the Strategic Advisor role?

Answer:One of his challenges was overcoming imposter syndrome as he transitioned from using his own name to representing the VP's decisions, which required him to adapt and build a deeper understanding of the VP’s philosophy.

5.Question

How can mentorship shape a career according to Rick Boone?

Answer:Rick emphasizes mentorship's transformative power, revealing that having mentors throughout his life

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

significantly influenced his trajectory and confidence, leading him to become a mentor himself and positively impact others.

6.Question

What key piece of advice does Rick want to share with engineers starting their career journeys?

Answer:He suggests following one’s passions and being open to mentorship, as well as understanding the importance of building relationships with leadership to facilitate better teamwork and project execution.

7.Question

How can engineers effectively stay connected to ongoing projects in an evolving role?

Answer:Rick advocates for actively engaging with engineering teams, asking for feedback on their experiences, and even participating in non-critical path work to maintain a connection with the practical coding work.

8.Question

What motivates Rick Boone in his mentoring efforts?

Answer:Rick’s motivation stems from his desire to serve as a

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

visible reference for minority engineers and to empower others, especially those just entering engineering, by sharing his experiences and guidance.

9.Question

How does Rick suggest engineers maintain awareness of ground realities in their projects?

Answer:He recommends routinely checking in with teams, listening to their challenges, and engaging in their discussions to stay informed about the operational realities they face.

10.Question

What impact does Rick believe organizational culture has on engineering success?

Answer:Rick believes that organizational culture and psychology are often the 'hidden x-factors' that distinguish great organizations, as they directly influence team dynamics and project outcomes.

11.Question

What advice does Rick give about focusing on specific projects?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:He advises engineers to prioritize and focus deeply on one or two impactful projects at a time rather than spreading efforts too thin across many, as this leads to more significant results.

12.Question

What characteristics are important for a Staff-plus engineer based on Rick's experiences?

Answer:A Staff-plus engineer should have a broad understanding of the organization, the ability to connect projects across teams, and the skills to advocate effectively for priorities and strategies that align with the overall vision.

13.Question

Can Rick share an impactful decision made during his role that highlighted the importance of inter-team relationships?

Answer:He cites instances where he actively facilitated connections between teams that had previously been siloed, allowing for better communication and more effective collaboration on shared challenges.

14.Question

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

What does Rick’s journey illustrate about professional development in the engineering field?

Answer:Rick’s journey illustrates the importance of being adaptable, seeking mentorship, prioritizing emotional intelligence, and being proactive in creating opportunities for oneself in the engineering field.

Chapter 32 | Diana Pojar - Staff Data Engineer at Slack| Q&A

1.Question

What did you learn about the role of a Staff Engineer at Stripe?

Answer:A Staff Engineer at Stripe must have a broad understanding of the organization's moving parts, be capable of identifying and solving significant engineering problems, and help shape both technical and organizational strategies. It's crucial to have a global perspective on challenges and to facilitate cross-team communication to address dependency issues.

2.Question

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

How can one maintain focus on deliverables when faced with multiple projects?

Answer:Prioritization is key. It’s important to recognize that while it’s tempting to push several initiatives forward at once, concentrating efforts on one or two projects at a time often yields better results. With extensive responsibilities and potential distractions, a Staff Engineer should actively decide which projects to prioritize to effectively drive change.

3.Question

What advice do you have for new Staff Engineers regarding relationship-building?

Answer:Investing in relationships with engineering leadership is crucial. Understanding their vision, priorities, and the challenges they perceive helps in aligning your initiatives with organizational goals. Building rapport creates opportunities for collaboration and enhances your impact when proposing changes.

4.Question

What is the significance of context in decision-making as a Staff Engineer?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:Having comprehensive historical context can inform better decisions, while also potentially hindering new initiatives due to past failures. Balancing the need to bring valuable insights from history while maintaining an open mind to new solutions is vital in navigating engineering challenges.

5.Question

How can ambitious projects shape an engineer's path to becoming Staff Engineer?

Answer:Working on ambitious projects, like leading the Data Model Stripe Release Plan, not only enhances visibility within the organization but also allows an engineer to showcase their capability to drive meaningful change. These experiences accumulate into a portfolio of evidence that supports their promotion.

6.Question

What should someone who just became a Staff Engineer focus on?

Answer:It's essential to embrace both technical and soft

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

skills, considering leadership opportunities and navigating complex interpersonal dynamics. A focus on improving process, advocating for technical changes, and mentoring others can also enhance both personal growth and the surrounding team's performance.

Chapter 33 | Dan Na - Staff Engineer and Team Lead at Squarespace| Q&A

1.Question

What role does culture play in a Staff Engineer's responsibilities?

Answer:Culture is a vital aspect of a Staff Engineer's role; they must be proactive in addressing and improving the culture within their organization. This includes fostering open communication, creating opportunities for team bonding, and ensuring that all voices are heard in discussions. A Staff Engineer has the responsibility to not only advocate for technical excellence but also to enhance the workplace environment, making it supportive and inclusive for everyone.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

2.Question

How can you advocate for others in your engineering team?

Answer:Advocating for others can involve creating platforms where junior team members can showcase their work, encouraging peer-to-peer recognition in meetings, and providing opportunities for less experienced engineers to take ownership of projects. This fosters a sense of belonging and encourages professional growth among colleagues.

3.Question

What is the significance of trusting your own abilities as a Staff Engineer?

Answer:Believing in one's capabilities is crucial in overcoming impostor syndrome, which many engineers experience. Fostering self-confidence enables a Staff Engineer to take on challenges that would help in personal and organizational growth. By recognizing their worth and contributions, they can influence important discussions, drive meaningful change, and mentor others.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

4.Question

What advice do you have for engineers aspiring to become Staff Engineers?

Answer:Aspiring Staff Engineers should focus on expanding their responsibilities beyond just coding. They need to engage in leadership, mentorship, and cross-team collaboration while seeking opportunities that challenge and grow their technical and interpersonal skills. Alongside technical expertise, developing effective communication skills is crucial.

5.Question

How does having a Staff Engineer title impact your influence in the organization?

Answer:The title of Staff Engineer comes with inherent privileges, increased respect, and credibility, which significantly enhances one's ability to influence decisions within the organization. This title allows for greater participation in strategic discussions and the opportunity to advocate for impactful projects that align with company

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

goals.

6.Question

Why is mentorship important in your journey as a Staff Engineer?

Answer:Mentorship plays a critical role in personal development and navigating career challenges. Having mentors can guide engineers through complex situations, provide invaluable advice, and foster a supportive network. As a Staff Engineer, it is essential to pay this forward by mentoring others, thereby cultivating a culture of growth and empowerment.

7.Question

What qualities should a Staff Engineer possess to drive change in their organization?

Answer:A Staff Engineer should have strong technical acumen, but equally important are empathy, communication skills, and strategic thinking. They must be able to understand diverse perspectives, collaborate effectively with various teams, and champion processes that enhance

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

productivity and morale. Being adaptable and open to feedback is also crucial in driving sustainable change.

8.Question

How do you balance technical responsibilities with leadership duties?

Answer:Balancing both requires careful prioritization and an awareness of when to step back from hands-on coding to focus on broader organizational goals. This means sometimes delegating technical tasks to team members, thereby empowering them while ensuring that the overall engineering strategy remains aligned with the company's objectives.

9.Question

What is the most significant challenge Staff Engineers face, and how do they overcome it?

Answer:One of the key challenges is managing the invisible workload that comes with leadership, such as fostering team dynamics and influencing culture. Staff Engineers overcome this by being intentional about their relationships, actively listening to their peers, and creating processes that support a

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

collaborative environment.

10.Question

How important is continuous learning and self-reflection for a Staff Engineer?

Answer:Continuous learning and self-reflection are essential for growth. Staff Engineers should regularly assess their contribution, seek feedback, and stay updated with industry trends to remain effective. This proactive approach helps them tailor their leadership style, adapt to changes, and enhance their technical capabilities.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Try Bookey App to read 1000+ summary of world best books

Unlock 1000+ Titles, 80+ Topics

New titles added every week

Brand | Leadership & Collaboration | Time Management | Relationship & Communication

ness Strategy | Creativity | Public | Money & Investing | Know Yourself | Positive P

Entrepreneurship | World History | Parent-Child Communication | Self-care | Mind & Spi

Insights of world best books

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 34 | Joy Ebertz - Senior Staff Software Engineer at Split| Q&A

1.Question

What are some challenges a Staff Engineer might face in their role?

Answer:Staff Engineers often deal with the complexity of balancing technical responsibilities with broader organizational leadership. They must navigate the challenges of influencing without direct authority, ensuring alignment across teams, and owning problems that might not fall directly under their purview. This could include advocating for cultural changes or improvements in the engineering onboarding process.

2.Question

How can a Staff Engineer effectively advocate for technology and process changes?

Answer:An effective strategy is to present clear, evidence-based cases for change, grounded in experiences and insights from previous roles. Building credibility through

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

consistent communication and internal presentations can also encourage others to align with technology or process initiatives. Engaging with stakeholders early and often, and ensuring that their concerns are heard and addressed, can help create buy-in for proposed changes.

3.Question

What is the significance of sponsorship in a Staff Engineer's role?

Answer:Sponsorship is crucial for fostering growth within an engineering team. It involves creating opportunities for less senior team members to showcase their work, encouraging them at meetings, and promoting their contributions to a broader audience within the organization. This responsibility not only aids in personal development for team members but also strengthens the overall team and company culture.

4.Question

How does one transition from a coding-centric role to a Staff Engineer position?

Answer:Transitioning to a Staff Engineer role often means

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

moving from a hands-on coding position to one that focuses more on strategy, mentorship, and technical leadership. While technical skills are still important, the emphasis shifts to understanding broader system challenges, leading initiatives, and influencing architectural decisions across teams.

5.Question

What advice would you give to someone starting in a Staff Engineer position?

Answer:Focus on amplifying your strengths while being aware of your weaknesses. Take responsibility for not just your work, but also for the larger engineering issues. Build relationships across teams, engage in broader conversations about the company's technical direction, and don't hesitate to take initiative where you see opportunities for improvement.

6.Question

Can you describe how to approach the promotion process for a Staff Engineer role?

Answer:Crafting a promotion case involves demonstrating

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

not only your achievements and contributions but also your growth in abilities. It's helpful to write this case early to identify any gaps, gather feedback, and understand where you may need to improve. Clearly articulate your narrative and align your experiences with the desired competencies of the role.

7.Question

What role do organizational culture and teamwork play in the success of a Staff Engineer?

Answer:Organizational culture significantly impacts a Staff Engineer's ability to effect change and drive projects forward. A supportive culture fosters open communication, encourages collaboration, and values input from all levels. This environment allows a Staff Engineer to influence positively, mentor others, and spearhead innovations within the engineering team.

8.Question

Reflecting on your journey, what have you learned from mentoring others?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:Mentoring allows for reciprocal learning; it challenges the mentor to clarify their thoughts and consider different perspectives. It fosters a culture of support and growth within the team, demonstrating that everyone has unique insights and contributions, which ultimately enhances the team's overall performance and cohesion.

9.Question

What qualities differentiate a great Staff Engineer from a good one?

Answer:A great Staff Engineer possesses a blend of technical expertise and strong interpersonal skills. They exemplify leadership by fostering collaboration, communicating effectively across teams, and encouraging innovation. Their ability to navigate complex organizational challenges and advocate for their team while driving results sets them apart.

Chapter 35 | Damian Schenkelman - Principal Engineer at Auth0| Q&A

1.Question

What does it mean to take ownership and responsibility as a Staff-plus engineer?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:Taking ownership as a Staff-plus engineer means seeing all problems as your own responsibility. It’s about driving improvements, engaging in discussions about vision, and ensuring everyone is aligning with that vision, rather than shifting the blame or responsibility onto others.

2.Question

What is the significance of having a clear technical vision for a team?

Answer:A clear technical vision helps unify the team’s direction, enabling everyone to make incremental improvements that align with long-term goals. When all members understand the vision, it fosters collaboration and accountability, ensuring that even small changes contribute towards achieving a common objective.

3.Question

How can writing, such as blogging, assist a technical professional in networking?

Answer:Writing strengthens networking by providing a

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

platform to share insights and engage with the community. It allows one to showcase expertise and connect with others who may be interested in similar topics, facilitating introductions that might not occur in face-to-face settings.

4.Question

What is the role of sponsorship in developing other engineers?

Answer:Sponsorship is essential in nurturing talent by advocating for promising individuals, promoting their visibility, and securing them opportunities for growth. It involves mentoring and encouraging them to take on challenges, thus helping them advance in their careers.

5.Question

How should someone approach the promotion process within their company?

Answer:Approach the promotion process proactively by preparing a case for your achievements well before you feel ready. Be aware of potential gaps in your experience or contributions and seek to address those gaps while

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

showcasing your strengths. Seek feedback actively to refine your case.

6.Question

What practices help maintain a connection with hands-on development as a non-coding Staff-plus engineer?

Answer:To stay connected with hands-on development, regularly engage with team members through 1:1s, attend technical discussions, and participate in projects. Reading relevant blogs, attending workshops, or leading smaller initiatives also helps keep one updated on current technologies.

7.Question

What are some key factors that contribute to climbing the engineering ladder to roles like Staff or Principal Engineer?

Answer:Key factors include finding opportunities to lead initiatives, gaining visibility for your contributions, and being part of environments that encourage growth. Additionally, a mix of having strong technical skills, effective communication, and being approachable

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

significantly impacts career progression.

8.Question

Can you explain the importance of advocating for architectural or process changes in an engineering organization?

Answer:Advocating for architectural or process changes is vital for improving the efficiency and effectiveness of teams. It helps to preempt potential pitfalls and guides teams towards best practices, ensuring that development efforts are sustainable and aligned with strategic goals.

9.Question

In what ways does the journey to becoming a Staff Engineer differ from that of a typical engineering position?

Answer:The journey to becoming a Staff Engineer emphasizes leadership and influence over direct coding work. It involves greater responsibility in mentoring others, driving technical vision, and aligning broader organizational goals, which requires developing strong communication and advocacy skills.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

10.Question

What have you learned from sponsorship experiences that can help others?

Answer:From sponsorship experiences, it's evident that recognizing potential in others and actively promoting their growth opportunities can significantly impact their careers. It’s crucial to create a culture of encouragement and visibility, to ensure talented individuals can step into roles that showcase their abilities.

Chapter 36 | Dmitry Petrashko - Tech Advisor to the Head of Infra at Stripe| Q&A

1.Question

What is the most impactful role of a Principal Engineer at Auth0 according to Damian Schenkelman?

Answer:The biggest impact comes from helping achieve 'people scale', which means influencing the work of many people internally, aligning the entire company towards common goals, and addressing long-term strategic initiatives rather than just coding solutions for immediate problems.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

2.Question

How did Damian approach the issue of lack of clarity in technical strategy at Auth0?

Answer:Damian identified confusion about the technical direction of the company among teams. He addressed this by creating a documented technical strategy that outlined what technologies and approaches should be pursued for consistency and clarity, thus empowering teams to make informed decisions.

3.Question

What advice does Damian give to new Staff Engineers about defining expectations?

Answer:He advises them to communicate with as many people as possible to understand what is expected in their role and to be patient, as the impact of their work may take time to be realized, especially when influencing others.

4.Question

What does Damian mean by saying that scaling requires patience, and how does it relate to achieving long-term company goals?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:Damian illustrates that scaling is like a ground war requiring persistent effort over time. It emphasizes the importance of aligning the company around common goals and taking the necessary time to implement changes that will have lasting impact, rather than seeking quick fixes.

5.Question

What strategies does Damian suggest for maintaining relevance in a rapidly evolving technology landscape?

Answer:He suggests keeping informed through regular communication with engineering teams and customers, dedicating time to read, experiment with new technologies, and prioritize initiatives that keep one engaged with hands-on development aspects.

6.Question

What key factors does Damian believe are necessary for reaching a Principal Engineer position?

Answer:Damian highlights preparation for opportunities, proactive learning, mentorship, and being open to taking on challenges as pivotal in advancing to a Principal Engineer

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

role.

7.Question

Why is it important for staff-plus engineers to document their thoughts and strategies according to Damian?

Answer:Documentation helps scale their influence, ensuring that others can access the information and ideas shared, reducing the likelihood of misunderstandings, and allowing for more effective communication across teams.

8.Question

How did Damian navigate his promotion from Director of Engineering to Principal Engineer?

Answer:After several conversations about his aspirations for broader influence across the company, Damian transitioned to focus on technical leadership, emphasizing his desire for growth opportunities that involved larger organizational impact.

9.Question

What relationship does Damian see between technical skills and effective communication in leadership roles?

Answer:Damian believes that while technical knowledge is

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

essential, effective communication is equally critical for influencing teams and ensuring collaborative success. Being able to present ideas clearly can lead to better strategic outcomes.

10.Question

What are some resources that Damian found helpful in his journey as an engineer?

Answer:Damian recommends following influential people in tech, reading books that delve into software architecture and management practices, and learning from experienced managers to build both technical and leadership skills.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Why Bookey is must have App for Book Lovers

30min Content
The deeper and clearer interpretation we provide, the better grasp of each title you have.

Text and Audio format
Absorb knowledge even in fragmented time.

Quiz
Check whether you have mastered what you just learned.

And more
Multiple Voices & fonts, Mind Map, Quotes, IdeaClips...

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 37 | Stephen Wan - Staff Engineer at Samsara| Q&A

1.Question

What is the primary role of a Staff Engineer at Stripe?

Answer:A Staff Engineer at Stripe serves as a level that corresponds to impact, communication, people skills, and project leadership, rather than a defined role. They can fill various roles, with the emphasis on broad influence and fulfilling strategic functions in the organization.

2.Question

How does a Staff Engineer balance coding and leadership responsibilities?

Answer:A Staff Engineer like Dmitry balances coding and leadership by designating specific days for meetings and working groups with others while reserving days for personal coding to maintain a strong connection to engineering work.

3.Question

What types of projects constitute a meaningful impact for a Staff Engineer?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:Impactful projects might include enhancing proposals for new initiatives by introducing proper structure or influencing a proposal to better address business needs, showcasing how a Staff Engineer can empower others.

4.Question

How does sponsorship relate to being a Staff Engineer?

Answer:While sponsorship isn't a required duty, it significantly contributes to a Staff Engineer's success by creating opportunities for others, fostering their growth, and enabling them to take on impactful projects.

5.Question

What advice does Dmitry give to someone new to the Staff Engineer role?

Answer:It’s essential to align with management on expected impact and compromises on achieving that impact, as well as to communicate transparently about those compromises.

6.Question

How does one achieve the Staff Engineer title at Stripe?

Answer:Promotion to Staff Engineer typically involves two upleveling opportunities where an employee is evaluated

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

based on their sustained operation at a higher level and the impact they have on the organization.

7.Question

What was a key project Dmitry attributes to his attaining the Staff Engineer title?

Answer:Dmitry cites the development of Sorbet, a type checker for Ruby, as a significant project that showcased his capabilities and contributed to his promotion.

8.Question

What is an important aspect of being effective in a Technical Advisor role?

Answer:As a Technical Advisor, one must possess strong insights and deep engineering understanding, which can be maintained through active engagement with internal customers and staying informed about systems and their performance.

9.Question

How does Dmitry use feedback to improve in his role?

Answer:Dmitry actively seeks feedback after meetings to learn about his impact and adjust his communication style,

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

which helps him improve his effectiveness in collaborative environments.

10.Question

What resources does Stephen, a Staff Engineer at Samsara, recommend for professional growth?

Answer:Stephen encourages reading literature explaining complex topics simply, participating in feedback loops within the organization and consulting knowledgeable colleagues for mentorship.

Chapter 38 | Additional resources on Staff-plus engineering| Q&A

1.Question

What is the most valuable resource for Staff-plus engineers according to the text?

Answer:The most valuable resource for Staff-plus engineers is their network of peers and mentors, rather than books or articles.

2.Question

What should you prioritize if you only have one hour to develop yourself as an engineer?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:You should prioritize building a network of people in similar roles, as it can significantly enhance your growth and learning.

3.Question

Can you provide examples of recommended books that have been influential for Staff engineers?

Answer:Some influential books for Staff engineers include 'A Philosophy of Software Design' by John Ousterhout, 'Accelerate' by Forsgren, Humble, and Kim, and 'High Output Management' by Andy Grove.

4.Question

What is one of the best sources for finding high-quality computer science papers to read?

Answer:One of the best sources for high-quality computer science papers is 'Papers We Love,' which also hosts meetups to discuss notable papers.

5.Question

Why do most Staff-plus engineers value giving talks more than listening to them?

Answer:Most Staff-plus engineers have mentioned that

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

giving talks allows them to solidify their understanding of the material and share knowledge actively, making it a more valuable experience compared to simply listening.

6.Question

What is a recommended first step for those aspiring to read more academic papers?

Answer:A recommended first step is to read 'How to Read an Academic Article' by Peter Klein, which provides guidance on engaging with academic literature effectively.

7.Question

How can one build a powerful network of colleagues?

Answer:Building a powerful network involves actively engaging with peers in similar roles, participating in communities such as #staff-principal-engineering in Slack, and seeking mentorship opportunities.

8.Question

What are 'Technical Decision Making' and 'Engineering Strategy' about?

Answer:'Technical Decision Making' focuses on how to make effective and aligned technical choices within an

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

organization, while 'Engineering Strategy' deals with creating a vision and framework for effective innovation and operational excellence.

9.Question

What can be concluded about the approach to learning in engineering as suggested in this chapter?

Answer:The approach to learning in engineering emphasizes the importance of community, mentorship, and shared experiences over solitary study, highlighting that collaboration and network-building are crucial for professional growth.

Chapter 39 | Where do Staff-plus engineers fit into the org?| Q&A

1.Question

What is one of the most valuable resources for Staff-plus engineers according to the text?

Answer:Their network of peers and mentors.

2.Question

If you only have one hour to develop yourself as an engineer, what should you focus on?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:Building a network of people in similar roles.

3.Question

Which Slack community is mentioned as a lively place for discussions on Staff-plus engineering?

Answer:#staff-principal-engineering in the Rands Leadership Slack.

4.Question

Why do most Staff engineers suggest giving talks is more valuable than listening?

Answer:Giving talks helps to solidify their understanding and expertise, through the process of sharing knowledge.

5.Question

What does the 'Office of the CTO' typically involve?

Answer:It involves a small group of Staff-plus engineers who report directly to the CTO and tackle important problems with minimal management support.

6.Question

What should you do if you find yourself reporting to the wrong manager?

Answer:Consider having a conversation with your manager

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

about the reporting structure, but be aware that many managers may react defensively.

7.Question

How should reporting structure changes be managed according to the text?

Answer:Reporting changes should happen immediately when possible, as delaying creates complex transitions that can complicate roles.

8.Question

What is the key takeaway about networking for Staff-plus engineers?

Answer:Networking is essential; it often leads to the most significant personal and professional development rather than relying solely on theoretical knowledge or resources.

9.Question

How do Staff-plus engineers generally feel about formal training versus informal learning?

Answer:They often value informal learning through mentorship and peer discussions more than formal training or structured courses.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

10.Question

What are foundational papers important for?

Answer:Foundational papers provide essential exposure to key concepts and designs that underpin much of modern engineering practices.

11.Question

What is an important consideration when discussing changes to your organization's structure?

Answer:Before advocating for change, consider what differences you expect to achieve with a new reporting structure.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

App Store
Editors' Choice

22k 5 star review

Positive feedback

Sara Scholz

tes after each book summary
erstanding but also make the
and engaging. Bookey has
ding for me.

Fantastic!!!

Masood El Toure

I'm amazed by the variety of books and languages Bookey supports. It's not just an app, it's a gateway to global knowledge. Plus, earning points for charity is a big plus!

Fi
Ab
bo
to
my

José Botín

ding habit
p's design
ual growth

Love it!

Wonnie Tappkx

Bookey offers me time to go through the important parts of a book. It also gives me enough idea whether or not I should purchase the whole book version or not! It is easy to use!

Time saver!

Bookey is my go-to app for
summaries are concise, ins
curated. It's like having acc
right at my fingertips!

Awesome app!

Rahul Malviya

I love audiobooks but don't always have time to listen to the entire book! bookey allows me to get a summary of the highlights of the book I'm interested in!!! What a great concept !!!highly recommended!

Beautiful App

Alex Walk

This app is a lifesaver for book lovers with busy schedules. The summaries are spot on, and the mind maps help reinforce wh I've learned. Highly recommend!

Free Trial with Bookey

Chapter 40 | Managing Staff-plus engineers| Q&A

1.Question

How should organizations structure the reporting of Staff-plus engineers?

Answer:Organizations should consider placing Staff-plus engineers in roles that maximize their access to information and authority. Instead of strictly adhering to organizational mathematics, it's beneficial for senior engineers to report to more senior leaders or managers to better support their decision-making and leadership roles. This design aids in their growth and effectiveness in guiding technical initiatives.

2.Question

What is the significance of feedback for Staff-plus engineers?

Answer:Frequent and constructive feedback is crucial for Staff-plus engineers to recalibrate their understanding of success in their roles. As they step into leadership positions,

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

their definition of success may shift from immediate tasks to long-term strategic goals. Regularly providing feedback helps them stay aligned with expectations and fosters their development.

3.Question

Why is it important to minimize manager overflow for Staff-plus engineers?

Answer:Minimizing manager overflow is essential to maintain the effectiveness and focus of Staff-plus engineers. When managers are overwhelmed with administrative tasks and coordination, they may unintentionally pass these burdens onto their Staff-plus engineers, which can detract from the engineers' ability to contribute at a high level and engage effectively in problem-solving.

4.Question

What should managers do when they realize they have appointed the wrong manager for a Staff-plus engineer?

Answer:Having an honest discussion with the manager about the misalignment is warranted, especially if there is a mature

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

relationship. However, if the relationship is less strong, it may be wise to address the structure more generally with higher-ups to avoid defensiveness.

5.Question

How can managers support the transition from Senior to Staff-plus roles?

Answer:Managers should proactively help Staff-plus engineers understand and navigate the significant change in role expectations. This includes providing mentoring, establishing clear timelines for changes in reporting structures, and recognizing that many may struggle to adapt to their new responsibilities. Supporting them through this transition is vital for their success.

6.Question

What should managers be aware of to enhance the effectiveness of Staff-plus engineers?

Answer:Managers should recognize the importance of aligning the work of Staff-plus engineers with business goals, support them in developing leadership skills, provide space

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

for independent thinking, and communicate crucial information. By fostering their autonomy while ensuring they remain connected to the organization's needs, managers can help these engineers thrive.

7.Question

How can Staff-plus engineers develop a positive organizational culture?

Answer:By embodying and promoting positive values, Staff-plus engineers can set a powerful example for their peers. Their behaviors and actions influence broader organizational norms, and their leadership can create an environment that rewards collaboration, integrity, and excellence.

8.Question

What strategy can managers use to involve Staff-plus engineers in planning and prioritization?

Answer:Proactively involving Staff-plus engineers in the planning process not only helps them understand the context of competing needs but also empowers them to advocate

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

effectively for technical initiatives they identify as critical. This inclusion helps boost motivation and align the team with cohesive goals.

9.Question

How should managers ensure alignment with business priorities for Staff-plus engineers?

Answer:It's crucial for managers to regularly communicate and emphasize the importance of aligning technical work with business needs to Staff-plus engineers. This reduces the risks associated with isolated technical focuses and helps maintain organizational coherence, ensuring that engineers contribute to the overall objectives of the company.

10.Question

What role does sponsorship play in managing Staff-plus engineers?

Answer:Sponsorship is vital for Staff-plus engineers to successfully navigate their responsibilities and initiatives. Managers should advocate for their engineers, support their projects, and create opportunities for visibility and

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

engagement within the organization, fostering an environment in which they feel empowered to take on leadership roles.

Chapter 41 | Designing a Staff-plus interview loop| Q&A

1.Question

What are the key differences between managing a Staff-plus engineer and a Senior engineer?

Answer:Managing a Staff-plus engineer differs from managing a Senior engineer primarily in the nature of their responsibilities and the level of independence expected. Staff-plus engineers take on more complex, long-term strategic work that often involves navigating through conflict and managing broader priorities. In contrast, Senior engineers may focus more on immediate tasks and technical execution. As a manager, you should sponsor and support Staff-plus engineers rather than micromanaging them, recognizing their need for autonomy and deeper strategic thinking.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

2.Question

How should feedback be given to Staff-plus engineers?

Answer:Feedback for Staff-plus engineers should be frequent, constructive, and clear. It's crucial to inform them about their performance, especially regarding key decisions and priorities. This regular feedback helps them understand their direction and reduces stress that comes from uncertainty. For instance, if they are prioritizing work in a way that diverges from the team's goals, providing timely feedback can help them align more effectively.

3.Question

What role do Staff-plus engineers play as role models in an organization?

Answer:Staff-plus engineers carry a significant responsibility as role models within an organization. Their actions, decisions, and behaviors inform others about what is acceptable and rewarded in the workplace. By embodying positive values and demonstrating effective leadership, they can shape the culture and influence the behaviors of both

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

junior engineers and their peers throughout the organization.

4.Question

Why is it important to involve Staff-plus engineers in planning and prioritization?

Answer:Involving Staff-plus engineers in planning and prioritization is vital as it helps them understand the broader context of the work while advocating for important technical initiatives. This inclusion allows them to see the competing demands faced by the organization and enables them to contribute effectively, ensuring that the right work gets prioritized.

5.Question

What impact can neglecting Staff-plus engineers have on an organization?

Answer:Neglecting Staff-plus engineers can lead to a lack of engagement, decreased morale, and ultimately hinder the organization's success. Without adequate support and recognition, these key engineers may feel undervalued, leading to a culture where critical initiatives may stall. They

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

are crucial for driving innovation and maintaining quality, so their well-being and engagement directly impact the organization's performance.

6.Question

How can a manager create space for Staff-plus engineers to think deeply?

Answer:A manager can create space for Staff-plus engineers to think deeply by protecting their time from distractions and urgent issues. This might involve delegating certain responsibilities or putting structures in place that allow them to focus on strategic thinking rather than being immersed solely in day-to-day firefighting. Managers should also encourage them to allocate time for deep, reflective work without detaching from team dynamics.

7.Question

What is one common mistake companies make when designing interview loops for Staff-plus engineers?

Answer:A common mistake is treating them like Senior engineers who just perform slightly better, focusing on faster

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

problem-solving rather than the unique leadership and strategic skills required at the Staff-plus level. This can dilute the effectiveness of the hiring process, leading to candidates who fit a mold rather than those who truly excel in influencing broader organizational strategies.

8.Question

What role does self-awareness play in the effectiveness of a Staff-plus engineer?

Answer:Self-awareness is crucial for the effectiveness of Staff-plus engineers as it drives accountability and fosters growth. Engineers who can recognize their strengths and areas for improvement are more likely to navigate complex challenges successfully, drive projects forward, and help develop their peers. This trait allows them to engage in self-reflection, ultimately increasing their impact within the team.

Chapter 42 | Staff-plus career ladders| Q&A

1.Question

What are common pitfalls to avoid when designing a Staff-plus engineer interview loop?

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Answer:One common pitfall is conflating the roles of Senior and Staff-plus engineers—many interview processes mistakenly seek a Senior engineer who is just slightly better at everything, failing to recognize that Staff-plus engineers often have different responsibilities that emphasize strategic thinking over rapid execution of tasks. Another pitfall is focusing too heavily on cultural fit, leading to decisions based on bias rather than capability. Lastly, interviews may be structured around outdated perceptions—like expecting the candidate to be a quick programmer, which can lead to overlooking their potential for impact in broader organizational contexts.

2.Question

What key signals should be assessed in a Staff-plus engineer interview loop?

Answer:Key signals to look for include self-awareness, such as accountability for mistakes and evidence of personal

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

growth; judgment, which encompasses problem identification and mediation skills; collaboration, particularly how candidates work with others of varied experience levels; communication proficiency, both in listening and conveying ideas; and development of others around them, indicating their ability to strengthen the team.

3.Question

How can interview formats be adapted to better assess a candidate's qualifications for a Staff-plus role?

Answer:Incorporating structured presentations allows candidates to exhibit their structured thinking and communication skills. Code reviews can be used to gauge empathy and clarity in feedback. Additionally, allowing candidates to walk through system designs helps evaluate their capability to adapt and respond to changing requirements. Moreover, mentor panels can showcase how candidates would engage with and develop less experienced team members.

4.Question

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Why is it important to distinguish between technical skills and other competencies for Staff-plus candidates?

Answer:While domain expertise is critical, it is often the combination of technical skills with competencies like leadership, communication, and problem-solving abilities that drives significant impact. Staff-plus engineers must navigate complex organizational dynamics, justify decisions, and mentor others, requiring a skill set that extends beyond mere technical prowess.

5.Question

What advice is crucial for organizations when designing their Staff-plus interview loops?

Answer:Organizations should focus on the specific signals relevant to their needs and ensure that the interview formats facilitate an accurate demonstration of these signals. Continuous testing and iteration of the interview process based on candidate feedback and evolving company goals are crucial for developing a robust and effective evaluation system.

More Free Book

Scan to Download

Listen It

Ad

Scan to Download

Read, Share, Empower

Finish Your Reading Challenge, Donate Books to African Children.

The Concept

BOOKS FOR AFRICA × ×

This book donation activity is rolling out together with Books For Africa. We release this project because we share the same belief as BFA: For many children in Africa, the gift of books truly is a gift of hope.

The Rule

Earn 100 points → **Redeem a book** → **Donate to Africa**

Your learning not only brings knowledge but also allows you to earn points for charitable causes! For every 100 points you earn, a book will be donated to Africa.

Free Trial with Bookey

Staff Engineer Quiz and Test

Check the Correct Answer on Bookey Website

Chapter 1 | Acknowledgments| Quiz and Test

1. The author of 'Staff Engineer' is Will Larson.
2. The book 'Staff Engineer' was written with minimal collaboration and input from others.
3. The cover design of 'Staff Engineer' was inspired by historical nautical maps.

Chapter 2 | Foreword| Quiz and Test

1. Will Larson expresses gratitude to various individuals and communities for their contributions during the year 2020 in the acknowledgments of his book.
2. Tanya Reilly believes that resources available for senior engineers are extensive and sufficient compared to management literature.
3. The term 'staff-plus' was introduced to clarify undefined roles in the tech industry for engineers.

Chapter 3 | Preface| Quiz and Test

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

1. The book 'Staff Engineer' addresses the needs of staff-plus engineers.
2. Tanya Reilly believes that principal engineers find managerial perspectives helpful and relatable.
3. Will Larson's intention in writing 'Staff Engineer' is to create confusion around the role of staff engineers.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

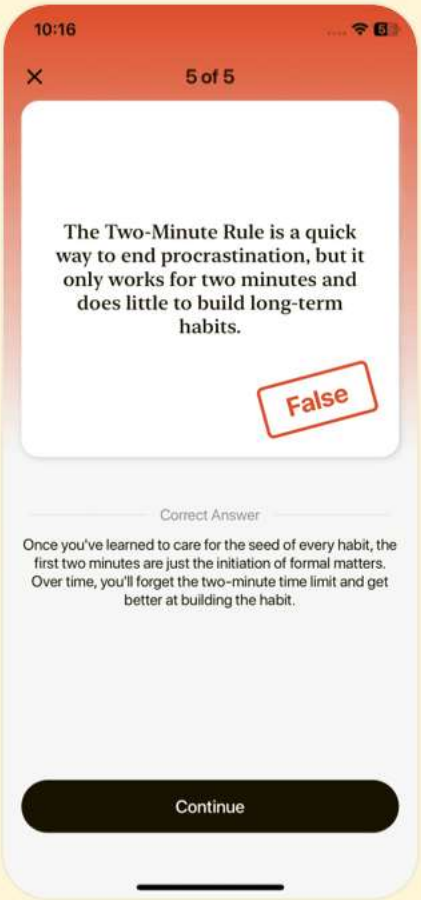
Download Bookey App to enjoy

1000+ Book Summaries with Quizzes

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 4 | Staff engineer archetypes| Quiz and Test

1. In most technology companies, it typically takes four to six years for software engineers to reach the Senior level.
2. The Tech Lead archetype is generally considered the least common among Staff-plus engineers.
3. Staff Engineer roles are only available in large organizations with complex codebases.

Chapter 5 | What do Staff engineers actually do?| Quiz and Test

1. Staff engineers primarily focus on coding rather than mentoring.
2. The Tech Lead archetype focuses on guiding execution and partnerships within a team.
3. Staff engineers work on projects that are not aligned with the organization's goals.

Chapter 6 | Does the title even matter?| Quiz and Test

1. The primary focus of Staff engineers is on projects of strategic value while enhancing technical design

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

and team performance.

2. Staff engineers have the same level of coding responsibilities as Senior engineers since they perform similar tasks.
3. Acquiring a Staff-plus title automatically grants new abilities and solves workplace problems.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

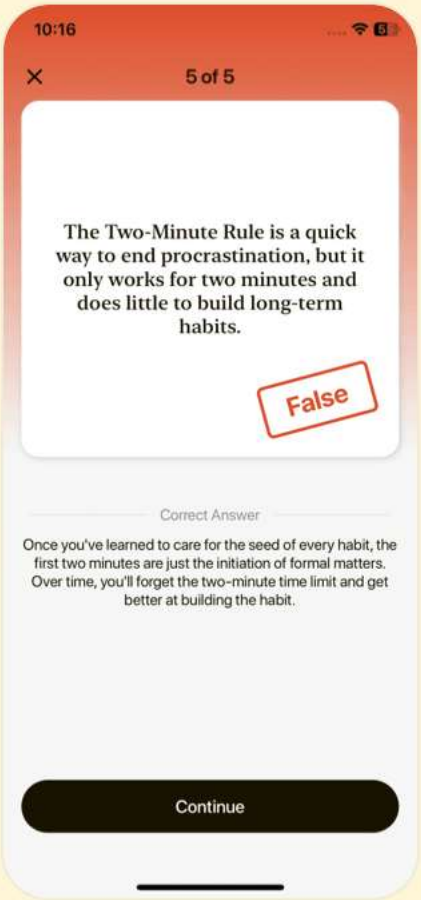
Download Bookey App to enjoy

1000+ Book Summaries with Quizzes

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 7 | Work on what matters| Quiz and Test

1. Becoming a Staff engineer grants complete control and authority over work responsibilities.
2. Empowering your team to grow is an important aspect of being a Staff engineer.
3. In the long run, measures like reputation and accumulated expertise are more important than individual project contributions for career success.

Chapter 8 | Writing engineering strategy| Quiz and Test

1. The concept of 'energized' work suggests prioritizing fulfilling activities over those deemed essential by the company.
2. It's beneficial to engage in low-effort tasks to feel a quick sense of accomplishment, even if they detract from high-impact work.
3. Fostering growth by mentoring team members has no significant impact on team dynamics and personal contributions.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 9 | Managing technical quality| Quiz and Test

1. Writing an effective engineering strategy is often more complex than writing a poor one.
2. To create an effective engineering strategy, one should avoid analyzing design documents as they complicate the process.
3. It's essential to implement many quality improvement techniques at once to ensure effective results.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

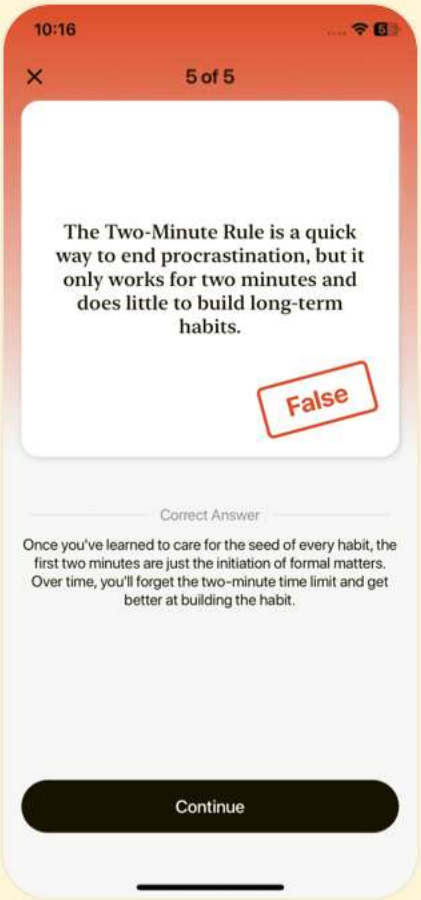
Download Bookey App to enjoy

1000+ Book Summaries with Quizzes

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 10 | Stay aligned with authority| Quiz and Test

1. Engineers, managers, and executives believe that the crisis in technical quality is mainly caused by personnel issues instead of organizational decisions.
2. Establishing clear metrics for technical quality is essential for identifying gaps and assessing changes over time.
3. Organizations should implement extensive best practices before addressing quality hot spots.

Chapter 11 | To lead, you have to follow| Quiz and Test

1. In a Staff-plus role, it is important to operate as a proxy for your direct manager by understanding their worldview deeply.
2. In leadership positions, one should rely on support and guidance from their team rather than setting success parameters for the team and company.
3. Effective leaders should always prioritize their perspectives over those of senior leaders to ensure their values are

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

advocated.

Chapter 12 | Learn to never be wrong| Quiz and Test

1. Leadership is mainly about managing tasks and projects effectively rather than understanding broader strategies.
2. Successful leaders spend more time leading than following and prioritize hierarchy in their teams.
3. Every interaction, including meetings and discussions, can serve as an opportunity to practice leadership skills.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

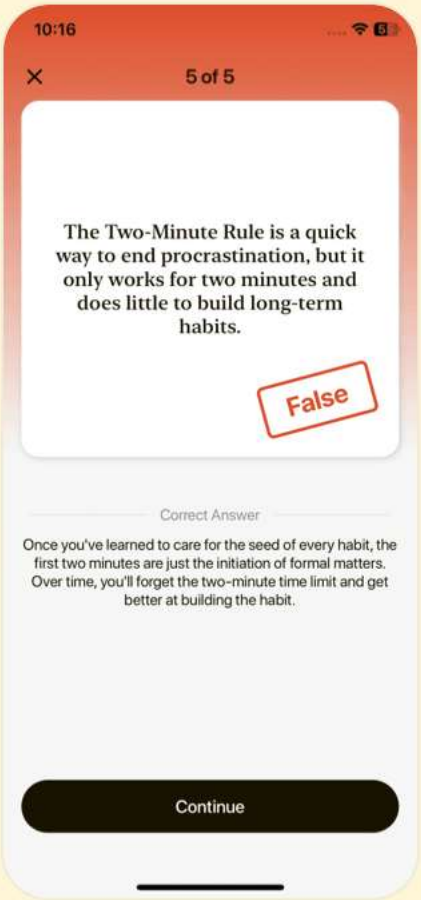
Download Bookey App to enjoy

1000+ Book Summaries with Quizzes

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 13 | Create space for others| Quiz and Test

1. Effective leaders should aim to create space for others to express their viewpoints and guide discussions toward productive outcomes.
2. Leaders should prioritize being right over creating a collaborative environment.
3. Documentation of thought processes and decisions is essential for transparency and learning within a team.

Chapter 14 | Build a network of peers| Quiz and Test

1. Empowering others is more important than making decisions for them as a staff engineer.
2. Building a large network of superficial connections is more beneficial than having a few genuine relationships.
3. Creating ambient networks is suggested for those who find traditional networking uncomfortable.

Chapter 15 | Present to executives| Quiz and Test

1. Building a personal network of peers is essential for advancing in a Staff-plus engineering career.
2. Quality of connections is less important than the number of

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

connections made in professional networking.

3. Understanding the technical details is the most important aspect when communicating with executives.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

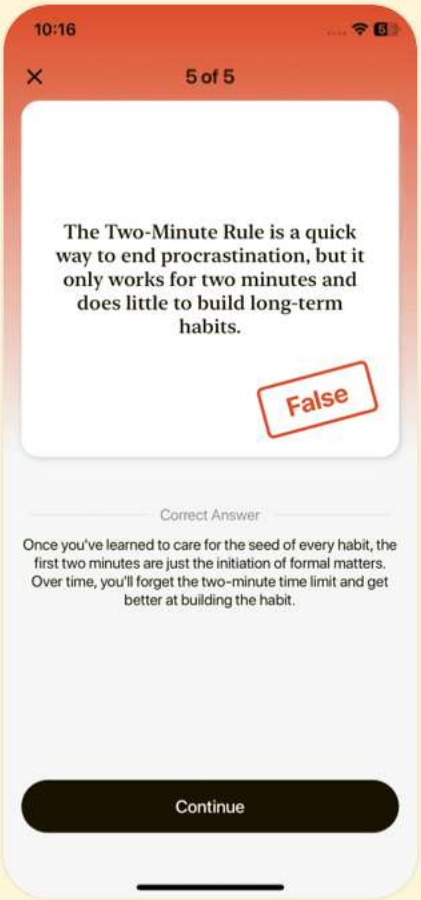
Download Bookey App to enjoy

1000+ Book Summaries with Quizzes

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 16 | Promotion packets| Quiz and Test

1. The transition to Staff Engineer often relies solely on personal effort without any influence from company culture or timing.
2. Engaging in high-leverage projects and visibility within the organization is crucial for promotion to Staff Engineer.
3. Management roles are commonly pursued by all Staff Engineers for the sake of personal advancement.

Chapter 17 | Find your sponsor| Quiz and Test

1. Promotion packets should only be created after you feel ready for promotion.
2. Having an organizational sponsor is important for achieving a promotion.
3. Engaging with your manager is not necessary during the promotion packet process.

Chapter 18 | Staff projects| Quiz and Test

1. Finding a sponsor is crucial for advancing to a Staff-plus role.
2. Your direct manager is typically the only person who can

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

sponsor you for promotion.

3. Completing a Staff project is always a requirement for promotion to a Staff position.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

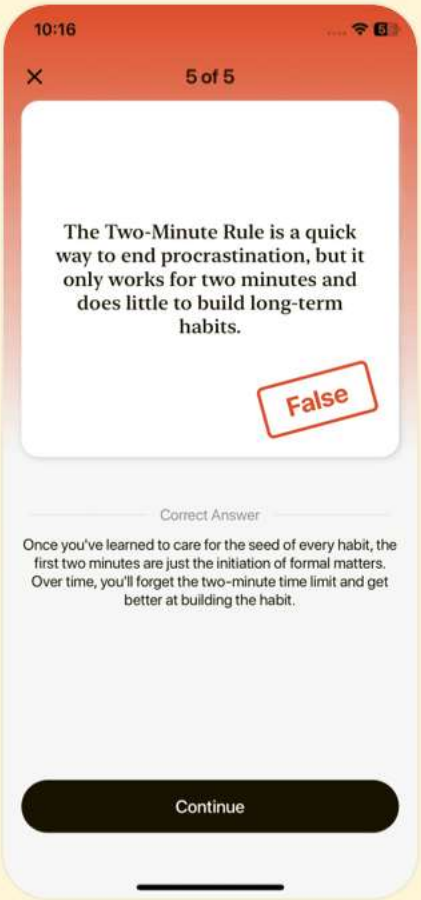
Download Bookey App to enjoy

1000+ Book Summaries with Quizzes

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 19 | Get in the room, and stay there| Quiz and Test

1. Completing a Staff Project is necessary for all engineers to be promoted to Staff Engineer positions.
2. Most companies require Staff Projects for promotions to Staff Engineer positions.
3. Engaging in a Staff Project can lead to significant personal and professional growth, even if it is not required for promotion.

Chapter 20 | Being visible| Quiz and Test

1. Staff-plus engineers often cite their absence from decision-making processes as a significant advantage of their roles.
2. To stay in the room, engineers must actively engage in discussions and provide valuable insights.
3. Having an external presence is mandatory for promotion within an organization.

Chapter 21 | Finding the right company| Quiz and

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Test

1. Keavy McMinn's decision to switch companies led to him obtaining the title of Principal Engineer at Fastly.
2. In technology, job changes are infrequent compared to other traditional fields like academia.
3. Achieving a Staff-plus title often requires finding an internal sponsor who believes in the candidate.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

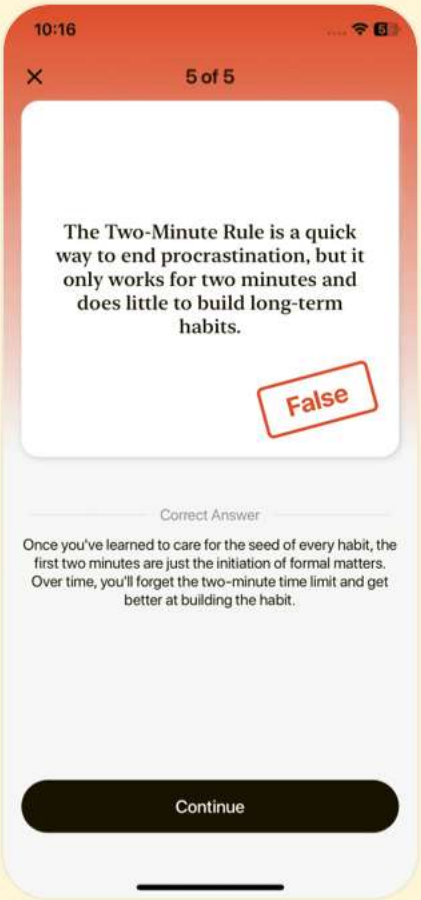
Download Bookey App to enjoy

1000+ Book Summaries with Quizzes

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 22 | Interviewing for Staff-plus roles| Quiz and Test

1. There are two main paths to achieve a Staff-plus role: negotiate for the title during a job switch or develop credibility in a supportive environment with a sponsor.
2. Meritocratic companies prioritize consistency and fairness over exceptional talent.
3. Establishing connections and networking is unimportant in finding a sponsor within a company.

Chapter 23 | Negotiating your offer| Quiz and Test

1. Clarity around the interview process for Staff-plus roles is often well-defined and similar to Senior Engineer interviews.
2. It's important to negotiate not only salary but also other aspects like equity and vacation days during the offer stage.
3. Following through with references and formalities after the interview process has no impact on professional relationships.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 24 | Michelle Bu - Payments Products Tech Lead at Stripe| Quiz and Test

1. Michelle Bu feels that her role as a Staff Engineer is energizing and she no longer feels merely impactful.
2. Most Staff-plus engineers at Stripe exclusively focus on a single domain without collaborating on multiple projects.
3. Michelle believes that advocating for specific technologies is more important than empowering engineering teams to feel ownership of their work.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

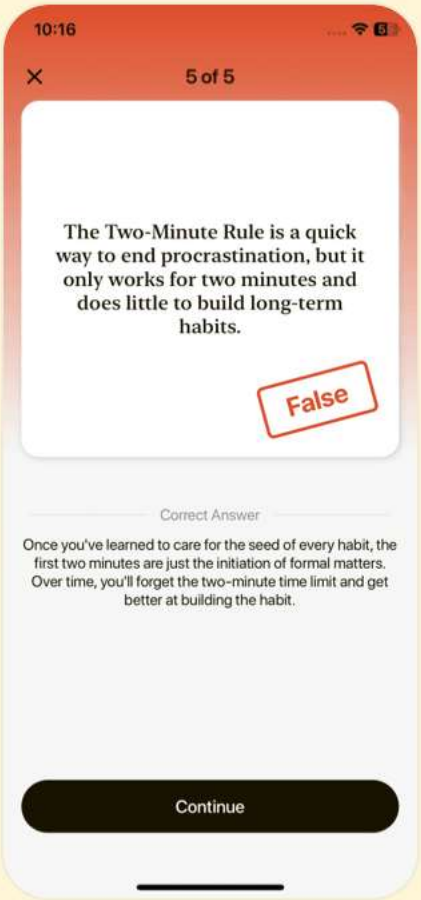
Download Bookey App to enjoy

1000+ Book Summaries with Quizzes

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 25 | Ras Kasa Williams - Staff Engineer at Mailchimp| Quiz and Test

1. Michelle Bu is the sole Tech Lead at Stripe, focusing solely on API design.
2. Staff-plus Engineers at Stripe are expected to engage in either deep or broad technical scopes.
3. Michelle's approach to career progression emphasizes individual accolades over teamwork.

Chapter 26 | Keavy McMinn - Senior Principal Engineer at Fastly| Quiz and Test

1. Ras Kasa Williams is currently a Staff Engineer at Mailchimp and works exclusively on software development with no managerial responsibilities.
2. At Mailchimp, the role of a Staff Engineer requires aligning with the company's product and technical strategies.
3. Kasa believes that titles have no impact on agency, visibility, and mentorship opportunities in an engineering context.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 27 | Bert Fan - Senior Staff Engineer at Slack| Quiz and Test

1. Keavy McMinn is a Senior Principal Engineer at Fastly, serving as the API Lead.
2. Staff-plus engineers at Fastly have limited autonomy and must strictly follow directives for project selection.
3. Keavy emphasizes the importance of creating design documents for API changes after coding begins.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

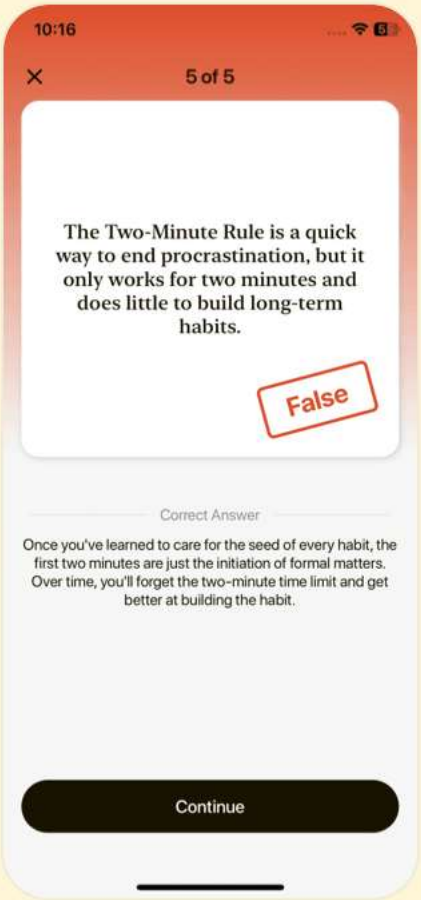
Download Bookey App to enjoy

1000+ Book Summaries with Quizzes

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 28 | Katie Sylor-Miller - Frontend Architect at Etsy| Quiz and Test

1. Bert Fan is a Senior Staff Engineer who focuses primarily on specific implementations of technology at Slack.
2. Regular one-on-ones with engineers help Bert maintain open communication and understand the state of engineering at Slack.
3. Bert believes that networking is not essential for maintaining connections with engineers and career progression.

Chapter 29 | Ritu Vincent - Staff Engineer at Dropbox| Quiz and Test

1. Katie Sylor-Miller serves as a Frontend Architect at Etsy, focusing on web performance and monitoring systems.
2. Katie believes that the role of a Staff Engineer only involves coding and technical skills without the need for interpersonal skills.
3. Katie emphasizes the importance of networking and

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

mentoring junior engineers as part of her responsibilities at Etsy.

Chapter 30 | Rick Boone - Strategic Advisor to Uber’s VP of Infrastructure| Quiz and Test

1. Ritu Vincent manages an incubator at Dropbox that is solely focused on project management.
2. There are two types of Staff Engineers at Dropbox: Tech Leads and Specialists.
3. Ritu’s promotion to Staff Engineer had nothing to do with her visibility in the company.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

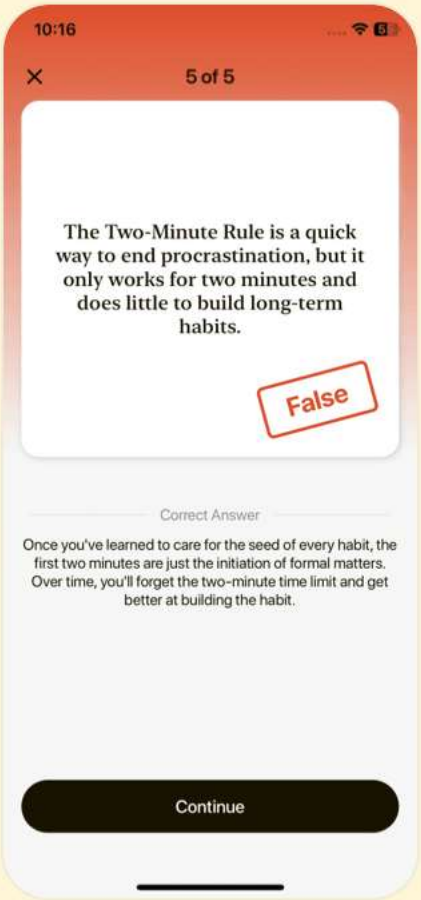
Download Bookey App to enjoy

1000+ Book Summaries with Quizzes

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 31 | Nelson Elhage - Formerly Staff Engineer at Stripe| Quiz and Test

1. Rick Boone's role as Strategic Advisor at Uber emphasizes operational aspects over strategic insights.
2. Rick Boone actively mentors engineers, particularly minorities, and holds regular sessions to support new hires.
3. Rick advises aspiring Staff Engineers to prioritize technical skills over building relationships with leadership.

Chapter 32 | Diana Pojar - Staff Data Engineer at Slack| Quiz and Test

1. Nelson Elhage worked on a team focused on improving payment processing at Stripe.
2. Staff-plus Engineers at Stripe primarily focus on minor technical projects that do not impact the organization significantly.
3. Nelson believes that focusing on many small projects is more beneficial than prioritizing impact for future Staff Engineers.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Chapter 33 | Dan Na - Staff Engineer and Team Lead at Squarespace| Quiz and Test

1. Diana Pojar believes that sponsorship is crucial for the growth of engineers.
2. Dan Na spends most of his day coding rather than engaging in strategic discussions.
3. Both Diana and Dan demonstrate that Staff Engineers balance technical expertise with mentorship and strategic influence.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

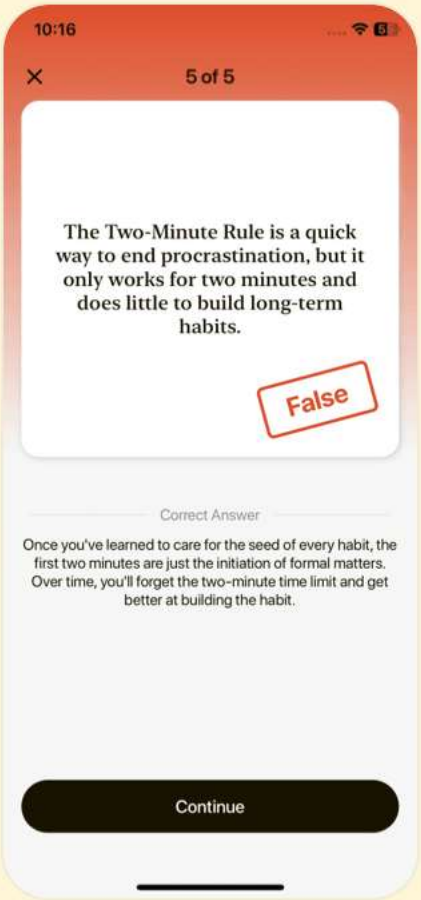
Download Bookey App to enjoy

1000+ Book Summaries with Quizzes

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 34 | Joy Ebertz - Senior Staff Software Engineer at Split| Quiz and Test

1. Dan Na is the only Staff Engineer at Squarespace responsible for the overall engineering output.
2. Staff-plus engineers at Squarespace focus primarily on hands-on coding tasks and technical contributions.
3. Dan Na believes that sponsoring others is important for growth within an engineering team.

Chapter 35 | Damian Schenkelman - Principal Engineer at Auth0| Quiz and Test

1. Joy Ebertz is a Senior Staff Software Engineer at Split.io focusing on backend development.
2. Joy Ebertz believes that sponsoring the growth of other engineers is not important for career advancement.
3. Ebertz found that her management experience was not helpful in understanding organizational dynamics.

Chapter 36 | Dmitry Petrashko - Tech Advisor to the Head of Infra at Stripe| Quiz and Test

1. Damian Schenkelman serves as a tech lead for a major product feature in Identity and Access

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Management (IAM) at Auth0.

2. At Auth0, Principal Engineers like Schenkelman typically lead teams in a specific domain, contributing to various initiatives.
3. Sponsoring other engineers is an unimportant aspect of Schenkelman's role as a Principal Engineer.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

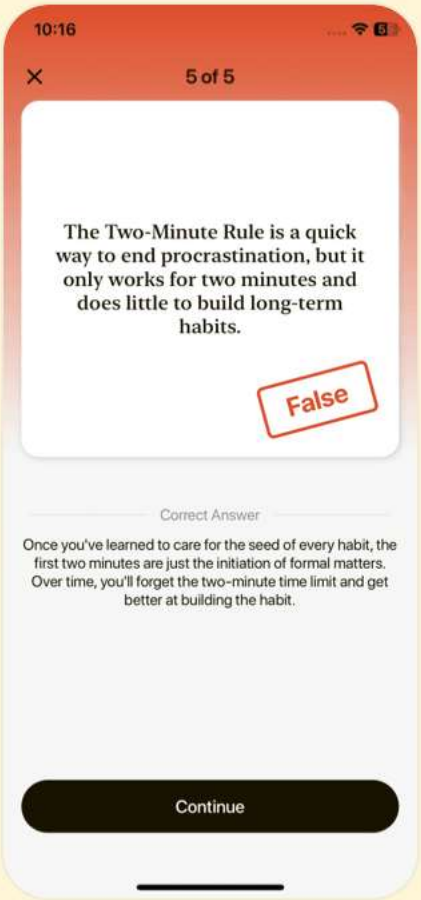
Download Bookey App to enjoy

1000+ Book Summaries with Quizzes

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 37 | Stephen Wan - Staff Engineer at Samsara| Quiz and Test

1. Dmitry Petrashko's primary role at Stripe involves making direct technical decisions for the engineering teams.
2. Dmitry emphasizes the importance of balancing coding practices with business priorities in his day-to-day activities.
3. According to Dmitry, mentorship and sponsorship are seen as identical roles in empowering engineers at Stripe.

Chapter 38 | Additional resources on Staff-plus engineering| Quiz and Test

1. Staff Engineers find giving talks more beneficial than attending them.
2. Reading academic papers is essential for staff engineers as they help in professional development.
3. Networking is not considered important for the success of Staff Engineers according to the chapter.

Chapter 39 | Where do Staff-plus engineers fit into the org?| Quiz and Test

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

1. Staff-plus engineers believe that networking is an important resource for professional development.
2. All staff engineers read extensively and utilize a wide variety of books in their professional growth.
3. The concept of an "Office of the CTO" is ideal and established at the beginning of many organizations.

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

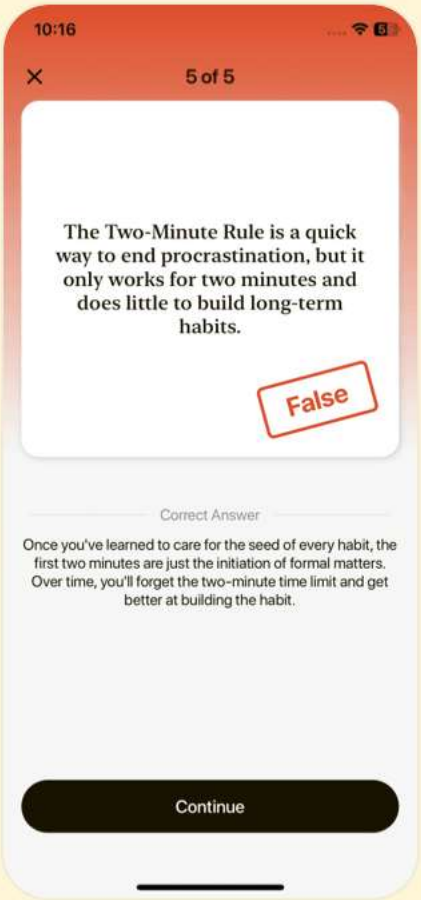
Download Bookey App to enjoy

1000+ Book Summaries with Quizzes

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play



Chapter 40 | Managing Staff-plus engineers| Quiz and Test

1. In designing engineering organizations, the ideal ratio is one manager per six to eight engineers.
2. Tech leads typically report to a senior manager only and not to a manager of managers.
3. Staff-plus engineers should be given autonomy and supported rather than being directed constantly by their managers.

Chapter 41 | Designing a Staff-plus interview loop| Quiz and Test

1. Effective management of Staff-plus engineers requires daily direction from their managers.
2. Consistent feedback is not vital for Staff-plus engineers in their growth development.
3. Participation in planning helps Staff-plus engineers understand the priorities and advocate for necessary technical work.

Chapter 42 | Staff-plus career ladders| Quiz and Test

1. Staff-plus engineers are simply enhanced Senior

More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

engineers with similar skill sets.

2. Structured presentations in interviews help evaluate a candidate's communication and structured thinking skills.
3. Interviewers should solely focus on a candidate's communication skills rather than their capacity for collaboration and problem-solving.

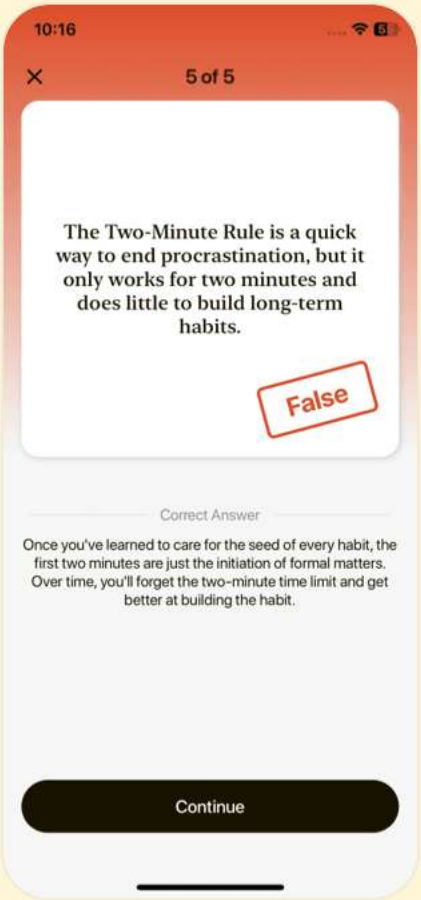
More Free Book
Scan to Download
Listen It

Scan to Download

Download Bookey App to enjoy

1000+ Book Summaries with Quizzes

Free Trial Available!

Download on the App Store

GET IT ON Google Play